

Rel 330 The Sermon on the Mount

Numbered Transcript

REL 330 • Dr. Jordan B. Peterson

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Lecture 1: Journey to Meaning

At a glance — Peterson frames the Sermon on the Mount — the longest continuous discourse of Christ — as a journey toward meaning.

- 1.1 The Sermon on the Mount is the longest continuous discourse attributed to Christ in the Gospels, and it's widely regarded as containing the central doctrines of Christian faith in, I suppose, the most condensed narrative sense. And a sermon is just a talk or a discussion, a dialogue in some sense, I suppose, as well. And the first question might be, well, why would it be on a mountain? And talking about that allows us to understand, to some degree, right, initially how complicated these things are.
- 1.2 Words and phrases and poetic titles make sense to us because they appeal to us at emotional, motivational, and an embodied level. And so you think, well, do you become enlightened in a valley, in a pit, or on a mountain? And the answer is, well, you become enlightened on a mountain, not in a valley. And why would that be? Well, you can't see in a valley, right? You're hemmed in. And so your vision is blocked by the surroundings. And it's dark in a valley compared to on a mountain, especially on a mountaintop, because—and you're closer to heaven on a mountaintop as well, in the symbolic sense, although you're also, in some sense, in the sky.
- 1.3 And the sky is up, and up is the place you aim, and up is where the heavenly bodies are, the sun and the moon and the stars. And we orient ourselves by the heavenly bodies, right? Because human beings are navigators, and we've learned to use the sky to, literally, to orient ourselves when we move from one place to another. And so part of the reason that a sermon that's enlightening is delivered on a mountain is because that makes sense to creatures like us.
- 1.4 And there's these old comic tropes of people climbing a mountain to see a guru who's perched on top, often in a lotus position, delivering wisdom. And that's also associated with the old Egyptian idea and the Mesopotamian idea of the eye of attention. And so you see in Egypt, there was a god, Horus, who was symbolized by the eye and also by the falcon. Falcons, by the way, are birds of prey, like eagles, raptors in general. And they're the only animals that have better vision than us. And so they've been used for a long time as a symbol of the capacity to see long distances from above and extraordinarily clearly. The falcon, of course, can fly above everything, as well as having great vision.
- 1.5 And if you remember The Lion King, the movie The Lion King, there was a little bird in there named Zazu. And Zazu was the eye of the king because he could fly above everything else and see. And that's an extremely interesting issue, too, because in the Mesopotamian creation myth, the god Marduk, who was their monotheistic god and a precursor of Christ in some sense, in that manner, he had eyes all the way around his head and he could speak magic words. So there's an idea there in Mesopotamia of the

doctrine of the word, the magic word that can bring things into reality, which is what we do with our words, for better or worse, and what we actually and truly do with them.

- 1.6 Because what you say changes your destiny, and it changes the destiny of people around you. And that's really worth thinking about, because you just have no idea how deep that truth goes and how much role you play in shaping the way the future transforms itself into the present and the past as a consequence of what you say. It's a core element of Christian doctrine that the word is the fundamental creative process that brings order into being out of chaos and potential, and you participate in that. That's partly why, in Genesis, in the first chapter, God uses the word that is true and oriented by love to bring about the habitable order that is good, and then makes the rather radical proposition that men and women are made in that image.
- 1.7 And so you can think about that in your own life. So the idea of love is that, despite its suffering and malevolence, the world is worth supporting and working to improve. And that's a real tough commitment, right? Because to the degree that your life is tragic and that it's contaminated by your malevolence and the malevolence of other people, it can make you bitter and resentful and destructive, and it can interfere with your desire to improve what's torturing and tormenting you, which also might be you. And so, part of the reason there's an emphasis in many religious traditions, and certainly in Christianity, on faith is because the evidence about the goodness of being is in some sense ambivalent, right?
- 1.8 I mean, you can tell that, not least because of the culture war that's tearing us apart right now, because the accusers, so to speak, say that the world's so corrupt, human beings are so corrupt, that we're best understood as nothing but the drive to malevolent power, in some sense. And it's a pretty powerful critique, because it's not like history isn't a complete catastrophe in many ways, and it's not as if we lack the capacity to make other people's lives miserable and our own—and also, I suppose, to some degree, pose a threat if we're not careful to the ecological integrity of the planet.
- 1.9 And so there's reasons to be unhappy about the conditions of existence, and part of the faith that is imposed on you, let's say, within the confines of the religious doctrines of Judaism and Christianity—not to say it isn't the case in other religious traditions—is that you should move forward as if you're benevolently predisposed to existence itself, to being itself. And that would be life, your life, other people's lives, life in general. But being as such, despite the fact that you're cursed with the burden of your mortal vulnerability. And that's no joke, right?
- 1.10 That's as heavy a burden, a moral burden, that can possibly be placed on people. And you have to accept it as a, as a presupposition of faith, because, as I said, at best the evidence is ambivalent. You know, women will think, "I shouldn't bring a child into a world such as this." And historians will look at events like Auschwitz and the Gulag Archipelagos and all the catastrophes of the 20th century and say, "Well, if history is

such a bloody nightmare, is it really something that we should propagate forward in time?" And these are very, these are very profound questions.

- 1.11 In Goethe's great play Faust, there's a demonic character, the devil himself, Mephistopheles. And Mephistopheles is the great adversary of being. And his credo is that life is so rife with suffering and malevolence that it would be better if consciousness didn't exist at all. So we're called upon, I would say, ethically and practically and philosophically and spiritually, to lift our eyes up to the heavens or to the hills. And there's another reason for that, too, which is that our primary problem in orienting ourselves in life is actually a navigation problem. It's not a perceptual or a conceptual problem.
- 1.12 It's how you get from point A to point B, because we're mobile creatures and we're always concerned with what we're going to do next and what we encounter along the way. And that means that we have to be aiming at something to move forward. Because why move forward if you're not aiming at something? Why would you move forward towards something you're aiming at, if you weren't aiming up? Because the place you're going to, if it's not better than the place you're at, why would you work to move there?
- 1.13 And so that idea of up is built into our conception, not only of progress forward, but it's also built into us psycho-physiologically and neuro-pharmacologically, because most of the positive emotion you experience—and this is worth knowing, man —is experienced in relationship to a goal. And so you might think you're happy because you attain things, but that's actually not why you're happy. You might be satisfied if you attain something, but it's fleeting because you attain it, and then the question is, well, now what, right? So when you graduate from high school, well, you've attained that graduation status. But the next day you wake up and you're no longer king of the high school, you're entry-level junior clerk at the local drugstore. Not that that's such a catastrophe, but you get my point. Being at the pinnacle isn't exactly the goal.
- 1.14 Now, what happens if you want to experience the positive emotion that can help sustain you through life and can also, what would you say? Well, fill you with enthusiasm, which means to be filled with God, by the way—"entheos" is to be filled with the spirit of God—is you have to be aiming at something worth aiming at. And then, and then, this is literally the case, the more vital the thing is that you're aiming for, the more positive emotion you experience when you notice that you're moving towards a goal. And so one of the things this means is that, if you don't have an aim, and even an ethical aim, because you're aiming up, right, you're aiming at something better—if you don't have an aim and an ethical aim, you literally cannot experience any positive emotion.
- 1.15 And more than that, the higher your aim—now that assumes that you're not making things impossibly difficult for yourself—but the higher your aim, the more intense the positive emotion associated with evidence of progress. And so then what you might

derive from that, if you were thinking about setting your life up properly, is that you should aim at the highest possible thing. And of course, then that begs the question, what is the highest possible thing? And that's partly what the Sermon on the Mount is about.

- 1.16** The highest possible good is a multifaceted phenomenon. It's not just one thing. It might be beauty, for example, but it also might be truth, and it might be love, and it might be courage, and it might be integrity. Right? You can see all these positive moral virtues aggregated into a single thing. It might be the call to adventure. It might be the call to wisdom. It might be the fear of God. There's all sorts of elements that make up what's best. And so you can't reduce it in some sense; you certainly can't reduce it, for example, to something simple like compassion. It's not a one-dimensional virtue. It's something very difficult to attain, a balance of many virtues or a sum of many virtues. And so God was often defined classically as the "summum bonum," the sum of all good things.
- 1.17** And this is a definition, not a statement of belief. It's a definition, and that's worth knowing, too. Imagine that you do know, we all know, that there are good things. And so that's an interesting category, because there are many different things that are good, but they share the common feature of being good. And so, then the question is, well, what is the essence of the common feature of good? And the classical, one classical answer to that would be, well, that's a good enough definition of God. And, and then you can ask yourself, too, well, if you're pursuing things that are good, and hopefully you are—not that you necessarily are, because people can pursue evil and harmful things, too—but if you're going to pursue something that's good, well, why wouldn't you pursue the sum of all that's good? Why?
- 1.18** And especially, there's another way of thinking about it, too, especially because you're betting your life on your actions. You know, I was out on jet skis this morning and I thought, you know, "I could die on this. I could crash into a boat and I'd just be dead." And then I thought, "Well, yeah, it's worth it to zip around out here, to take that risk." And, but the fundamental truth of the matter is, because of the mortal conditions of your limited existence, you're betting your life on what you do, all the time, in maybe a rather small way, but often not so small, because people do die in the pursuit of what they're pursuing. And so you might ask, well, what's worth betting your life on, betting your sanity on, betting your family on, betting your future on? And why should it be less than the sum of all that is good? Why would you do that?
- 1.19** Now, one answer is because it's a heavy responsibility to pursue the highest possible goal. And you might think, well, "I'm afraid of that responsibility," and fair enough. But if you think I don't want that responsibility, you might want to think again, because it isn't obvious what you have on your side to justify your miserable life to yourself. You know, we all are very aware of our own flaws, and we're also very prone to torture ourselves with our own consciences. And we probably do that more to ourselves than

we do to other people. Most of the people I know who aren't narcissistic are much harder judges of themselves than they are of other people. They're often less likely to do good things for themselves than they are to do good things for other people. And that's because they're acutely aware of their multitude of flaws.

1.20 And then you might say, well, how is it that you contend, can contend in a realistic way, with your multitude of flaws? And you might say, well, you could develop the self respect that would emerge as a consequence of bearing a heavy responsibility. And I actually don't think there—I don't think there is any other solution than that. And I know, like, I've seen people in very dire circumstances, you know, who've been brought low by all sorts of things, including their own foolishness and malevolence. And one of the things they do have to rely on in such situations is the fact that they've been of some service, well, to themselves, but mostly to other people. Genuine service, right.

1.21 And I also think that if you, if you're mature and you have some experience, one of the things you also notice is that there are few pleasures in life as deep as recognizing that something that you've done—escaping from your bitterness and, as a precondition for this—that something that you've done has genuinely been of service to someone else, especially in service to their continued development. And so there are a lot of cynics about people who run businesses, for example, that you're just exploiting your workers. The bloody Marxists think that all the time. But if you run a prosperous and reasonable and productive and generous business, one of the true pleasures—it's the same if you're an academic or anyone in a position to mentor—one of the genuine pleasures of life, and it's a deep pleasure, is the opportunity to take young people who have real promise and to open doors for them and help their development.

1.22 And that's a much deeper pleasure and also a much more useful salve for your conscience than any trivial profit you might derive from exploiting them, which is also not a very effective or efficient way of dealing with anyone around you. If I can cooperate with you, and we can align our interests, and I can help you move forward, and you can do that vice versa, even if you're in a junior relationship to me, we're going to do way better together than we are, if I'm just telling you what to do, and you're resentfully dragging your miserable carcass along because you have to. That's no way to conduct your affairs, and no one wants to be around anyone who does that. And so, the responsibility is, it might be worth the effort and the attempt, you know? And you just—

1.23 There's other reasons to think that, too. So, imagine that you go different places and you do different things. And one of the things that happens as a consequence of facing that challenge is you start to develop because you get more informed, right? You meet more people, you have a wider social network, you learn more skills, you gather more descriptive information, you flesh out your knowledge of geography and philosophy and history and beauty and all of that. That's all information. But that isn't all that

happens to you when you challenge yourself, especially if you take the challenge on voluntarily.

1.24 So one of the other things that happens is, if you stress yourself, challenge yourself physiologically—so you put yourself in situations that you hadn't been in before, that demand something new of you—new genes turn on and start to code for new proteins, and they build new parts of you. And so it's as if there's a reservoir inside of you of biological possibility that's a consequence of your inheritance in the deepest sense, but it will not be transformed into actuality unless there's a demand. And then you could imagine further that maybe you're facing a challenge and you don't want it, right? And you reject it. And so you're afraid and you're running. Then the genes that turn on inside you are going to turn you into a prey animal and something that's hiding. But if you face that voluntarily, then that puts you in an entirely different psycho-physiological state.

1.25 The data on this are quite clear. And that's going to craft you into the sort of person who's more and more able to confront, to voluntarily confront, larger and larger challenges. And given that the basic challenge of your life, in some real sense, is to not allow the weight of your mortal vulnerability to embitter you and drag you into hell—I think that's even a more pertinent threat than death—you better be set up for the challenge, because, and everyone faces this in the most fundamental sense, right? Betrayal and death and old age and all the things that are classic elements of the catastrophe of existence—they are definitely coming your way, and hopefully you can prepare yourself for that. And there's every reason to assume that you can.

1.26 And so that's a very positive message in the face of something that's extraordinarily negative. And so that's all background just for why this is a sermon on the mountain. And so that gives you some indication of the depth of these kinds of stories. Very little in them, if anything, is accidental. And almost every word and phrase is connected to a multitude of other words and phrases, say, within the biblical text, often within the chapter itself. But then also, it has its branches out into the broader culture, into poetry and art. You'll see that with the images that I've selected, for example, that accompany the statements in this sermon. And so, aim up. That's the first rule.

1.27 "And seeing the multitudes." So he's being Christ in this situation. This is early in his ministry, by the way. "And seeing the multitudes following him, he went up into a mountain, and when he was set, his disciples came unto him, and he opened his mouth and taught them, saying, 'Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.'" That's a very confusing line. Blessed are the poor? In spirit? So are we talking about the economically poor, or do we mean poor in spirit? What does that mean? Does that mean those who are bereft of spirit, so of energy and enthusiasm? And that isn't what it means. It means blessed are the—it's blessed are those who are the antithesis of narcissistic. That's what it means.

- 1.28** So, to be poor in spirit means to be humble. And it isn't humble in a self-effacing way, in a cringing milksop sort of retreating, "I am unworthy" way, especially not if it's accompanied by such pronouncements. That's not what it is. What it is instead, is that there's an immense emphasis on humility as a virtue in Christian practice. And again, I'm speaking of Christianity specifically here, because this is a Christian text. And I'm not implying that this isn't an attribute of other religious traditions. But what is this humility, and why is it a virtue?
- 1.29** And a long time ago, when I was teaching this course that I developed over a few decades, called Maps of Meaning, I put forward the proposition that your experience is made—you can subdivide your experience into two components. At the broadest level, it's yin and yang, to some degree. But another way of thinking about it, a more concrete way, is known and unknown. There are things you know, and there are things you don't know. Now, here's the definition of know. It isn't that you have a description of it. You know a place when what you want to happen happens there, when you act. That's how your brain reacts to a known situation. So when you're somewhere familiar, the reason it feels familiar is because everything you do works, and that's one of the nice things about being home. You know where everything is.
- 1.30** Everything's simple, assuming your house isn't an absolutely chaotic hellhole, which it might be, but if you set it up well, it's familiar and comforting because everything you do there works. And so you feel secure there, like you should, because everything you do there works. But then you can go out beyond the domain of what's kind and familiar, and you can go to places where you don't know how to match your behavior with the demands of the situation. And that's in the unknown. And you might say, well, why bother going to the unknown at all? And there's a variety of answers to that is, well, do you want to just stay in your house? And the answer to that is probably no.
- 1.31** And second, the unknown has an uncanny ability to come into your house, even if you don't invite it, which is the motif, by the way, of the serpent in the garden, right? No matter how carefully you set up the walled garden, you're not going to keep out all the snakes. And so you better be prepared to deal with snakes, even if you're on familiar ground. And the way you learn to deal with snakes is by going out and interacting with snakes. And so, then your safety isn't dependent on security, right, which is an impossibility in any case. Your stability starts to become dependent on your competence, and that's a way better deal.
- 1.32** In order to move out into the world and to become competent, you have to make friends with what you don't know. And this is the opposite of being a totalitarian. So if you're relying on security to regulate your emotions, you're going to insist that what you know is right, because if it's not right, then you get anxious and upset. And if you're anxious and upset, you have no tools. But if your security isn't dependent on what you know, but is dependent on your ability to handle snakes, let's say, your ability to deal with the unknown, then you can welcome the unknown.

- 1.33** And so why should you do that? Well, first of all, you're not going to escape from it because it's going to come visit you at home, no matter how secure you are. You know, even if you just stayed at home, at some point you're going to get ill and then, well, in come the snakes. And if you're not prepared for that, well, all hell's going to break loose. And so there's no final security in being a human being. Insecurity, which is why tyranny and authoritarianism, mindless rule-following, is insufficient, even though careless rule-breaking is also not helpful. What you want to do is welcome the unknown with open arms, because it can teach you and change you, and it can teach you the things you don't know, and it can change you into what you could be.
- 1.34** And so then you think, well, maybe what I don't know is my friend. Now you might ask yourself, well, is what I don't know my friend? And here's the answer to that question. To what degree are you living in paradise? If your life is not everything it could be, and I mean everything it could be, then hopefully the reason for that is that you're wrong. And that'd be great if that was the reason, right? Because if the world's wrong and that's why you're miserable, you're done. Because that's the world and there's just you. And if it's the world making you miserable, you're pretty much doomed. But if it's your own stupidity and your own ignorance, your own blindness, your own malevolence, then at least in principle, even though this wouldn't be easy, at least in principle, you could do something about that.
- 1.35** And so what you do, in some sense, and this is why Christ says, "Blessed are those who are poor in spirit," is because they've opened themselves up to the possibility of revelation. "Knock and the door will open. Ask and you will receive. Seek and you will find." Which seems wildly optimistic, but which has a real point, which is that the manner in which the world manifests itself to you is dependent to an indeterminate degree on what you aim for and how much you're willing to sacrifice to attain that. And I mean that technically as well. Because when you look at the world, you look at the world through an ethical hierarchy, because you have to prioritize your perceptions. You have to decide what's most important, because that's what you look at. Because what else would you look at—what's least important? And so with every act of your movement, of your eyes, and
- 1.36** with every attempt to focus your attention, say, on a conversation in a restaurant, when there's all sorts of other conversations going on, you're making decisions about what's most important. And so, if what's most important is opening yourself up to revelation, then you're going to put yourself in a position where that's a possibility.
- 1.37** So one of the things I recommended to people who are trying to develop a vision for life, and this is a meditative exercise or even a prayer, is—and we could put it in biblical terms for the purposes of this lecture. So imagine that you can have what you want and you need, but you have to know what it is, and you have to be willing to do, to let go of whatever is necessary to let go of, to move in that direction. And the more you're willing to let go, and that's a sacrificial motif, the more you're willing to give up to move

in that direction, the higher the probability you'll move in that direction. And the more clear your vision is with regards to what you want, the higher the probability.

- 1.38** Well, that makes perfect sense, right? How are you going to orient yourself towards something if you don't know what it is? And how are you going to attain something difficult if you don't put in the requisite effort? No one with any sense would ever presume that either of those things were possible without doing both of those things. And so the exercise asks you to spend 15 minutes, first of all imagining, OK, here's the deal. You get to have what you want and you need, five years from now, within the bounds of reasonable rationality, right?
- 1.39** But who knows what that is? Because God only knows how far you could go in five years if you were all in. You can go a long ways, but let's be reasonable about it. You can make another plan in five years if you're radically successful. If you could have what you wanted, what would it be? And it's a bit of a vague question, so we ask people to answer it more specifically. What would you want in an intimate relationship? What would you want in friendship? What would you want in your job or your career? How might you educate yourself? How would you take care of yourself mentally and physically? What would you do with your time outside of work?
- 1.40** Remember, you get to have anything you want here within the bounds of your limits, let's say, and even the limits of your imagination. Just what would that look like? Well, that's an opening up to revelation. You think, well, you're asking yourself this question. Well, that's an interesting thing, right? It's like, why do you have to ask yourself a question? If you could hypothetically generate the answer, why isn't the answer just there? And the answer is, we don't know why, but it's clearly the case that you can ask yourself a question and then you can get an answer. That's what happens when you think. That's the revelatory element of thinking.
- 1.41** And we think we think up those answers. But the religious presumption is something more like, well, no, the thoughts enter the theater of your imagination because you've opened yourself up to the revelation. And that isn't you in any real voluntary sense. In some sense, it's almost as if it's something external to you because you didn't have the answer, and you posed the question, and now you have the answer. You know how that works, too, because you can get an answer that manifests itself internally, and sometimes it clicks, right? It's intuitively appropriate. It matches you in some fundamental way. And you think, "Oh, yes, of course." And, well, that's a revelation. And then that's part of thought. First part, ask yourself a question. The second part, receive an answer. The third part, dissect and analyze the answer and maybe compare answers, and maybe do that in dialogue with other people. And that's thought.
- 1.42** But all of that's predicated on the initial openness to the receipt of the revelation. And so this is such a cool idea that the more of your own ignorance and insufficiency you're willing to admit—and that's a painful thing, right? If you go right down to the core of why you're much more useless than you might be, you go right to the core of that. The

deeper you go down, and that's, in some real sense, an admission of your sins and inadequacies, the more likely it is that you'll receive an answer that will rectify that. And I think, well, that's the first line. I think that's literally true.

- 1.43 I think that's almost all you do in psychotherapy, for example. It's like, what's wrong with my life? Now, some of that might be you've been terribly hurt by other people, but maybe you need to fortify yourself so that won't happen anymore. And you may have all sorts of physical and psychological problems that are intrinsic to you, but it's still the same issue. You still have to contend with those weaknesses, and you've probably multiplied them stupidly in all sorts of ways. And so you've got to put yourself down, not in a demeaning sense, but you have to strip yourself of all your presumptions and your pretensions, especially when you're dealing with the worst problems that you face.
- 1.44 Because the worst problems you face are in some sense directly proportionate to the most blind that you are, right? Or, God, wouldn't it be lovely if that was the case? That that was the reason you had serious problems, is because that's where you're most blind. It makes sense, hey, because you'd be most afraid there and also most unwilling to take remedial action. And so you really have to humble yourself. And it's supposed to be a private act, too. This isn't something you do and sort of expose your vulnerability to other people, although there might be circumstances under which that's appropriate. You're really doing that for yourself. Like, "What the hell's wrong with me, exactly?" That's a terrifying thing, too, because that means you have to admit to yourself that you are unhappy.
- 1.45 And that's the first thing a tyrant does, by the way, is forbid you to be unhappy. And so you might be a tyrant to yourself in that regard. You have to admit to yourself the depths of your misery and your longing and the bitterness that might go along with that. And then you have to associate that with all your insufficiencies and your errors. And that might involve a real detailed analysis of your past. That's something like a confession of sins. And the more you do that, and this is literally the case, the more open you are to a corrective revelation. And so Jung, Carl Jung, the great psychoanalyst, he said, "Modern people don't see God because they don't look low enough," and that's worth thinking about for the rest of your life. So, that's a great opening. These are the Beatitudes, by the way. That's what this section of the Sermon on the Mount is known technically, the blessings. And it's very strange, conceptually, this part of the document, and this is true, the Bible in general, is that it brings polar opposites together, right? So it lays out some of the elements of the catastrophe of life. And then it says,
- 1.46 it's in this twist. There's a twist here that makes the acceptance of those catastrophes something that can be transformed into a blessing.
- 1.47 And you see this exemplified most particularly in the metanarrative of Christ's life, because Christ, of course, dies a torturous and unjust death at the hands of malevolent

people, which is the worst sort of death you can die, in many ways, but the story itself is contained in a broader narrative that the acceptance of that destiny—which, by the way, is a destiny that to some degree we're all prone to in some real sense—the more radically you can accept that, the higher the probability that you can fundamentally transcend it. And I would say that's an open question, too, man, because we do know that the more you're able to contend with your own insufficiency, the stronger you'll get.

- 1.48** And so then that is an open question. It's like, well, how far down can you chase that insufficiency, right? Is it all the way down to the fear of death, the fear of social rejection, the fear of insanity? Because maybe those are the three cardinal fears. Can you chase it all the way down to that, and then can you rectify that? And I would say—this is a Kierkegaardian idea—you find that out in the course of your life. No one can tell you that, how that's going to go, right? That's your adventure, and no one can have that for you. And so—and you don't have to find it out. You don't have to dig all the way into the depths, but they will come looking for you, and there's no doubt about that.
- 1.49** So my sense is, it's a hell of a lot better to be prepared. And you're a lot less harmful and toxic to other people under those circumstances, too. And that's really worth considering as well, if you have people in your life that you love, because maybe you don't want to hurt them while hurting yourself. That's often a way out of self-inflicted pain for people. It's like, well, you know, maybe you don't care that much about yourself and maybe you have your reasons, but there are people who love you, and they are not going to be happy if you are not doing well for yourself. That's generally particularly true of parents in relationship to children.
- 1.50** So, "Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven." That's a hell of a thing to say and something to believe. "Blessed are they that mourn, for they shall be comforted." I would say again, there's an emphasis on the, the full experience of these emotions in some sense. I'll give you an example. So this is a rough one. When my wife's mother died of a degenerative neurological disease, an Alzheimer's variant, it was very nasty. It basically took her apart over 15 years, you know, and it's a terrible thing to watch someone decay, piece—in a piecemeal fashion, right—towards an inevitable death. And of course, everybody in her family was very sad about that.
- 1.51** But there were some, some events around her demise that served as their counterpart. The first was her husband. His name is Dell Roberts. He's my father-in-law. I've always liked him. He's a really charismatic guy. He's real 1950s Dean Martin, Man About Town kind of guy. Extremely extroverted, pretty disagreeable, really funny. Everybody in the little town we grew up in knew him. He just had that ebullient personality. And he was out all the time working as a businessman, and he was an athlete as well. And he had a big, booming voice. And he was always the center of the—he was always the center of the party in a good way. I really liked Dell, and luckily, he liked me.

- 1.52 But when his wife got sick, no one really knew how he would respond, because I wouldn't say that he—his cardinal, his cardinal virtues were not those of compassion. And this is not an insult. Compassion can be a devouring virtue, and for the person who experiences that and for the target of the compassion. So I'm not saying this in any manner that was critical at all, but he didn't seem to be the stay-at-home, take-care-of-someone sort of guy. And that's exactly what he turned into. And it was, it was stunning. Yeah. Yeah. It was unbelievable because he took such care of his wife. And it was so amazing to see that part of his character flower like that, you know? And to see him sacrifice his more extroverted and outward-oriented mode of being to take care of this woman that he loved.
- 1.53 And he really did love her. And she really loved him. And really, right up to the end, when she couldn't speak, she would light up when he came into the room. And so that was something, because he was mourning her loss. He wasn't shielding himself from the grief. And because of that, it affected him deeply enough to transform him. And so what was the benefit of that? Well, the benefit was, she had a lot less miserable time of it than she might have. So it was still hell, but it wasn't the lowest depths of hell, and it could have been. And then he manifested a widening of character and wisdom.
- 1.54 And one of the things that did was, there was some friction within the family, like there always is, and some ambivalence in the relationship between the children, say, and the father. But all of his children came to respect and admire him much more. And so when she died, and he got old, they were much more around to take care of him, which is an extremely interesting thing. And also, the family, who was not afraid of death in a very fundamental sense—my sister-in-law was a palliative care nurse, and my wife is very brave in that regard, and another sister was a pharmacist—they were in the medical establishment and accustomed to confronting reality head-on, in some real sense. And so, when their mother died, they marshaled together and they didn't squabble and fight with each other. And they did what they could to make
- 1.55 her deterioration as bearable as possible. And because they saw in each other the effects of the loss that they shared, they got closer. And by the time Tammy's mother died, the family had tightened up to a much greater degree than had been the case before the onset of her illness. And so one of the things they benefited from—because they actually experienced, in some real sense, the depths of their grief—was a compensatory tightening of the relationships. And so something was taken out of the family, a major catastrophe, the loss of a mother. But something nontrivial was gained.
- 1.56 And I'm not trying to say, well, that made up for it, because nothing makes up for the loss of someone that you love, not in any real sense, but you can do it badly or you can do it well, and there's a big difference between doing it badly and doing it well. And so, I think this Beatitude reflects that notion, is that—well, the other thing, too, is that mourning, in the real sense, is proportionate to love, right. The more you love someone, the more you're going to mourn. And then to mourn someone's loss is also,

in a paradoxical sense, a celebration of life, because if you allow yourself to be affected by the disappearance of someone that you loved, even if you had a somewhat ambivalent relationship with them, which is often the case with family members, for example, you also signify to yourself that, in the depths of your soul, you regarded their existence as worthwhile in the most fundamental sense, and their loss, a true loss, despite their inadequacies and their flaws, and yours as well.

1.57 And maybe in some sense, even because of their inadequacies and their flaws. You know, as my parents have got older, because people get, in some sense, more like they are as they get older and their horizons get somewhat restricted, you know. And you see your parents, as they start to become more fragile, and you see as well that you care for them not despite their idiosyncrasies, but also because of them, because the idiosyncrasies make up part of what they are.

1.58 There's a Nietzschean quote, which I really love. He said, "Great men are seldom credited with their stupidities." And his notion, and Nietzsche knew this very well, is that you don't want to be thinking so certainly that there's a virtue without a corresponding vice, right? And that something that you love about someone might come along with an attendant weakness that's a necessary precondition or an accompaniment for that strength. And I would say that's the same about you. And maybe you can work on those weaknesses because you have the strength and broaden out your personality. And I think you can, and I think you should.

1.59 But it's still the case that, when you love someone, you kind of take them, you kind of take them as a package. And maybe that's in some way—I don't mean an all-encompassing and all-forgiving judgment, less compassion, you know, because you want to hold people to standards as well, because that's part of love. But there is still that element of liking them because of who they are in all their peculiarity, right, as well as their possibility. And so—

1.60 "Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the earth." That's a re-representation of the poor in spirit idea there, is that to be meek, again, isn't a —I've read multiple translations of that word, and meek can mean —what would you say? It means not arrogant and narcissistic. That's the best way of thinking about it. And there's another way of attacking that. That's a very deep idea, too. So the notion of Lucifer, there's very little discussion of the nature of the satanic spirit in the biblical corpus, really a few lines, almost nothing. Almost the whole idea that there's an adversarial entity, a satanic entity or Luciferian entity, is sort of in the cloud of dreamlike imagery and story that surrounds the biblical corpus. So it's material, literary material in a real sense, outside of the biblical writings.

1.61 It's a figment of the imagination, so to speak, which doesn't mean it isn't real, by the way. The Luciferian spirit, this is Milton. Milton developed this idea more than anyone else. He believed that it was the untrammelled, arrogant intellect that insists that its rational presumptions are 100% correct. And so you could think of the Luciferian—so

Milton portrayed Lucifer as the highest angel in God's heavenly hierarchy, gone most catastrophically wrong. Lucifer means "light-bringer," and Lucifer was represented as the spirit of the intellect. And that's, in some sense, that's rationality itself. But it's not just rationality. It's the rationality that falls in love with its own pretensions and then elevates them to the status of God.

- 1.62 And that's the story of the Tower of Babel, for example. So when the people who build the Tower of Babel build it, they build a structure that attempts to replace God. And the consequence of that is that no one can communicate with one another anymore because fundamental categories become questionable, which is, by the way, exactly what's happening right now. And Babel referred to Babylon, which was an empire. But the word Babel is also derived from—the babble of unintelligible speech is also derived from the same root as the Tower of Babel.
- 1.63 And so it's authoritarian presumption that reduces utterances to meaninglessness. And certainly totalitarian presumptions do that, because in a totalitarian state, every word everyone says is a lie. And that's what makes it a totalitarian state. And that's true of everyone, right? Parents lie to their children. Children lie to their parents. Wives lie to their husbands. Husbands lie to their wives. Everyone lies about everything all the time, and that's why it's a totalitarian state. And so no one ever says anything that's real or true, and no one can communicate. And the Luciferian spirit is behind that. And that's the spirit that wants to not open itself up to continued revelation from the transcendent, let's say, but to insist that what is already known is all that needs to be known, and more importantly, all that is morally allowed to be known.
- 1.64 And you see that again playing out in the culture war, where what we see now is that, if you think certain things that aren't canonically correct, not only are you wrong, but you're basically immoral and worse, right? You're predatory. And worse, you're positively demonic. And that's a complete inversion of the actuality of the situation, because you should be holding your knowledge lightly, because what the hell do you know, unless your life is perfect and you're a shining light on the hill? And so you should always be looking for corrective from what's transcendent.
- 1.65 And so one of the things I realized recently, it's quite a frightening realization. This is when I, mostly, when I was talking to Richard Dawkins, because Dawkins is an atheist, as most of you know, so he doesn't believe in a transcendent deity. But Dawkins believes in a transcendent object. And this is very interesting. So he believes in a transcendent—so what would a transcendent object be? Well, imagine you're a scientist, right? And you have a theory about the way the world is, and you can think about that as a Tower of Babel. It's a set of presumptions about reality itself.
- 1.66 But if you're a real scientist, you don't believe in your theory. You believe that there's an object, transcendent object, that you do not understand, which is outside the confines of your theoretical presuppositions. And if you match the theory against the transcendent reality—which you cannot detect, by the way, right, because it's outside

of your conceptual framework, so it only exists in possibility—if you match that theory against the transcendent object, it will correct you. And I think that's the same idea as a transcendent deity. It at least shares the notion that there's something, well, that there's an objective reality, but it's not objective. It's transcendent because it's outside of your epistemological frame, right? Epistemological frame would be your philosophical and conceptual frame.

1.67 And so I think, I don't know if this is true, but it could be true. It's possible that the reason that science developed in the West was because we developed the notion of a transcendent reality and instantiated that very deeply in our culture. And once that had been instantiated, that you could exist in a relationship, say, of truth in relationship to the transcendent, we could also use that on the material world. And it also turned out to work there. And there's an interesting corollary of that, too, which is that the Nietzschean "death of God," which is the death of the transcendent deity, might also be the death of the transcendent object.

1.68 And you certainly see that playing out with the Postmodernists, because they basically make the claim that there's no territory, there's just different maps. There's no transcendent reality even on the objective front, which is why you see things like the decolonization of science and the insistence that the scientific enterprise is nothing but a variant of the oppressive maneuvering of the power structure or something like that. It's not any real attempt to contact something genuine on the ontological front—so that's the study of reality itself—because there is nothing genuine there. And if you think there is, that's just an index of the depth of your willingness to use your own delusions to oppress other people.

1.69 That's a hell of an accusation, you know, both on the theological and the scientific front. And so it could be that, if we lose our humility in the face of the transcendent, we'll also lose the transcendent object in science itself. And no one, no one saw that coming. But I think not only is it a possibility, I think that's exactly what's playing out right now. And so science, there's no reason to assume that's not a fragile enterprise. It's only 500 years old in the formal sense. I mean, you could trace it back to the Greeks, if you really want to push it, but fundamentally, it's 500 years old. That's not very old. That's like, that's not even yesterday. That's like two minutes ago. And it only emerged in our scientific culture, never emerged anywhere else. And we don't know the preconditions for its emergence or its maintenance, but belief in the transcendent object certainly seems to be one of them.

1.70 You know, one of the things I liked about Dawkins, and I like about the scientific atheists in general, is that most of them are actually scientists. Dawkins is a real scientist, and that means also that he believes that the truth will set you free, because he wouldn't be so assiduous in his pursuit of the truth if he hadn't accepted that as a metaphysical axiom. I tried to torture him a bit about that, and we got a little ways on it. But he believes, like most of the atheist types believe, that you can have a hunger for

truth outside the framework of a Judeo-Christian morality. I'm not so sure that's true. But he thinks it is, and he might be right, but he isn't —as he's finding out as the scientific enterprise collapses around him.

- 1.71** And all the atheist humanists who were supposed to be rationalists degenerate into Postmodern woke ideologues. And he's suffered a fair bit on that front already. And so, you know, because his dream was, well, "We'll shed the shackles of superstition, we'll all be enlightened Renaissance rationalists," like, no, we'll just be way crazier than anything you've ever seen. And that seems—first of all, it's the most likely outcome because it's really hard to be a trained scientist. It takes you ten years of practice to really think like a scientist. And then if you take all those scientists that have practiced for ten years, only a real tiny subset of them can really think like scientists. It's really, really hard to learn that. And so the probability that what's interfering with that primarily is just the hangovers of our superstitious past, it's like, you know, that's part of it, I suppose, but it's not very much of it. It's a way worse problem than that.
- 1.72** "Blessed are they which do hunger and thirst after righteousness, for they shall be filled." Well, that's a lovely idea. It's another variant of the "knock and the door will open" notion, is that, well, if you want righteousness, whatever that means, well, what would that be? To walk the proper path. And so you might say, well, do I want to walk the proper path? That's the first thing you have to figure out. And you got to think, well, why wouldn't I? And the answer would, because you're bitter and resentful and you'd rather aim down and you don't want the responsibility. And maybe not only that, you want to pretend that you're good, so that you get all the benefits of being good without having to do any of the work.
- 1.73** So those would be the fundamental impediments. And if you don't think they're in you, you have not looked, because they're definitely in you. And so you've got to shed that, and you got to think through, do you really want to carry that along with you? And then you want to walk the righteous path. Well, you better discover what it is, and that's going to be hard because it's probably not the path you're on. And you can feel that out to some degree. You know, one of the things I learned and that I've tried to teach people is that, if you pay attention to what you say, and I really mean attention, not think about it. I mean attend. Attend is an opening,
- 1.74** to watch and to be receptive. That's why the Eye of Horus was a redemptive figure for the Egyptians and not the rational spirit, the Luciferian rational spirit. It's attention. If you pay attention to what you say, you can feel whether you're making yourself weak or strong with every word, and then you can decide to stop saying things that make you weak, and then you can practice that, and that works. And so that's one way of sort of feeling out the righteous path. It's like, well, is this the right pathway forward?
- 1.75** You know, you do that when you meet someone and you're trying to feel out how to have a relationship with them, right? You're dancing with them and you're seeing, does this work? Not instrumentally, but if you're doing it genuinely, learning how to play

with them, you test it out. And you see, you do that with a dog in a park to see what the pathway is. And you do that in an embodied sense, not just a rational sense. And so, to tread the path of righteousness is to, first of all, orient yourself so you want that. And one way of doing that is to think of the alternative, you know, because paths that aren't righteous lead to hell. And that's—if you don't know, that's worse than death.

- 1.76 There's lots of things you still don't know. And so you really want to ask yourself if that's the path you want to be on. A path that's associated with deceit, that's definitely the pathway to hell, because that's the totalitarian path. And if the pathway isn't informed by love, then it's neutral or it's informed by hate. And it's hard to see how that's—unless you want hate, and you can have your reasons for that, but it's very difficult to think, to believe in any fundamental sense, that that's going to do you any good, or anyone else. You might have dispensed with the desire to do good. That happens. But that's not my point. My point is, if you do want to do good, almost no one thinks you get there with lying and hate.
- 1.77 And so, this Beatitude basically claims, "If you want it, then you can have it." But there's a cost, because the question is, what do you mean 'want'? And that's why the sacrificial motif that runs through the biblical corpus is so important. Because to want something means to work for it, and to work for it literally means to make sacrifices, because work is a sacrificial enterprise. And you say, well, what do you mean by that? It's like, well, work sacrifices the present for the future. If that isn't what you're doing, you're not working. You might be playing. Maybe you even have a job that's play, you know, but it's not real work. You're just so fortunate that you found something you can play at that actually provides you with economic sustenance.
- 1.78 But very often you have to work in order to make ends meet, right? And you do that by sacrificing the short-term hedonic pleasure of the present to the medium- and long-term stability of the future. And that can be very effortful and responsibility-laden, but it works. And then the question, I suppose, and this is a question that's posed—it starts to be posed right in the early opening stories in the biblical corpus—what should you make sacrifices to? And the lurking idea here is righteousness. So, imagine you're trying to decide what's worth giving up your selfish short-term pleasures in service of. And then we're back into the same problem we started with. Well, what's worth making sacrifices to?
- 1.79 Or more importantly even, what spirit should you be making sacrifices to? And that's the question of God. And you might think, well, "I don't believe in God," and I would say, "That's completely irrelevant in some fundamental sense," because if you're not making sacrifices, you're at best useless. At worst, you're harmful and you're chaotic and anxiety-ridden, seeker after trivial pleasures. That's you. And then you're making sacrifices anyways, because now you're sacrificing the future to the present instead of the reverse. So there's no way out of the sacrificial paradox. There's only a matter of

getting it right. And then the question is, well, what's worth the ultimate sacrifice? Because you're going to have to make that.

- 1.80** Everything you have, everything you hold, you're going to lose. And then the question really, the question comes up, what could possibly justify that? And the answer might be nothing, right? That would be the fundamentally pessimistic answer. But you could always pose it as a question to yourself, right? You could take it seriously. "I'm going to lose everything." All right, so given that that's the case, "How might I live?" And it seems hopeless. "I'm going to lose everything. Why would I live at all?" But it's possible if you actually asked yourself the question, you could find an answer to it. And I do believe you can.
- 1.81** You know, when people, when someone my age, because I'm getting older, I look back on my life, I think, "That was worth it," you know, and it's often something that took a fair bit of struggle to manage, but I think in retrospect, "Yeah, but it was worth it." And that's a hint in the right direction, isn't it? Because if it's difficult and demanding, and you do it in the face of your mortality and your insufficiency and your judgment on that, in retrospect, is, "Yeah, but that was worth it," then you actually found a solution to the problem. One of the things I really liked about the biblical corpus, especially the story of Abraham, but you see it in the story of Moses as well, is there's this idea that it isn't happiness that redeems you, it's proper sacrifice. But there's more to it than that.
- 1.82** What redeems your life is the adventure of your life. It's not happiness, it's not ease or security, it's not freedom from anxiety or even privation. None of that. In fact, those—experiencing those in the proper proportions might be a precondition to a full life, right? To putting yourself in a position where you actually have something to lose, and both risk and experience loss, because nothing ventured, nothing gained, right? And so, but I do think that, I do think that it strikes a deep chord in people when you say you could have the adventure of your life and that would be so magnificent. It could be so magnificent that it would justify the catastrophe of your life.
- 1.83** Or you could even put it forward as a challenge. It's like, could you conjure up an adventure for your life that's so magnificent that it would justify the catastrophe of your life? And the answer is, well, "We'll see what you do with your life," because you literally answer that question. You literally answer that question with your life. And here's something else to think about that, I think, that's so interesting. So in the force that God uses at the beginning of time to conjure habitable order, the habitable order that is good, out of potential—that's the word. And the word is Allah is directed towards love in the sense that we've already described, but it's also the truthful word. And so truth is subordinate to love in that sense.
- 1.84** So then you might say, well, how to think about truth? And so imagine that, oh, I don't know, maybe you're out on a date and you're trying to manipulate the person that you're with into bed with you for some short-term hedonic gratification. And so you're trying to craft yourself so you're maximally attractive to attain that short-term end. And

so, it's not you that's talking, right? It's this little fragment of yourself that's possessed by this desire. And now you're twisting and bending your words to attain that desire. And you might say, well, I'm lonesome and I'd like to be with someone, and so that's perfectly justifiable.

- 1.85** But the problem with that—here's the problem. I thought about this in relationship to these guys in colleges. Now, there's a small percentage of people, men in female-dominated colleges, who basically have their selection of sexual partners because there's a shortage of men, and there's a tiny fraction of that shortage of men who are popular. And so they can engage in repeated short-term hedonic sexual interactions. And so why not? What a deal. Except, well, what are you learning? Exactly. Like, are you learning a variant of psychopathic instrumental manipulation? Because you just treat the other person as if they're a target for one interaction that's not repeated.
- 1.86** And that's a recipe for learning how to be a psychopath, that's for sure. And so you get what you want, but what the hell do you know about what you want? That's the big issue here. It's like, unless you're 100% reliable, and you're not, your conception of what might constitute the optimal future is likely to be warped. And so, that doesn't mean you shouldn't make plans. It doesn't mean you shouldn't have a vision and lift your eyes up. But you have to do that, given your sense of your own inadequacy. And so then you might say, well, why don't you just give all that up and just say what you believe to be true? And then what you find is, that's an adventure.
- 1.87** Because if I tell you only what I think you want to hear, I might be able to manipulate you to do what I want, right? And that could be true in business, and it could be true in my family. And then I, maybe I even have a slightly higher chance of getting what I want, although I think that's debatable because people see through that pretty quickly if they have any wisdom. But if I just tell you what I think, then I have no idea what's going to happen. None. It might be good, might be bad. It might be bad, and then good. That's happened to me a lot. It was, like, really bad, and then it was good. And so I kind of learned to live through the desert part of that and to get to the positive part.
- 1.88** And, you know, it shook my faith in the truth to some degree because it got me in a lot of trouble to say what I actually thought. But I found that if I didn't, if I was careful to begin with and if I didn't backtrack, things would turn eventually. It was not so fun while they were turning, you know? And it wasn't necessarily the case that they were going to, but there's something deeper in that. Imagine that you want to have the adventure of your life, OK? Now, imagine you're using lies to manipulate yourself and other people. Well, those lies aren't you by definition, right? They're not the real you. That's what makes them lies. And so if your lies work, the thing that's succeeding is not you.
- 1.89** And then you might ask yourself, well, who or what is the prince of all lies? And what makes you think that that's not what's succeeding, when you get your short-term way? And if you think about that deeply enough for a while, then that's one of the things that

can scare you straight. Think, well, if I say what I believe to be true, or at least don't lie, because you can at least start with that, then at least it's you, right? And maybe you're not very good at it to begin with, and so you get hammered pretty hard, but then it's you getting hammered, too, you know? And if you, if you hammer metal carefully enough, you could make something beautiful out of it.

1.90 And so if you tell the truth, this could, this could literally be the case, is that the way you have the adventure that justifies your life is by telling the truth. And then you might think, well, how could it be any other way, right? It's one of those things that, once you lay it out, you think, well, that has to be the case. Because if you're not telling the truth, it's not you. If it's not you, then you're definitely not having the adventure of your life. And you know perfectly well that telling the truth is an adventure. Because the reason most of the time you don't tell the truth is either because you want to manipulate people or you don't want to have the consequence of telling the truth. So you just sugarcoat it or you put it away or whatever.

1.91 So you're actually denying yourself the adventure. And I can understand that, right? Because how much bloody adventure do you need? But that is an open question. Like, what are we, rabbits? Or are we adventurers on the high seas? Maybe we're adventurers on the high seas. And maybe that's where life is really to be had. And so when you shirk away from that adventure, you could easily be shirking away from the destiny that stops you from being bitter in the face of your own mortality. That could easily be the case.

Lecture 2: Virtues of the Beatitudes

At a glance — The Beatitudes and the virtues they encode, including reciprocity and mercy.

- 2.1 "Blessed are the merciful, for they shall obtain mercy." Well, that's a reciprocity idea. And I told you the story about my father-in-law, right? I mean, he went above and beyond the call of duty to care for his wife. Now his children are going above and beyond the call of duty. Well, in fact, this is what happened. Eventually, he had to arrange for her care in a long-term care facility. That happened when she was physically unable to rise out of a chair anymore, and he couldn't lift her out. That was that. There was no recovering from that. Then he would go to the long-term care facility and feed her and interact with her every day.
- 2.2 He met another woman there whose husband was dying at the same time . While his wife was dying, they started a friendship. And then after both of them died, they started a relationship. And so he got another person to be with him who's a very good person, and he's been with her for at least 12 years now. And so it was a direct consequence of his willingness to care for someone else that he found someone to fill the void in his life. And so that was pretty interesting.
- 2.3 And then his children, who, like I said, had some ambivalence towards him, like there are in all families. This is a good family, and this is not a criticism. Almost every family has knots and discontinuities in their communication. So it was certainly far less than almost any family I've ever seen, but it was still there to some degree. And they had some doubts, I suppose, about the degree to which their father was committed in the most fundamental sense to their mother. But when he cared for her for, like, 15 years in a stellar manner, all those doubts just vanished. And so they're also much more gratefully inclined to him now. And now that he's old and starting to become infirm, he just has help around him like mad.
- 2.4 And so part of the reason you care for the weak and the poor and the sick and the old is because there's a good possibility that that's you, man. That's certainly old. That's coming down the pipelines. And so if we could construct our society and ourselves so that we cared for the elderly, then we wouldn't have to be so afraid of being old. And that would be a good deal. It's just straight reciprocity issue. And one of the messages here is that you get what you deliver. And that's really true. And one of the things that's really cool is if you deliver more than people expect, you get back more than you expect.
- 2.5 So I can give you a concrete example of that. If you work 10% longer hours, you make 40% more money. So there's a hint for you. If you don't come away from today's discussion with any other hint, go to work 15 minutes early and leave 15 minutes late. Just every time you go to work, do one extra thing. What will happen, you can understand why this happens, is because it'll mark you out slightly in the sea of people

who might be promoted. When the boss has 15 minutes to figure out who needs to be elevated to the next position, the first person that will pop into their mind is you because, well, that person—I don't know much about any of these people, really, but that person is always, weirdly enough, they're always there before everyone. They're gone after everyone. It's like, that seems to be a good sign.

- 2.6** It's a big deal to get a promotion. It can really start you on the promotion hierarchy, and to mark yourself out like that. I would say, too, there's this trading game that economists have developed, so I'll play it with you two very quickly. Here's the deal. I'm going to give you \$100. I'm not, but you're going to pretend. You can share it with the lady who's sitting next to you, but you can only make one offer. You can offer as much as you want. If she rejects it, neither of you get anything. OK, so you have \$100. How much are you going to give her?
- 2.7** \$1.
- 2.8** \$1. Now, what would you say?
- 2.9** No.
- 2.10** OK, now, so why did you say \$1?
- 2.11** Well, I want to keep \$99.
- 2.12** OK, so this is good. Do you know this game?
- 2.13** Somewhat.
- 2.14** OK, I thought so. So he's playing a trick, and it's a good trick. So that's what the classical economist would recommend that you do. You're a rational self-maximizer, and you get \$99 and you get \$1. So what's wrong with you? Why not take the \$1? You didn't have a dollar, now you just get to have a dollar. So why didn't you say yes? And the answer is, well, you're nobody's fool, and you don't want to be taken for one. And so if you play this game across the world with people, the average offer is 50-50. And you might say, and that flies in the face of the classical economist prediction of rational self-maximization.
- 2.15** The reason seems to be is, well, now imagine that everybody gets to play this trading game, but you get to pick your partner. Don't pick him. Our trading games are played in the context of multiple iterative trading games. One of the things you really want to do is develop a reputation for being the best person to trade with. It's no different, really, than the best person to play with. And so your best bet in a situation like this, especially when other people are observing you, is probably to say, "I'll give you \$60," especially if you know that the next game is everybody gets to line up and pick their play partner.
- 2.16** And that's really what life is like, because we are tracking each other's reputations like mad constantly. We do almost nothing but that in relationship to ourselves and other

people. And if you have a reputation as someone who is not only reciprocal , 50-50, but maybe you'll go 55-45 just to be sure, or maybe just to be generous, or maybe because you know you can bear the extra burden, or maybe because you're wise enough to know that you want to broadcast yourself as an optimal play partner, then people will line up to play with you, and the doors will open everywhere.

- 2.17** I've worked in corporations, I've worked in small businesses, I have multiple small businesses, I've worked in academia, I've worked as a scientist, I've counseled all sorts of people, including people who manage big companies and so on and so forth. I know how this works. I know how it works. The way it works is that the more productive and generous you are simultaneously, the more doors that you don't even know are there fly open.
- 2.18** I'll give you an example. Undergraduates used to come to me because they wanted to work in my lab. There were more undergraduates that wanted to work in my lab than I had time to supervise. I wanted to give people opportunities, because why not? But it's not that easy to give someone who doesn't know anything an opportunity because it takes some training. And so generally, what I would do is give them some difficult thing to do. It's like, well, here, you want to go do this? Maybe it's a research project because I needed research done on a particular—"Go do this. Bring it back in a week." And so there was a hard task.
- 2.19** And so, reliably, one of two things would happen. The person would come back and say, "Here it is ," or they'd come back and say, "Well, I couldn't get it done, and here's six reasons why." And there are generally good reasons, and sometimes even real reasons. But what I found when I investigated further is that the people who did it had just as many reasons not to do it as the people who didn't do it. They just did it anyways. And what the people who didn't do it didn't realize was that a hundred doors had just closed to them.
- 2.20** Now, I tried to, if they had a death in the family or something like that, that was a genuine life-altering catastrophe, it's like, well, then maybe you get chance two. But maybe not two. Not if you're dealing with someone who's busy and who has 50 other people that they could be offering the opportunity to as well . It might be that there's no excuses. You do it or you don't do it . If you do it, if you're dealing with someone who's well connected, they have 100 places they could put you. And not only that, they have need to put people these places . And so they're just a gateway of possibility.
- 2.21** And then if you make the proper sacrifices and you put yourself forward as a problem solver , then the world goes like this to you. And if you don't, those doors shut, and you didn't even know they existed. And if you do that, you do that in university 20 times, you're done. It'll be a hostile environment to you, and you won't even know why, as opposed to what it could be like if you were a 55-45 player. We know this is the case.

- 2.22 So Frans de Waal, who's a famous Dutch primatologist, has been studying how chimpanzees organize their social hierarchies. You hear about the alpha chimp, chest-beating, rapacious, domineering, power-mad, oppressive patriarch, takes over the troop, has preferential sexual access to the females, and rules with an iron fist. That's the law of the jungle. That's the alpha male model for human males, let's say, and model for the brute force of nature and social domination. It's like, yeah, wrong.
- 2.23 De Waal's work, 30 years now, I think he should get a Nobel Prize for it. He's shown, first of all, that the smallest male in the troop can be the alpha, if he has good reciprocal relations with a network of compatriots—friends, essentially, because chimps can have friends that span decades—and if he gets along with the females and their infants. That "gets along" means engages in continual reciprocal interactions. So the stable alphas in the chimp troops are peace-making and reciprocal, and that's the basis for their sovereignty.
- 2.24 The same applies in the human case. I was just reading some anthropology on the tribal tradition of elders. Elders might make decisions for the whole tribal group, family, extended kin group, let's say. Who becomes an elder? Well, cross-culturally, it's men, generally, but by no means always, because it can easily be women. The women tend to be more preoccupied with the immediate kin relationships. So that, what would you say? It focuses them on the local and interferes to some degree with their capacity to deal with the broader. And that's not inappropriate, although there are many exceptions.
- 2.25 But the typical elder is a highly productive and generous older man. It has to be both. And who has a reputation for that. And all you have to do is think about that for 15 seconds. It's like, well, who would you listen to? This is someone who can do things, obviously, and who has a track record. And then they're good to other people with the things they do. Well, why not listen to that person? And so they don't rise to positions of power. They're appointed by a claim to positions of authority. And that's the tradition of the elders. I know that those power systems can become—those systems of authority can be corrupted by power, just like your marriage can be corrupted by power.
- 2.26 If you're not getting along with your wife, well, maybe you'll try to dominate her to get her to do what you want. It's like, that's pretty bloody pointless, and it's going to make you and her miserable, and it's not going to work anyways. And so it certainly won't work on your friends, and it doesn't work well with business partners, because why would you go into business with someone who's dominating you? Unless you're a masochist or a fool, what you want in a business relationship is you want to outline your vision. You don't really want to sell to someone. This is a good thing to know, too. If you're a salesman, you don't sell. That doesn't work.
- 2.27 What you do is you say, well, here's what we're doing, and this is why we think it's good. And if you don't think that, then find another company because you're a liar, and

that's not going to work. Here's what we're doing, and this is why, and this is what we think it'll do profit-wise and for the general good. Is there something interesting we could do together? If the answer is no, it's like, OK, if it's no, there's no sense forcing it. Maybe we could discuss it a bit. There's no sense forcing it. You're doing something else. What you want to do is you find someone who says, oh, yeah, we're doing something similar to that. We can align our interests and we can move forward together. Then you have a partnership . There's no compulsion in it, and there's mutual reciprocal interaction. That's how you work, both in marketing, marketing and sales.

2.28 It's communication. You want to find voluntary partners. You really need to know that if you're starting to build an enterprise. You don't sell your product. If you have to convince people, well , maybe it's not a very good product. Certainly, even if it is, you're talking to the wrong people. None of this should be compulsion. It's a sign of bad policy on the sales front and on the governmental front. So, "Blessed are the merciful, for they shall obtain mercy." And so that's a reciprocity observation.

2.29 "Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God." That's quite the phrase. Pure in heart. Pure. Pure means uncontaminated, fundamentally. It doesn't mean safe. It doesn't mean—it's not the opposite of frightening. Pure really means not contaminated, not disgusting. And so, what would it mean to be pure in heart? Well, I can tell you. Here's a good example. If you do couples' counseling—and so these studies have been done. So you're talking to couples and you want to predict whether they're going to get divorced. The best predictor of divorce is that when you talk to the couples, one or both of them roll their eyes after one or both of them say something.

2.30 To roll your eyes, it's hard to tell exactly what that means. It means like, "I'm picking you up with my eyes and I'm throwing you to the side or maybe in the garbage can." It's something like that. It's that gesture of, "Oh my god, really ?" And it's contempt. It's contempt. So there's a disgust element to it. When a relationship has deteriorated into disgust, it looks unsalvageable. It's an unbelievably good predictor of one-year divorce horizon. You guys have gone too far. You're disgusted by each other. You're contemptuous. You're way beyond the possibility of renegotiation and mutual dialogue.

2.31 And so then you might think, well, what if you have that relationship with yourself? You're disgusted by what you do. And why would you be disgusted? Well, you can ask, you could ask yourself that. That's a good question to pray on. It's like, well, I seem to be disgusted with myself. Why? I'm ashamed. Well, what am I doing? I realized this when I was young, about 25 or so. I started going to graduate school, and I was drinking quite heavily at that point. I came from this little town in northern Alberta , and it was horrible winter for all year. There was a lot of drinking in this little town. I was drinking a lot when I went off to graduate school. It wasn't really appropriate there.

2.32 I found that, more often than I wanted to be, I was not happy with my behavior, sometimes in a professional situation. I had moved up in the professional hierarchy.

There were more demands on my propriety. I had a good reputation as a student and a lecturer and a researcher, but I was a party animal to some degree, and then I'd drink too much and I just would get sloppy. It was a bad idea. Then I also couldn't write and edit because the stuff I was dealing with was too emotionally intense, and I'd have a cloudy mind. I got disgusted with myself and I thought, well, why are you disgusted with yourself? And the answer was, well, you're misbehaving when you're drinking.

- 2.33** So what do you do about that? Well, you could learn not to misbehave when you drink. It's like, well, you can't learn that because the whole reason you drink is so that you can misbehave. So that's just not going to work. You drink so you can misbehave with a good conscience, at least while you're drunk, obviously. And so, I just had to stop drinking. And I was going to have kids around that time, anyways. And I thought, there's no way I'm going to drink around my kids. But it was the willingness to realize that self-disgust.
- 2.34** And so, to become pure in heart in some real sense is to shed those behaviors that make you contemptuous of and disgusted by yourself. Now, you know, you can be too harshly judgmental. Freud would regard that as like an overbearing superego. Maybe you had a very judgmental father. That was where Freud thought that was most likely to come from. You might be more disgusted by yourself than you should be. You're a harsher judge. Happens to people a lot. The best way out of that is to talk to somebody about it. It's like, maybe you have someone close and you can say, well, "Look, this is what I'm doing. Do you think I'm going too far here?" And they'll say—hopefully you can trust them—"No, you're being too hard on yourself."
- 2.35** You've got to separate out the tyrannical superego from the part of you that's conscience that's judging you properly, and then you have to respond to that. That takes careful discernment and judgment and often a fair bit of dialogue. But to become pure in heart is to abandon the behaviors and preconceptions that are making you ashamed of yourself. You can see the humility in that, too, because you have to be willing to think, well, "I do things that are shameful." Who wants to admit that? Well, I know who wants to admit that. The person who doesn't want to do things that are shameful anymore. And so, and again, it's depth of admission is proportionate then to the probability of respite.
- 2.36** I think you can let yourself off the hook to some degree. This is why the concept of original sin is so helpful. It's like, well, of course you're useless and corrupt. Everyone is. This is such a good thing to realize, this universality of sin, in some sense. You think that's a terrible catastrophe in judgment. I felt that way when I went to church when I was a kid because the minister was always hectoring people about their sinfulness. I didn't really know what that meant when I was a kid. Maybe I wasn't that sinful when I was a kid, but I was more when I was a teenager.
- 2.37** In any case, the advantage to that is that universal accusation in some sense is it depersonalizes it. It's like, of course you've got problems. It's like, that's the human

condition. You have to deal with them, and it's your fault, and it's your responsibility. But it's not just you. It's part of the universal human condition, and it truly is. I mean, even among the ancient Egyptians, they knew that the god Seth, who is the origin point in the imagination of the idea of Satan—the words are etymologically linked, and Seth becomes Set, and Set becomes Satan through the Egyptian Coptics—and so Seth was the enemy of the state. And so the Egyptians had a god of the state, Osiris. He was like the patriarchal father. He was basically good, but he was willfully blind.

- 2.38** He had an evil brother, so that's the evil uncle, like Scar in Lion King, who wanted to overthrow the kingdom. That's always the case, right? It's always the case that the good kingdom is threatened by the tyrant, always. Inside you, for that matter. Inside any structure is the benevolent social order is threatened by the power-mad tyrant, always. You need to know that of yourself, too, and to see that as part of the universal human condition. You have to struggle with that and hopefully overcome it and atone for it. But it doesn't mark you out as idiosyncratically terrible. If you know that, then you can allow yourself to admit to your flaws without simultaneously believing that you're an incorrigible pariah.
- 2.39** One of the things that—paradoxically, people are often relieved when they come into a psychotherapy session and they get a diagnosis. And you might think, well, God, what's worse than having a diagnosis? And I'll tell you what's worse—suffering miserably and thinking you're the only person in the world with that problem. That's way worse. And so if I had an agoraphobic client with panic attacks, they often didn't know that lots of people have this. And so they're terrified of going out. They feel they're going to die, and die stupidly, because that's part of the fear of agoraphobia. And then they also think, well, "I'm the only one in the world who's this anxious."
- 2.40** And then you say to them, "No, no. One person in 30 is that anxious . It's actually pretty common. And not only that, we basically know what to do about it." Well, they're not so happy that now they have a diagnosis, but they're pretty damn thrilled that it isn't one of them and seven billion other healthy people. And so it's a useful thing to know with regards to your own inadequacies. So.
- 2.41** "Blessed are they which are persecuted for righteousness' sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven." That's a rough one. Like, really? I think this is part of the philosophy of the adversary. It's like, do you want to have an enemy set against you? And in some sense, the answer to that is no. It's because, who needs enemies? But by the same token, how sharp do you want to get? If you do something that's good, and people push back on you, and that often happens. If you're in a pathological family and you start to improve yourself, man, people get annoyed about that . Or if all your friends are drunkards—and if you're a drunkard, all your friends are drunkards, because who else is going to hang around with you?—and you decide you're going to stop drinking , well, they're not very happy about that.

- 2.42 And so, you move towards the good, they're going to go after you for being self-righteous, like, "Who the hell do you think you are?" etc., etc. And that's very troublesome to encounter that, to be punished for doing what's good. But then, by the same token, it sharpens you up. And it's very seldom that someone can express a doubt at you that will stop you, unless it echoes a doubt that you already have within yourself. And so if someone comes at you with a doubt, and attempts to stop you, and then you take that on as a challenge and you can overcome the doubt, well, then you're even more committed in the righteous sense to what you're doing. It's not obvious that the amount of resistance you want to your movement forward is zero.
- 2.43 You think about your kids on a playing field. You don't want them to go out there. You don't want your six-year-old going out playing soccer against a bunch of three-year-olds. Well, why not? Because he's going to win. It's like this one-dollar deal here. He's going to win. Why not just have him go out there and just mow down the three-year-olds? And the answer is, well, because you want him in an adversarial position so that he's sharpened and strengthened while he's moving forward. And so that's a way to look at opposition, even if it's malevolent.
- 2.44 Now, this is a tough one to manage, because if people come after you, attempting to take you out, attempting to savage your reputation, it's bloody difficult to see that as a positive advantage. And you might think you have to be some sort of Pollyanna to even pull that off. But one thing I have learned is that—I told you this story earlier. If I was attacked for something I said that I believe to be true, no matter how imperfectly I stated it, if I could wait it out, it almost inevitably reversed. It wasn't obvious at all. The things that have brought me the most opportunities—this is literally the truth—the things that have brought me the most opportunities in the last five years were often the things that were most devastating when they first happened.
- 2.45 It doesn't calm your soul exactly to realize that, but it's a good thing to know. And one of the things my family has learned, because we've been through, I would say, something like 40 attempts to cancel me and to cancel us in consequence, is that, don't be so sure this is a bad thing. It looks bad and it feels bad, and it could go seriously sideways. It's no joke. But it happened so many times and reversed so hard so many times that we started to learn that it could reverse. That meant you didn't apologize and you didn't back down. And that didn't mean a kind of narcissistic stubbornness, hopefully. It meant you were careful in what you did to begin with, and it wasn't just for show to begin with. And there was no reason to apologize because it wasn't wrong, even though it might have made people uncomfortable. That's a very difficult thing to get right, especially if you're dealing with contentious issues.
- 2.46 But it would be nice to be able to have the attitude that, well, just because this doesn't look like a good thing to me right now, especially if it was brought about by truth, that doesn't mean it isn't a good thing. It just might be that I don't have the bird's-eye view that's wide enough, let's say, to see the whole enterprise in its totality. I would say the

more careful you are with what you say and you do, the more likely that getting into trouble for doing it is going to have a positive outcome. Again, you think, well, you can see why that would be the case, right? If you just think through it logically, because if you've been careful in what you do and say, then you can't be undermined for reasons that are outside of what you said because there's nothing to point to about your behavior that casts an additional dim light on you .

2.47 That's what that means. That's a rough one, man. Same thing here. "Blessed are ye when men shall revile you, and persecute you, and shall say all manner of evil against you falsely, for my sake." Now, that's a strange statement. Who the hell would say that, "for my sake"? Because that's what Christ says in this sermon. Well, who is it that's talking here? Because it's either someone who's crazy or someone who isn't the same as anyone else is, because no one would ever say that. It's one of the great mysteries of the Gospel writings, is those sorts of utterances, and they happen quite often. "When men shall revile you, and persecute you, and say all manner of evil against you falsely, for my sake." Why would that be a blessing?

2.48 I think, probably—so imagine you decide to aim up, right? And you're aiming at the highest mountaintop you can manage, and you're committed to it. And then let's say, the more committed you are to it , the better that's going to work. Well, how do you indicate or test your commitment? And the answer to that has to be that you're tested. It has to be that because, well, how do you know you're committed until push comes to shove? If there's no resistance, there's nothing to help chase the last vestiges of failure to commit out of you. That could easily be the case, is that, if you're really aiming up and you get in trouble for it, the blessing in that is that it redoubles your integrated commitment to that movement forward because it forces you to think it through, too, right?

2.49 Because if someone comes up against you and says, "Well, you say you're doing this for good reasons, but here's a bunch of people you hurt, and here's a bunch of reasons we are doubtful," and then you go home and you think, "OK, well, these people are feeling upset about this and hurt their feelings . Could have the words been chosen better? Am I really aiming up here, or am I just being narcissistic or just being provocative for the attention or whatever it is?" Then you have to sort through all that, and then make whatever changes are necessary because probably some changes are necessary. But maybe you also come out of that thinking, "No, it was OK. It was OK. It isn't a lie. Even though it was upsetting, it isn't a lie."

2.50 There was no way moving forward in this situation without it being upsetting. Because there's a commitment to the truth, because we're aiming up, then we let the cards fall where they're going to fall . A lot of thought, well, thought puts you together, because why think? A lot of thought is hard because there's the revelatory aspect, which can be shocking. But then the testing of ideas means that the ideas have to clash because you want ideas that can take a pounding. What that means is, you have to, either within

yourself or in dialogue with other people, you have to let those ideas that guide you be battle-tested. And maybe, especially if you're trying to justify to yourself your own mortal suffering, maybe all you want around you are ideas that have been tested in the most intense of battles, because they're going to be tested in the most intense of battles eventually.

- 2.51** And so, I don't know, man. So does that mean you can welcome opposition? Maybe if you got your act together completely. I mean, if you like critical thought, you do welcome opposition to some degree. If you can have a debate with someone, that is a clash. It can be civil, but still a clash, and it can undermine you. And you can learn to enjoy that. And I think that people do enjoy it in a fundamental sense. It's like, the better you get at thinking, the more you enjoy that, and the more robust you are as an opponent as well, and the better you are at retooling your own presuppositions. The opposite of what you think is not necessarily your enemy. It can be the stone against which you sharpen your blade. And so that's a positive thought.
- 2.52** And so that's another example here of how there's reversals in these blessings. It's like, well, here's a terrible thing, and here's the hidden blessing, and here's a terrible thing, and here's the hidden blessing. And well, as I said, that's echoed in the broader context of the crucifixion and the resurrection. So you see in these stories this fractal structure. So there's an overarching narrative, and that would be the crucifixion and the resurrection. The voluntary acceptance of this catastrophic death and the triumph over that, and then all these little micro-stories that are embedded inside that have the same structure, which is a kind of miracle in and of itself, and also something that makes a story deep.
- 2.53** It's also symphonic in some sense. If you listen to a piece of music, you see that the phrase makes sense inside the longer melody and then inside the symphony as a whole. There's a relationship between each part and the whole. Each part echoes the whole. You see this so wonderfully in improvisation in bands that are improvising because they'll go off on a tangent. One of the soloists will go off on a tangent, but then he'll bring the experiment back to the original melody. If his band members have practiced, they all know exactly when the predictable is going to kick in again, and they can just nail that. That's a good example of how, even in improvisation, which could be improvisational speech, if you're careful, you can make all the words and the phrases and the sentences reflect the whole continually. That's a real mastery of language to do that, when you're writing and when you're speaking, when you're thinking.
- 2.54** So this is a great one. This took me a long time to figure out. "You are the salt of the earth; but if the salt has lost his savor, wherewith shall it be salted? It is thenceforth good for nothing, but to be cast out, and to be trodden under foot of men." Salt of the earth. You hear people say that about other people. It's a colloquialism. It means solid, reliable people, salt of the earth types. And that's so strange because that is not what this statement means at all. And so we can think about salt for a minute. Roman

soldiers were paid a salary. They were paid in salt because salt was rare. And without salt, you die. And so they were paid in salt. And so you need salt . It's vital.

- 2.55** And salt is a preservative. So to have the characteristics of salt in part is to be that which preserves. But salt in this context is also portrayed as a spice. It's something that takes something that's good already but gives it an additional savor that makes it not just acceptable but delightful . That's what this injunction is a call to. And in the Gospels, Christ is a very—I wouldn't say provocative person because provocative, in some sense, means provoking . But he's not presented as someone who shies away from necessary controversy. One of the things that happens continually in the Gospel stories is that the Pharisees and the scribes, so the bureaucrat types and the moralists, try to trap him into saying things that are heretical so they can prosecute him. The religious authorities do that on the religious side, and the legal authorities do that on the legal side.
- 2.56** Well, there's one scene, for example, where one of the religious types asks him, "Which of the commandments is the greatest?" And you're done if you answer that, because no matter which one you pick, there's nine ways that you're wrong. And so how do you get out of that? You can't not answer because then you're a coward. But no matter what you answer, you're wrong. And so what Christ says is something along the lines of "serve God in the highest sense and love your neighbor as yourself. That is the law and all the commandments." And the story closes with this statement, and no one dared ask him any other questions.
- 2.57** And no wonder, right? Because it's so brilliant to say, "I've abstracted out the core theme from the whole set of commandments, and this is what it is. How's that?" And that happens repeatedly in the Gospel context, and that's that saltiness. It's this playful, comedic provocativeness that has a deep wisdom in it. And it's part of the joy of life. This is why you know, if you're aiming up, one of your enemies is the enemy of comedians. Because comedians are exactly that. And they're that in the most true sense. As a comedian, we'll say something that's true, that no one else will say, in an unexpected way . It's such a relief to everyone.
- 2.58** That's why we laugh involuntarily, and that's why comedy has to be truthful, because you cannot think and laugh. You laugh and then think. That's so interesting because that means those words hit you. They hit you in the body. They hit you way underneath your thinking. We also really like that. That's like a revelation. That's what the comedians are doing, is this, "Here's a little revelation," and everybody goes, "Ha, ha, ha. I wouldn't have said that. I wouldn't have thought that." And everyone's so happy because they really needed to think that. And comedians are such effective social critics that way. It's so interesting to me to see all of these people who've blown up in the alternative media, like Rogan, Rubin, Steven Crowder, Theo Von, people like that . So many of them were comedians. And it's not surprising because comedians, if you don't

tell the truth, you're just not funny. And if you can tell the truth and be funny, man , that's art. And that's this saltiness and savoriness that's being strived for here.

2.59 Carl Jung, he knew there was a mythological motif that the fool was the precursor to the savior. The fool is, so for example, in the king's court, there's a jester, right? And well, is the jester the lowest person in the court or the highest? And the answer is, he's both at the same time because he's a fool, but he's beneath the king's contempt. And so what that means is that he can say anything he wants. And that means that the only person in the whole court who's actually free is the fool. And he's free as long as he's funny. And he can tell the king the truth. And the thing that tells the king the truth is the thing that's divine. And so the trickster and the fool, the joker, the wild card, right? That's often, what would you say? It's a bearer of messianic revelation. And that's what this statement refers to. So that's really cool . It's also really useful to know that if you're an enemy of the fool, you are definitely a tyrant.

2.60 "You are the light of the world. A city that is set on a hill cannot be hid." OK, so you can see the echoing there of the idea of the mountain, right? So a city set on a hill, that's the holy city, that's Jerusalem, the city on the hill. And you can think metaphorically, poetically, that we're all stumbling uphill under our load to the holy city on the hill. It's a city for a reason, right? Because it's not just that you're trying to climb the mountain. It's you're trying to climb the mountain so that you can join a community of people who have climbed the mountain. That's that image of the shining city on the hill. You have that image in you, right? In the most fundamental sense. Because if you could have what you wanted and you weren't being corrupt and bitter and cynical, then you'd want to have things. You'd want to take care of yourself.

2.61 But that would mean taking care of other people because what do you want to do ? You want to have everything alone? No, you don't want to do that. You want to have a wife or a husband. You want to have some kids. You want to maybe be good to your parents if you can manage that, if you can arrange that with them. It's no fun having everything by yourself. Why not have people along to play along with? We've got that image of community. There's no difference between being good to yourself, really. There's no difference between being good to yourself and being a shining light for the community.

2.62 Here's partly why. So there's you now, but there's you tomorrow, and next week, and next month, and next year, and five years from now. And so because you propagate yourself across time and because you transform across time, you're basically a community that's just localized to you right now. And so if you treat yourself properly, so all your potential future manifestations, that's exactly the same thing as treating other people properly. There's no difference. We know this partly because of studies of psychopaths. So psychopaths , they will take advantage of you because, for a psychopath, you're just a fruit tree. It's like , what can I pluck? And who cares what you

think or what you want? And maybe if I can hurt you along the way, so much the better, because that's entertaining, too.

2.63 And the problem, first of all, that is an unsuccessful strategy. Although it might be better than just laying in your bed and not moving. So you'd have sporadic success as a psychopath, but it's not a good long-term strategy because people figure you out. But also because psychopaths fail to learn from experience. They're so short-term-oriented, so hedonically oriented and impulsive, that they constantly get themselves into scrapes of all sorts and hurt themselves. They can't even regulate their own being. They betray themselves just as much as they betray other people. They do it for their short-term gain, but it's not helpful. The way they treat their extended self is literally no different than the way they treat other people. It's not helpful. It's not a good solution .

2.64 What's this idea? "You are the light of the world. A city that is set on a hill cannot be hid." You're also being assimilated to some degree to a city, and your goal is being assimilated to a city. There's a communal responsibility that you bear if you're optimally configured. You can think about this as being a good sport on a high-quality team. And so maybe you're even the star of the team. But if you're a real star—and so that's a light on a hill, isn't it? That's a light in the heavens—if you're a real star, then not only are you unbelievably skilled, and so people are pretty happy you're playing soccer, they're pretty happy to pass to you because maybe you'll score, but you're also passing to other people.

2.65 And you're also looking for talent on your team that you can develop so that the team thrives across time. And maybe you're not taking all the glory. You take as much as commensurate with your skill and maybe a little less just to err on the side of caution. But you're the kind of player that's not only maximizing your own ability to bring the team to victory, but to make it an exciting game for everyone who's watching and to play fair with the other team and to develop everyone along with you. Then, well, why wouldn't you do that? You can have your cake and eat it, too , right? So you can be the star, and hopefully, each of us can be the star to some degree in our own lives, at least when that's appropriate.

2.66 But then everybody else could be the star, too. And why wouldn't that be a good deal? And then maybe other people would be happy when it was your turn to be the star. So this city image, one of the things I really realized about modern liberal Protestantism and the therapeutic endeavor as well, to some degree, is that it's way too individual-focused , is that—because we think of sanity as something that's inside you. You have a well-constituted psyche, and now you're sane. But that isn't how sanity works. You can't be sane without sane relationships. And causally, because you're going to have some weak points where you can't regulate yourself.

2.67 And if you're surrounded by people who love you, they'll regulate you. Your friends will just tell you when you're not that funny. And then you can be a little funnier next time . And it can be real subtle, right? Real subtle correction. And so if you're around people

that love you and that would like the best for you, then you almost don't have to be sane at all because they'll just remind you all the time when you're not being optimal.

2.68 And this is something that's so cool, too, about listening to people. Jimmy Carr, the comedian, told me this about developing his comedy routine. He said, "Comedy is the most dialogical of arts." I said, "Why?" Because it's a monologue, right? It's stand-up. He said, "Well, before I go out on the road, these world tours," and other comedians have told me this, he goes to 50 clubs and tries out new material, and some of it bombs. And he notices because people don't laugh. And so he just, he doesn't tell those jokes anymore. And then some jokes people laugh at. And so he just goes out and does that 50 times . And if he gets a minute worth of funny material out of each time, then he's got a whole set. And he knows the set works because people laughed. And so all he had to do was listen, and he turned into a comedian. All he had to do was listen.

2.69 And so then you think, well, people are always telling you what they would like from you . Always, constantly, constantly. They're always upset. I don't mean in this instrumental sense, is that they're hoping you're the real thing in the depth of their heart, and they're signaling to you, partly with their attention. They're signaling to you all the time about how you deviate from that ideal constantly. If you pay enough attention , and so that's that attention issue again, that's also why your eye is part of the, is the core of your soul, which we'll come to.

2.70 If you pay enough attention, other people will tell you how you should be. I don't mean you should just be a follower, or you should just go along with the crowd and not make waves, because that actually isn't what people want from you. They want that spiciness that's part and parcel, say, of being a comedian, that gives savor to life. They don't want you to be drab and dull and harmless. They want you to be challenging. They want you to be optimally challenging. That's what they want. If you pay enough attention, then you can just find out if that's what you are.

2.71 I haven't lectured with notes for years. It's probably 30 years. One of the huge advantages to that is that I'm not lecturing to you. I'm just talking to you. I can tell if you're listening, and if you're not, then I can do something different. And you tell me immediately , right? Because I can see if you're distracted or if you're moving around or if you're looking somewhere else or if you're paying attention. And so, if you pay attention to that feedback, you can—and that's an element of being open to and not being contemptuous of your audience. If what you're saying isn't connecting, it's you, not them. Or at least that's a good initial slice . I mean, sometimes you're talking to people, and that's not the case. But generally , if it's a bunch of people and it's you, you're wrong. Not always. Sometimes they're all wrong and you're right. That's not a good position to be in.

2.72 "Neither do men light a candle, and put it under a bushel, but on a candlestick, and it giveth light unto all that are in the house. Let your light so shine before men, that they may see your good works and glorify your Father, which is in heaven." That's another

one of those lines you think, who the hell would say that? That is something—it's such a profound thing to say, right? "Let your light so shine before men." OK, so that means you should be so good that people are falling over themselves to be like you. People do that. That's why we have celebrities. Celebrities play out these roles that people are hyper-attracted to and want to emulate. So that definitely happens.

2.73 And so they're at least playing people who are letting their light shine because they play these great heroes in movies and so forth, and we're extremely attracted to that. So their light is definitely shining, and it attracts your attention. That's why the metaphor of light is being used, right? And it glitters. One of the things that happens to Christ and also to Moses is when they come down the mountain after having communed with God, their skin is shining so brightly that people can't look at them. And that assimilates them to the sun. That's a gold coin, by the way, with a head on it and symbol of value. It's the same idea. That's the same idea as the halo. It's this light emanating, and the light attracts attention like a moth to a flame, and that attention compels imitation. That's what's being said here.

2.74 I was thinking about the competition between religions recently. It's like, well, you have a religious war, a jihad . What's the proper jihad? How about a competition between invitations? Your faith is right? Well, how about you are such a stellar example of a human being because of your faith that people are lining up to join your religion? Is that better than conversion by the sword? It's like, well, conversion by the sword doesn't work. Or it results in a tremendous amount of death. And that also might involve your death if you happen not to be victorious. And it's a second-rate war. It's like, why not a competition of invitations?

2.75 Well, who's right? Well, how about those who can attract the most voluntary adherents ? Full-hearted voluntary adherents, not some cult and certainly not something done by force. "That they may see your good works." Well, that's another thing, is that if what you're doing is good, then in some sense it's incumbent upon you to do it on a hill and in public so that the results, the results of your actions , if they're good, will be evident to people and that you're not hiding that because you're confident in what you're doing. It's OK to show it under those circumstances, not because you're bragging or trying to aggrandize yourself, but because people need the example.

2.76 Then it says, "so that they may see your good works and glorify your Father, which is in heaven." Now, that's really something to add to the end of that statement, because you can imagine an ordinary person saying, "Let your light shine before men," using that metaphor, "that they may see that you're doing good works." Fine. But then what sort of person appends that to the image of God? Because that's quite a move. I had this vision once. I was thinking about all these men that I had had in my life that were signal contributors to my development. I remember this occurrence when I was about three. I used to go over to this house. Old Russian guy owned it. His name was

Niksitorov. Great guy. Had a great family. I just loved them. They were very warm and inviting. I just loved going over there.

2.77 They had this farmhouse with a nice wood stove in it, and it was very hospitable. They were very good to us . He was really my grandparent by default. I had grandparents who I loved, but they lived a long ways away. I remember sitting on the floor in front of him, and I was very little, probably three. Him and my dad would be talking in front of the fire, which is a lovely place for a little kid to be when the conversation is peaceful and there's a dinner cooking in the background and the house is full of good odors , and it's a good house. It's a really comforting walled garden to play in.

2.78 I would take my fist and try to hit Nick's foot, and he'd move it. You think , well, what's going on there? First of all, he was paying attention to me. If you're three and this older guy, because he would have been 40 at that time and he was a farmer, he was a tough guy, a Russian immigrant, tough guy. He was playing with me and he was a really playful guy. He'd move his foot around and think, well, what's he doing? I was trying to figure out why my dad was obsessed by rifles at the same time. He was teaching me to take aim, to hit a moving target, and he was playing that . My dad would say, "Jordan, don't bother Nick," and Nick would laugh and say, "He's not bothering me."

2.79 I thought about all these other men, my father as well, who's a marksman and has a huge collection of single-shot rifles, and he's obsessed with them. I thought, "I'm not obsessed with rifles." I thought, "What the hell is up with my dad? Why is he so obsessed with rifles, and why single-shot?" I thought, "Because he wants to hit the bloody target with one shot." And he acted that out. He didn't even know. He didn't even know what he was doing. Because I told him, five years ago. I said, "Dad, I know why you collect rifles." And he said, "Why?" I said, "Because you want to hit the target with one shot." He said, "Yeah, I think that's right."

2.80 So that's so interesting because he had 300 of them. It was a major hobby. He's a gunsmith and he's a sharpshooter. And so it was a major component of his life. But he didn't know why he was doing it, not in the most fundamental sense. But it was, you get one shot to hit the target, and you'd better aim dead-center, and you'd better have your equipment in order, and you'd better know what you're doing. He's a very painstaking craftsman because you have to be if you're fixing rifles, because they have to be accurate.

2.81 And so then I had this vision of all these men, and I thought, and there was a commonality among them. And the commonality would be the commonality of what was good about them. I can see a spirit shining through them. And that's that spirit, the Father that is in heaven. That's the spirit that shines through good men. And so the idea is that you set your light on a hill so that people can see that what you're doing is good, and what they see through you is the spirit that's represented in the biblical corpus as the Yahweh that created the order that is good out of chaotic potential. That's where we'll stop today.

Lecture 3: Discipline and Freedom

At a glance — 'You are the light of the world' — discipline and freedom.

- 3.1** "You are the light of the world. A city that is set on a hill cannot be hid. Neither do men light a candle, and put it under a bushel, but on a candlestick, and it giveth light unto all that are in the house. Let your light so shine before men, that they may see your good works, and glorify your Father, which is in heaven." There's much more to this as well. So my friends from Canada with Scandinavian heritage went to Scandinavia to be married. During the ceremony, they stood side by side and held a candle aloft between them. And the candle is a symbol of illumination, and it's a star, and it's a light on a hill, and you hold it up so that it casts light everywhere.
- 3.2** And it's a Christmas tree light, and it's the sun returning in the midst of the winter, which is why Christmas is set there, by the way, because that's the rebirth of the hero on a cosmic level. That's why you put a star on the top of a Christmas tree, and you orient yourself by a star. But why would you hold a candle aloft in a Christian marriage ceremony? Because it was a Christian marriage ceremony. The answer to that is something like, well, if you're married to someone, who's the boss? Who should be superordinate? You actually need to know this because, when you have to make a decision, it has to snap down to one thing. Some element of the decision has to dominate over all the other decisions in order for you to move forward.
- 3.3** Then the question is, who should be in charge, let's say? The answer that's symbolized by this ceremony is that the light that shines above and between you is what's in charge. And so, what does that mean? There's this idea in Genesis that the name Eve means—it's translated in the King James version as "helpmeet," and that has an element of subordination to it, although it's meet means equal, in some sense. So equal helper is kind of what it means. But the Hebrew, from what I understand, is more harsh in some sense, because Eve means "beneficial adversary." And that's a really useful conceptualization, even biologically, because if you want to make a tricky decision about something—so there's a process that biological systems use called opponent processing, where you set one force against another because you can calibrate very well.
- 3.4** If you want to move your hand very smoothly in one direction, you can go like this. It's still choppy. But if you do this, then you can move with unbelievable precision. Then you can imagine, within a relationship, a marriage, say, that there's an opposition that's set up inside of it, and that would be just the opposition between two people. But in a marriage, it's the opposition between masculine and feminine as well, so two sets of virtues in some real sense. Then it's out of the "dialogos," so that's the sharing of a logos—that's what dialogue means —that the truth comes out, and that would be a consequence of honest and humble communication. It would also be a secondary consequence of treating your partner as if they're you, in some real sense.

- 3.5 If you're married and you don't know your wife is you, for all intents and purposes, you're just not thinking very hard because you're basically stuck with her for the rest of your life. And so treating her like she isn't just an extension of what is you in the real sense, it's just not wise and vice versa. And so, if you're treating yourself well in the highest sense, and then you extend that courtesy to your partner, and then you approach each other in a spirit of humility that you might be right, but you might not be, and you better get it right because there's some important decisions to be made, like how you're going to discipline your children, for example, then you can set up this pattern of communication. And what you're both subordinate then to the superordinate principle of the illumination that occurs as a consequence of the communication. And so that's really much worth knowing.
- 3.6 And then there's another idea here, too, so that if you set your light up on a hill, then you're a beacon to others. And that's a, what would you say? It's a call to the spirit of imitation. So the central moral impetus that's put on Christians in the practice of Christianity is the imitation of Christ. It's not an adherence to a set of propositional statements about the nature of reality. It's not a scientific theory. It's not a description of the world in that sense. It's a pattern of behavior to emulate, to act out, to embody. That's why it's a spirit and not a theory in some real sense, because a spirit is something that animates you. It moves you. It shapes your perception.
- 3.7 When you go to a movie, you don't know this, but this is what you're doing, we're such imitative creatures in the most fundamental sense. When you watch a movie, you imitate the characters with your body. The way you understand a character is you get some sense of their aim and their strategies. The storyteller hints at that. What's this person up to? That's what you're trying to figure out. You don't want it to be too obvious because then it's not interesting. You want to sort of infer it. But as you're tracking the progress, the adventures of the characters on the screen, you're adopting their goal as if you're them.
- 3.8 So you share their frame of reference and their goal. You share what they're aiming at. And then, as a consequence, your emotions snap into line along that goal. And then you can feel the triumphs of the hero, and you can feel the sorrows and the anxiety of the hero, and you embody that fully, in that way that you can play out like you're using that character as an avatar of your imagination. You can play out what that's like to embody that set of principles in the world. So that can be very useful.
- 3.9 You can think of maybe the more recent Batman-Joker movies. There's been a lot of them, interestingly enough. And the Joker is an ambivalent, satanic character who's got a trickster element. And one of the things that you're doing when you're watching that movie is playing out that role. And he's an anti-hero. The anti-hero is a hero in some sense, too, because you should be the opposite of the worst thing that you can be. And so, if a skillful script writer can lay out a good evil character, then you get a sense of what evil is in some deep sense. And then at least you can start to infer, well, first of all,

what a catastrophe that might be, but also the motivations that are behind malevolence, and then you can flesh out the opposite pathway.

- 3.10** And of course, in the Batman-Joker dichotomy, it's a variant of the hostile brothers motif. That's a variant of the Cain and Abel motif, which is a very, very deep motif. If it's not the most fundamental narrative motif, it's in the top two or three. That's also an allegory in some sense of the battle that's always going on within you as well, which is the battle between wanting to aim up and to make things better because you're productive and generous and noble and faithful and all of those good things, righteous, and the temptation of resentment and bitterness and the desire to destroy and to lay waste.
- 3.11** That's supposed to be an internal battle, most fundamentally, but we play it out in our dramatic representations continually. A lot of our entertainment endeavor is actually an attempt to lay out the battle between good and evil in heaven. I know that sounds dramatic, but it's definitely the case. You think about the Avengers cycle, for example, which has gripped people. I guess it was really what came up after the Harry Potter cycle, in some sense. We're always gripped by these myths, and they're almost always compensatory in the Jungian sense, is that we'd be attracted to forms of entertainment that shine a light on things that we're ignoring.
- 3.12** The Chitauri in the Avengers movie cycle are basically demons who come from another dimension to torment mankind. It's an unbelievably old idea that, in some sense, we're always battling against a satanic reptilian force that's from another dimension in some sense, and that the hero is Iron Man in that cycle. Iron Man is an alchemical symbol because Iron Man is a man of iron who's attempting to turn himself into a man of gold. And he does that. Interestingly enough, he's almost killed. One of the things that's very interesting about the Avengers cycle is he's almost killed. He falls from space like Icarus, and he falls to Earth and he's dead. And it's the Hulk who's like the spirit of untempered masculinity, just this raw spirit that yells at him and wakes him up and revitalizes him.
- 3.13** And that's all compensatory because our culture is very, what would you say, antithetical to the masculine spirit at the moment. And so what you see is its resurgence in these movies because, well, you can't quell it. And as soon as you quell it, it starts to shine in the darkness in some sense. But in any case, that's all a bit of commentary on the power of imitation. And we imitate because we can use our bodies as representational structures. And so Jean Piaget, the great developmental psychologist, he pointed out that even the ability to grip something is an imitation. So if you want to pick up a glass, say, how do you understand what a drinking glass is? And the answer is, this is the understanding, right?
- 3.14** It's not an object. It's a tool. And the nature of the object is an imitative—there's an imitative element to it because to see the glass even is to rearrange the structure of your body to interact with the object so that it has a useful function. You see the glass and you understand it because you can pick it up and you can use it. There's a form of

brain damage called utilization behavior, and people manifest this, I believe, it's with left prefrontal damage. If you are characterized by utilization behavior, you can't not use something that someone sets before you. If someone puts a glass before you, you'll pick it up and drink it. If you're walking down a hallway and the door is open, you'll go into the door. It's an extremely—the frontal cortex is inhibitory to some degree, so it's damaged. You lose inhibition.

- 3.15** What that shows is that your object perception, object perception, motivates you as perception. It's not like you see an object that's devoid of significance, that you overlay it with significance and meaning, and then you act. That isn't how it works. You see the meaning of the object first. The meaning is what you see, not the object. That's why it took us so long to even develop a notion of objective reality, because we had to detach the meaning from the object. That's almost impossible because what you see is the meaning.
- 3.16** For example, there's a famous psychologist. He said, "When you walk to a cliff, you don't see a cliff; you see a falling-off place." If you're up on the 20th floor of a high-rise and you get near the balcony edge, you feel that. It's because you perceive the cliff, well, as a place where you'll die, and it's the death that you see. You don't see cliff and then think death and then respond emotionally. It's like, that takes way too long. You'd just be dead if that's how you perceived. And so, you even exist in a relationship of imitation to the world. And I mean, in a fundamental sense, way under cognition. It's way deeper than cognition. It structures perception itself, this imitative attitude.
- 3.17** And I can give you another example of that that's associated with the idea of the light. So if you look up at the stars at night, you see the heavenly host, let's say, arrayed before you. It's really a situation where you confront the infinite, or as close as you're going to get in some real sense in your life. Maybe you see that in fire and you see it in beauty and you see it in someone you love. You see it in anything that inspires awe. And certainly the night sky will do that if it's dark enough. You look up and you're struck by wonder, and that's a sense of awe. And that can cause the hair on the back of your neck to stand up like great music can. That's piloerection. It's an instinct that's probably 60 million years old. It's really old.
- 3.18** And if you ever see a cat respond to a dog, if a cat is surprised by a dog, it'll puff up and its tail gets this big around, and then it dances sideways. And the reason it does that is because it wants to look like a really big cat. And that's an automatic instinct, right? That dancing sideways in piloerection. And so the cat is entranced and awestruck by the dog. But its response is to turn itself into a predator. And so when we look at something that inspires awe, there's a call to us, right? And we feel that as a meaning. And it's as if the sky calls to you to be more than you are. That's what happens when you look up like that.
- 3.19** And that's not cognitive. It's not propositional. It's way deeper than that. And so the atheistic and rational types that criticize religion on the basis of the grounds that it's,

like, what would you say, an artifactual and superstitious propositional description of the world, they don't have any idea what they're talking about. The religious domain is underneath the perceptual domain. It's way below cognition. It's not fundamentally propositional. And one of the weaknesses, I suppose, of the Western emphasis on rationality and, well, rationality, per se, is that we've confused our religious experience with propositional theory, and it's just not helpful. It just confuses you.

- 3.20** It's also why the atheists tend to lose when they debate the biologists, for example, even though the best biologists I know are extremely interested in Jungian theories in particular, because the biologists that I study were very interested in emotion and embodiment and motivation. And as soon as you stop studying rationality and cognition and you look at the physiological underpinnings of perception and action, you're in a romantic domain. And the idea that we do something like act out a story or perceive the world through a story that basically has its roots in emotion and motivation and the body, that's just self-evident to the biologists who study emotion.
- 3.21** And so I think that's very interesting, that that's coming together from the bottom up, is that the most religious scientists I know are those who study the biology of emotion and motivation because they know we're guided by these deep, deep instincts, spirits in some sense. They're biologically instantiated. They're ancient spirits of rage or spirits of play or spirits of enthusiasm, sorrow, anxiety. And these aren't second-order propositional phenomena, and they're not antithetical to rationality.
- 3.22** The affect of neuroscientists know as well that rationality is nested inside of emotion and motivation and embodiment. They're not fighting one another. It's not like emotion is the enemy of reason. In fact, emotion and motivation and embodiment are the preconditions for reason. You can't even get to reason without filtering the world through your body imitation, your motivations, your aims, your emotions. Without all that, it's not like you'd be a cold calculating machine free of delusion and superstition.
- 3.23** You just can't get anywhere without that underlying psychological architecture that structures your perceptions and your cognitions. And huge part of that is this imitative capacity with human beings. So that's all tangled up in these three lines in some real sense. You know, it's dense, unbelievably dense. Well, which is what you'd expect of something that's deep and profound. It's almost the definition of deep and profound is that it affects everything at the same time.
- 3.24** "Think not that I am come to destroy the law or the prophets." Another—it's another one of those statements that you can't imagine someone saying it. What are you saying here? And who are you to be saying that? Because the law and the prophets, that's the whole Jewish tradition. So you have someone who stands up, and in a single line—what does it say? He presents himself as someone who could be confused with a political revolutionary, for example, who isn't that, and says that, and thinks that he needs to say that, and then also says something completely different. And that's all managed in

two sentences. And that's just the beginning of the phrase. It's just beyond comprehension.

- 3.25** "Think not that I am come to destroy the law or the prophets." A friend of mine, Jonathan Pageau, who's a great Orthodox scholar and artist, told me that there's a scene in the Passion where the crowd is called upon to either choose the criminal Barabbas or Christ to be saved from crucifixion. And the crowd knows that Christ is innocent, and the crowd knows that Barabbas—I think I'm pronouncing that wrong, but—is guilty, is a criminal. Pageau told me that there's an alternative name for Barabbas in the Orthodox tradition, and that's, he's Jesus as well.
- 3.26** And so then what you have, it's so brilliant, is that you have Jesus the revolutionary, political revolutionary, which is often how he's portrayed, often as a left-wing figure, fighting against the oppressor. So it's like Marxist Jesus. So you have Jesus as revolutionary, you have Jesus as prophet, and the crowd picks Jesus as revolutionary. That's, yeah, it's like, you can think about that pretty much forever. But Christ says here that that's just not the case. "Think not that I am come to destroy the law or the prophets." Now, the crowd, as such, part of the reason Christ gets crucified is because the crowd calls upon him to be a political revolutionary, to be king of the Jews. Well, he's crucified under that epithet, let's say, under that heading.
- 3.27** But he says that's not his kingdom. The kingdom is not the kingdom of the world. It's not the kingdom of the Jews. It's a universal kingdom. It's not a political kingdom. It's something superordinate to that, which is also a hell of a thing for someone to say. And that part of the establishment of that kingdom isn't the overthrow of the law and the prophets. It's very interesting, the idea of the law and the prophets, because you can imagine that, to keep a society functioning, you need the opponent processing of two forces. One would be the law. So for you, your law would be the habits that you've established that guide your life, the things you can do automatically and without thinking, that you've practiced to do and that without which you would be lost; you'd be truly lost.
- 3.28** But that's not good enough because you can't just do what you've always done yesterday, today and tomorrow. And you can't because today and tomorrow are different than yesterday, actually irreducibly different because the world isn't deterministic, and you're not a machine. And so you have to ally the law with the prophets. And the prophetic voice is the voice of transformation. And hopefully the prophets are inspired by and disciplined and shaped by the law. So when their voice speaks, it speaks in the spirit of the law. That means, if that happens within you, it means that you can learn new things that are also integratable into what you already are. And so you can learn without disrupting the structure that you've developed that protects you and orients you in the world.
- 3.29** But there's this constant—it's a logos interplay, and that has to happen within you as well. The necessity for you to change, the demand to change, has to be integrated with

who you are and where you came from. Then that happens in the political domain. In some sense, that's the endless battle between the conservatives and the liberals. It's not quite that simple, but it's very close to that. The conservatives say, "Look, man, do what everybody else always did, and then maybe we'll get along." And the liberals say, "Well, that works great until it doesn't work." It doesn't work some of the time. And then being different is actually crucial.

- 3.30** It's also the prophetic voice that comes out, and this is where you'd give the devils on the left their due, let's say the radicals as well. The law can tend towards a stasis—it's static because it's the state, and the state is static—can tend towards a stasis, and it can degenerate into corruption. And so the prophetic voice is also that which—and it's also the eye as well as the voice—it's that which, what would you say, illuminates the state and revivifies the state. And that's what your eye is supposed to do, is to pay attention. Where are things not right? And then your voice is supposed to be part of the force that revivifies the static state, and that unites you with the law and the prophets.
- 3.31** And Christ's description of his own being, strangely enough, is that the pattern of being that he represents optimally unites the law and the prophets. And in that sense, he also says, and this is all in these two sentences, it's just absolutely beyond belief, that the spirit of the law, the spirit of the law, is the prophetic tradition. And that's such a brilliant realization, right? Because you can think of the prophets as operating contra to the law in some sense, right? Because they stand up against the law, they stand up against the king, they stand up against David, Moses stands up against the Pharaoh — antithetical to the law. But the proposition here is, no, the prophetic voice is the true spirit of the law. And what you have in the law is the manifestation of the spirit that's appropriate for the time. But that has to be updated because the times change.
- 3.32** And so Christ represents himself here as the true flowering of the spirit that's embedded in the law. So if you followed the law most precisely, then you would develop a prophetic voice. That's the idea. That's so smart. It's so smart because it also pulls in the idea of disciplines. You want to be free. Well, maybe you're just a revolutionary with your sandals on and your placard and you're against the state. I found out that I could go to universities without getting harassed and speak if I went at 8:00 in the morning. Yeah, and everyone knows why and thinks that's funny. It's like, "Well, yeah, I want to save the world, but I'm too hungover to get out of bed, so we'll leave the professor alone." And so it was so comical. It's like, no discipline. There's no discipline there at all. You think, well, "Discipline is antithetical to creativity." It's like, no, wrong. Thoroughly, 100% wrong.
- 3.33** And you know this. You watch a concert pianist. You think that's not a disciplined person? That person disciplined themselves. And then if they're a genius, they transcended the discipline, right? They get beyond the mere law, and then they can commune with the spirit of the music. But that's through the discipline. It's the same

with dance. It's the same with any great art. It's the same with any skill. It's through the discipline to the freedom. They're not set up against each other like Freud's ego, say, and the superego, or Rousseau's noble savage against the demonic oppression of the state. It's like, the state can be oppressive and so can your superego. But fundamentally, what you're trying to do is to put the prophetic voice in alignment with the law.

3.34 Then I would say, and this is so cool, too, because I really believe this is true. When you find yourself engrossed in something, that's when you have the law aligned with the spirit. It manifests itself as that sense of intrinsic and deep meaning. That's not an epiphenomenon. That's not a secondary consequence of cognition. It's way deeper than that. It's the instinct that orients you to the proper path in the world. So you say, well, is meaning real? It's not only real, it's the most real thing. Meaning. Almost, and by definition, you say, well, life intrinsically has no meaning. It's like, that's a propositional statement.

3.35 Watch your life because you'll see, first of all, you're not going to dispense with the meaning of life. You can dispense with the positive meaning of life. Try dispensing with pain and suffering by thinking. Good luck with that. That is not going to happen. So if people say life has no meaning, what they really mean is, life has no transcendent meaning beyond misery, anxiety, and suffering, because they certainly haven't freed themselves from that with their nihilism. And then the next question would be, well, that's still a powerful argument. Maybe the fundamental reality of life is suffering and misery.

3.36 Well, then you watch your life. It's like, when are you not like that? What are you doing? How are you acting? How are you speaking? What are you engaging in when that self-conscious horror of mortality that drives you to nihilism and vengefulness disappears? Well, you could say that's a flash of the kingdom of God in some real sense. And then you might think, well, then your goal is, OK, so you watch yourself and think, "Oh, I don't know what's going on at the moment, but I'm in the right place at the right time, doing the right thing. I'm walking in the garden un-self-consciously with God right now." Why? What did I do? What did I do right? Maybe that happens, like it's just a flash.

3.37 If it happens once a week or something, when you're with someone you love or you're doing something you enjoy, or maybe you've got your attitude adjusted properly momentarily. There's something that's right. And then that's when you want to have that humility and the open eyes to think, "Aha! Something here is right. I'm in the right place. What did I do right? What did I do right? Or what did I stop doing wrong?" And then you—I suppose, in some sense, the purpose of meditative practice is this. And then you want to learn to expand that. "Can I be here more often?" And then you might think, "Could I be there all the time?" And then you might think, "Could I be there all

the time? And while I'm there, to discover something within that that was even better, that I could do the same thing with? And then, could I repeat that?"

3.38 And so you could say, well, in some sense, the kingdom of God is the place where you are when you're walking un-self-consciously with God in the garden. But at the same time, you're dreaming up a better garden that has within it the seeds of a better garden yet and that there's no end to that. And so, that's like a sequence of mountaintops, right, that has no peak. Just as hell has no bottom, and that's definitely true, maybe heaven has no pinnacle because the real pinnacle is the process of generating new pinnacles and continuing the movement upward. And that certainly makes sense if you look at how people work pharmacologically and physiologically, because I think I mentioned to you yesterday that your nervous system is set up so that you feel enthusiasm. That's to be filled with the spirit of God. Creative enthusiasm would even be better when you see yourself moving towards a valued goal.

3.39 And so then you think, well, what do you do if you attain the goal? Because then there's no movement. Well, you posit a higher goal. And then you could think, well, OK, I see. So the goal isn't to attain the goal. The goal is to generate a sequence of better and better goals. It's a meta-goal. And so that journey towards Jerusalem, the city on the hill, is the establishment of a meta-goal, right? A goal that guides all goals. It's something like that.

3.40 "For verily I say unto you, till heaven and earth pass, one jot or one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled." Another unbelievably pregnant phrase. There's a line in the Gospel of Thomas, the gnostic gospel. Christ says, "You will be destroyed by that which you do not reveal within yourself." And we know that. We know that. So if you're a parent, one of the most painful experiences as a parent—maybe it's the most painful experience. There's a lot of painful experiences, so it's hard to tell—but one of the things you hate to see in your children more than in anyone else is when they don't live up to who you know they are. It's really painful. So maybe your son's out on the sports field playing, and he's being a bad sport, and he's acting in a way that brings shame to him. And it really hurts you because you love your child, and children are so remarkable when they're uncorrupted. And you see them betraying that. And it's horrifying. It's horrifying.

3.41 And if you have any sense, you put a stop to that right away. It's like, "Do not do that. You're demeaning who you could be. You're demeaning who you can be for a short-term gain. Do not do that." That's the proper discipline for a child. You don't want them to be acting in a way that brings shame onto them. Not you. I mean, you too, because you're letting them get away with it. But that's not the fundamental issue. What you see is them engaging in an activity that will corrupt their potential. We call each other out on this all the time, ourselves in particular. You're not living up to your potential. That's a source of immense guilt and shame for us, to not live up to our potential.

- 3.42 That's a very strange idea because potential isn't real. It's only what could be, right? By definition, it's not the actual. It's whatever element of reality that's real, that's set against the actual. It's what could yet be called into existence. You know that some of that's outside of you because the world is full of potential. But a lot of it's inside of you, is that—and we have that sense, I suppose. The degree to which the notion of self-actualization is useful is a reflection of that, is that there's more to you yet that hasn't been called forth.
- 3.43 So here's a question to ask yourself when you're feeling nihilistic and bitter and resentful. It's like, well, the world isn't as it should be. It lacks. That's Cain's complaint to God. Cain says, "I'm making all these sacrifices. I'm just not getting anywhere. You're benefiting Abel. I'm breaking myself in half here. I'm not getting what I need and want. What the hell is wrong with the cosmos?" And everyone asks themselves that question. Mothers ask, "Should I really bring a child into a world such as this?" And men wonder and are asked to wonder, well, "We've participated as men in the atrocities of history. Is the masculine spirit best conceptualized as something that's fundamentally destructive and damaging?" And we call ourselves out on this constantly.
- 3.44 Here's an alternative idea. The cosmos is flawed in proportion to your unwillingness to bring forth that which is within you. And I really believe this. I really think it's true. And I don't know how it can be true for every single one of us, because in some real sense, in our deepest core, the potential that's within us is the medication to the suffering of history and society. And that's true for everyone at the same time. And that's linked to the idea that each of us is a divine locus of consciousness and a participant in the creation of being, which seems to be the case. And this is a terrible burden. And it's part of the idea of carrying the cross, in some sense, because that's the burden of the world and the burden of suffering.
- 3.45 It's like, if things aren't the way they should be, that's your fault. And Dostoevsky knew this. He said, "Every man is responsible not only for what he does, but for what everyone else does as well." You think, oh, my God, how can that possibly be true? But then you think, well, if you were a more shining light on the hill, maybe the people around you would be better. And what's the probability that's not true? At least in the local sense, it's certainly going to be true for your children. It's going to be true for your wife. It's going to be true for your friends. And then you might think, well, if you really got your act together, how far out could you extend that influence? And the answer is, well, there's been some pretty great people in the course of history, and they've extended that influence almost indefinitely.
- 3.46 I was talking to my friends yesterday at this Exodus seminar, and Moses freed the Israelis from the Egyptians. And so Moses freed "the people who wrestle with God," because that's what Israel means, from the tyrant. But then Moses—it's so strange, and this is what makes the story biblical in its import, because the Exodus story has been used as the structural narrative for revolutions against slavery ever since. And so

not only in some real sense did Moses free the Israelites, then and there, let's say, in concrete historical reality, from tyranny, but he enslaved all those who strive to be free from tyranny for the full 3,000-year course or thereabouts since the story was instantiated. And more than that, because the story has been psychologized, too, because there's the external tyrant and the internal tyrant. And part of the striving towards freedom, since you're not supposed to be a slave, is, well, you're also not to be a slave to your own presumptions and your own narrow desires.

- 3.47** And so, not only is his action in the Old Testament story a concretized act of both spiritual and political revolution in that time and place, but it propagates itself across history, and it's transformed itself into a spiritual transformation as well. And so then you think, well, to the degree that your actions are righteous and they move into the archetypal, then that consequence of your actions can echo not only across larger and larger spans of people, but across larger and larger tracts of time. And I would say, we're on a knife's edge right now in our cultural moment. Things could get very, very bad in the next 10 years or faster because they can go downhill very fast, or they could get way better. And both those choices are open to us. And I truly believe that all of you will be making that choice.
- 3.48** And in the ultimate sense, in some real sense, you meet the devil at the crossroads. Every choice, it's heaven or hell in the fundamental analysis. And you think, well, I don't want hell. It's like, if you don't think that part of you wants hell, you are really not paying attention. And, because how could it be any other way? We're embittered by our suffering. We're embittered by our encounters with malevolence. We're embittered by the self-conscious and painful realization of our own inadequacy and of our littleness, in some sense, in relationship to the infinite. One of the consequences of that embitterment is really the generation of a desire that everything suffer for the sin of its existence. That's a revenge against God, which is certainly what the hallmark of the spirit of Cain.
- 3.49** If you don't see that that's inside of you, you don't know who you are in the most fundamental sense. I would also say you lack that humility that we talked about before, that's a precondition for learning. You also lack the terror of God that might be sufficient to actually transform you. Because if you take the burden of your own sin and inadequacy seriously enough, you can tie it to the atrocities of history. It's the same thing —the lies of the totalitarian states and the desire of the Auschwitz guards to torment and torture. You need to see that as you. Then maybe you're scared enough. You think, "No, that's not what I want. I seriously 100 % do not want that." And then maybe that's enough to scare you straight. Maybe, maybe. "For verily I say unto you," and
- 3.50** this closes this, "till heaven and earth pass, one jot or one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled." So there's another hint there, which is that the law is like a seed from which an endless tree can grow. So there's a pattern embedded inside

the law, and that would be something like the prophetic or the messianic, the redemptive spirit. And it needs to manifest itself fully for the world to transform itself from the fallen place it is now —its intermingling of heaven and hell in some real sense—to something more closely approximating the paradisaal. And that depends on you. And things won't be what they could be until we're all what we could be.

- 3.51** And it's also interesting in relationship to the adventure of life. It seems to be, in some sense, that's man's destiny to participate in the perfection or the continued imperfection of being. And it's real. God won't do it by all appearances, without our voluntary buy-in, in some sense. I'm not putting this forward as a proposition. I'm putting it forward as a question, in some sense. You know perfectly well that if you really try to make things better, you can make them better. You certainly know if you don't do that, that you don't have to try that hard and you can make things a hell of a lot worse. Worse is definitely in your grasp. If worse is in your grasp, well, the opposite of worse is there.
- 3.52** And so then you think, well, if you devoted your life, really, you devoted your life to just making things better, and that was your fundamental orientation—that's the righteousness—how good could you make things? And the answer is, that's what you're supposed to find out in your life. That's the adventure of your life. And then the fact, this goes back to the Beatitudes, then the fact that you're faced with a true adversary in the deepest sense, tragedy and malevolence, let's say, that's really the challenge. And so that even means, maybe you've grown up somewhere that's pretty damn brutal and miserable, especially in comparison to what other people have. Everything you see around you is a problem. It's like, well, you've got no shortage of things to do. If it's that bad, everything's crying out for improvement. And so you could say that a barren field is an unlimited place of possibility. And maybe the more barren and the more disarrayed it is, well, the more there is for you to do.
- 3.53** I'm not trying to justify the barrenness or the catastrophe by saying that. I'm just saying that people are always looking for something to do. "What's the purpose of life? Look how terrible things are. How can life have any purpose?" It's like, well, if it's terrible and it's manifesting itself to you as terrible, which means it's bothering you, why is it bothering you? Why can't you just ignore it or transcend it? It's like, "No, this really bugs me." It's like, "Great. Therein lies the seeds of your destiny." And so that's useful to know, too. And that's a calling, right? These things that bother you. And maybe they outrage you and they make you cynical. They make you rant and all of that. And everyone falls prey to that. But at the same time, that's really you. For some reason, those problems have been thrown at your feet. That's why they disturb you.
- 3.54** And then maybe you don't think enough of yourself or you don't want the responsibility. And God knows you can understand that. When Moses is called on by God directly, he basically says, "I don't think you got the right guy here." And some of that is he can't speak. So Moses is a stutterer. That's part of the mythological overlay.

He's certainly not fleet of tongue. And so he says, well, "You really got the wrong guy here. I'm full of flaws, and I can't even really speak. I'm supposed to go carry the word of God to people?" And if you have any sense, if your destiny calls you, you think the same way about yourself. It's like, well, who am I to do that?

- 3.55** But the other question, the better one, is, "Who are you not to do that? Are you going to reject that?" And then is that humility or is that false pride? Because you can't tell when Moses —he tells God he's got the wrong guy. It's God. It's like, he doesn't have the wrong guy. And it does look like humility, and there's an element there. But when you're resisting the call of responsibility, you think, well, "I just don't think I'm up to it." It's like, that's pretty good news for the lazy, useless part of you. So then, well, that's embedded in this last sentence, this idea that if the law and the spirit that was embedded in the law made itself fully manifest, then the hell that still contaminates the world would be eradicated. And we don't know the upper limit to that, right?
- 3.56** Because we don't know, I don't know how all-in people are. I'd think we probably run at about 60-40, something like that, 60% in and 40 % either not doing anything or opposing. And we're still not doing too bad. We're grinding forward at a pretty good rate. Life for most people, by most measures, is way better than it was in 1895. And then you think, well, what would happen if we just, we were all in, like 100% in? What could we conquer? Could we get rid of all disease? Maybe. Could we educate everyone? Certainly. Could we feed everyone? Absolutely. Could our cities be as beautiful as the most beautiful parts of Europe? Yes. Could we have what we wanted and more? Could we continue to improve our vision? Yes. Could we extend our lifespans? Well, we're expanding our lifespans four months per year right now. So God only knows what the upper limit to that is.
- 3.57** What could we conquer? Well, could we conquer death? Could we conquer hell? Well, if you live in a healthy manner, you're conquering death. If you attempt to combat malevolence, you're conquering hell. How good could we get at that if we were all in? Well, maybe we should find out unless we have something better to do. As far as I can tell, we don't have anything better to do. And then you might ask, why wouldn't you do what's best to do? And that's also worth thinking about. By definition, the best is what you should do, by definition. And so if you're not doing that, well, you know it's laziness, it's ignorance, it's bitterness. You know it's that.
- 3.58** And you might think, well, "I'm justified." And man, I was a clinician for like 20 years, and I've heard lots of terrible things from lots of people and immersed myself in many terrible accounts. I understand perfectly well that people have reason to be Cain-like and bitter. I mean, there are people, you hear their lives and you think, "Oh, my God, how can you even be alive?" But then I've met people who've come through unspeakably vicious things perpetrated on them by others and who—they're aiming up, still. Because you could say, well, because we're deterministic, you have a terrible past, it's no wonder you're broken and bitter. And there's some truth in that. But then you

meet these people who had pasts so terrible that you don't even want to hear about it, much less live through it.

3.59 And you see these people, and every word they say lands on solid ground. And they've decided that despite the catastrophe of their life, they're not going to be a perpetrator. They're going to make things better, and people can definitely do that. And that just makes a mockery of the whole deterministic trauma idea. You're broken and hurt because you were traumatized. It's like, yeah, but what about those people who were ennobled by it? How do you account for that? The same deterministic theory? It's like the outcomes are opposite, so that doesn't work out. And you know, too, you know that it's a triumph of your own spirit when you overcome an obstacle. And the bigger the obstacle is, the bigger the triumph of the spirit that's to be had in its overcoming. And that's what you want in your biography, is a sequence of those overcomings, because you're not going to escape from the trauma. And so maybe you take it on as something that you can transform. So that's all tied up in those two lines. So. "Whosoever therefore shall break one of these least commandments, and shall teach men so, he shall be called least in the kingdom of heaven.

3.60 But whosoever shall do and teach them, the same shall be called great in the kingdom of heaven." And there's an emphasis here again, not on the propositional, although teaching is part of it. But the first injunction here is to do. To do. And that's why I also laid emphasis on the idea of the imitation of Christ. Because you might ask yourself, well, what does it mean to believe if you're a Christian? And the rationalist answer, in some sense, and I would say in some sense the Protestant answer, maybe the Western answer as a whole, is, you believe a set of propositions. Jesus Christ is the Son of God. I believe that. I state that, and I say that it's true. It's like, is that belief, or is what you do belief? And you might say, well, it's both. And that's what happens in this line. It's like, "Do and then teach." Do and then teach.

3.61 So it's not propositional to begin with. It's embodied. Then I would say it is also an embodiment of faith because all of what we're laying out is a landscape of faith. Should you aim up or down? Well, that's not a question you can answer by sifting the evidence. That's not how it works. Well, that's especially true if you've had an absolutely bloody, dreadful life. The evidence suggests that this is maybe so awful that it's not even sustainable. But in the face of that, you can say, "But nonetheless, I'll decide to walk up the hill." Nonetheless. So it's in some sense, even despite the evidence, and that's where the element of faith comes in, is that regardless of the catastrophe of existence, I will do good. Why? Because that's the right thing to do. That's a statement of faith.

3.62 You see, it's not propositional in the sense that you're describing your accordance with a set of descriptive ideas about the world. That's how scientists think. This isn't a scientific issue here. This is an issue of embodied action. Then if you can do, then you can teach. Carl Rogers knew—the clinician—he was very interested in what personal

attributes a therapist had to have in order to increase the probability that a conversation would be therapeutic. One of the things he stressed—Rogers was basically a Christian missionary. He became an agnostic, but he was on his way to China. He was the children of Christian missionaries. He was on his way to China to be a missionary, and he lost his faith. But his whole clinical endeavor is secularized Christianity, just as clearly as part of the prophetic tradition and the union of the law. It's just as clear as can be.

3.63 And one of the things Rogers pointed out was that, in order to be the sort of person who can listen credibly—so that would be the sort of person that other people would want to talk to—is your actions and your utterances have to be in accordance with one another. He called that congruence. So, what you do and what you feel and what you're aiming at and what you say are all lined up. Part of the function of yogic practice is to produce that inner alignment, too, by the way, to line up everything as deeply down into the physiology as you can go, to get everything 100% lined up like a Jacob's ladder. That's what the chakras are right there. They're elements of the heavenly hierarchy. To get everything lined up within you so that the divine voice can pull itself up from the depths and make itself manifest within you and to clear the beam from your eye, as we'll see as well, so that you can perceive without being trammelled.

3.64 But the emphasis here is on action, on doing, on doing. That's why it says later, we'll get to this, "By their fruits, you will know them." You see how the person operates in the world. We talked yesterday a little bit about the tradition of elders. If you look at the anthropological literature, it's very commonly the case that tribal groups are guided by consensus, but usually with a panel of elders, or that there are people in the grouping that are particularly influential, so targets of emulation. And they communicate with one another. So even if it's not formalized, you know perfectly well in any social group, there are some people that people really listen to and some people that they don't. And those people tend to be productive and generous, and they have a charisma that goes along with that.

3.65 And that charisma, I think, is the charisma of symphonic orchestration in some sense. They're the same at every level of their analysis. You meet them privately, it's the same person you meet publicly. If there's a persona, it's integrated in them. There's no falsity in them. And they just say what they think. That doesn't mean they're right. That's not the point. What you see is what you get. There's no show. There's no instrumental usage. And there's a gravitas to the words of people who are like that that make the words compelling.

3.66 And that's interesting, too. It's like, well, you talk to some people, you just can't listen to them. They're babbling away, and you're thinking about 50 other things. And sometimes, if you have that experience a lot with people, then that's you. You're not listening hard enough for them to actually trust you enough to say anything interesting. But if most of the people—and maybe that's true in the final analysis, I found this in my

clinical practice. If my attention started to wander with a client, then I had to listen more because they weren't receiving the messages from me that indicated that they could really reveal themselves. And so then there was a surface babble that went along with that, and then I would fall out of the conversation. Then I'd have to listen more. It's like, "OK, I have to intensify my attention here." And then that would call out of them, well, generally, was too interesting to bear.

- 3.67** And often the simplest—I had a lot of clients in my practice who were very intellectually impaired, as well as having all sorts of physical and psychological problems. And they often had the most interesting stories, if you could get them to tell their story. Their lives are so hard. And they overcame so many burdens, these simple people, and often had drawn remarkable moral conclusions, despite their, say, intellectual inadequacy. It did not mean at all that they weren't capable of—there is no relationship in the fundamental sense between your intellectual prowess and your moral value. Those things, in fact, they might be antithetical to some degree because the prime temptation of the intellect is Luciferian pride. And so if you're smart and you think you're smart, and maybe you are, it's like, yeah, but how smart are you? How smart do you want to be? It's harder to be humble if you're smarter than everybody else. And so that's the burden you bear that goes along with that talent.
- 3.68** So this emphasis on action, I think, is extremely important. And there's an insistence in Christianity that it's only by God's grace that you're saved, and that works themselves are not an indication of salvation. You think, well, how do you square that with the idea of action? It's like, well, the reason that doctrine arose is because the Christians insisted that just because you were king, that did not mean God favored you over the pauper or the peasant. Certainly not on the ethical domain, and the king was no greater in the kingdom of heaven than the peasant. What that meant was that what you had aggregated around you, or what had been delivered to you by fate, was not an indication of your moral value. One derivative of that thought was, your success is not an indication of your moral quality, and certainly not of your intrinsic quality.
- 3.69** Now, it's tricky because—I think it's tricky because you can get into positions of social power through treachery and manipulateness and Machiavellianism and all of that. So it's not a clear marker. That doesn't mean that there's no positive relationship between your diligent effort—that would be your sacrifices—and your holy orientation. But it's hard to parse those things apart. It's like, just because you're rich doesn't mean you're good. Just because you're powerful doesn't mean you're favored by God. Often the opposite is true. But it's also the case that just because you're successful doesn't mean you're evil. And so it requires discernment to sort these things out.
- 3.70** And you know that. I've been talking to the capitalist types who are all being overwhelmed by the DEI people. And I think, "Why are you so damn guilty?" It's like, you're successful. You've built a business. Hypothetically, you deliver products that people want to your customers, and they're happy enough with you, so they buy again,

and they don't badmouth you and bring your company down. And so it's honest trading. Well, if you garner a billion dollars, it's pretty hard not to be guilty. And you're guilty because you walk down the street, and you see homeless people, and you think, well, "Here I've got all this, and they have nothing. And do I really deserve that? And is society really set up in the justest possible manner?" And the answer to that is clearly no. And then you might say, well, "Are you actually good enough to have a billion dollars without that weighing heavily on your conscience?"

3.71 Because there's another statement. I don't remember if it's in the Sermon on the Mount. "To whom much have been given, much will be demanded." And so that's also, and this is a really good thing to know, people call you on your white privilege, let's say. It's like, well, yeah, you're Americans. You're unbelievably fortunate by historical standards. I come to the States from Canada. Canada is a rich country. This is a much richer country. The infrastructure here is just something miraculous, and that's basically been given to you. And so, should you be guilty about that?

3.72 Well, it was purchased at the cost of a fair bit of blood. So, perhaps. And that's partly why your culture is tearing itself apart, for example, on the issue of slavery. Well, how much of your privilege was purchased at the price of atrocities committed upon others? And the answer is, "Some." And so then you think, well, what do you do about that? It's like, "Justify your privilege." And it isn't "deny it." It isn't "spend it carelessly." It isn't "crush yourself with guilt and emasculate yourself." It's "be grateful for what you've got." And then decide how you're going to take what you have, your talents, in the biblical sense. How are you going to multiply them so that you can say to yourself, when the mob comes knocking at your door, and says, "Have you atoned for your privilege?", you can say, "Yes. Have you?" If you can't do that, the mob—you will allow the mob to convict you.

3.73 And so along with your privilege is a call to conscience. And if you are guilty for what you have, you have to, first of all, you have to ask yourself, maybe you're being too hard on yourself, right? Because we can judge ourselves too harshly. And you can talk to other people and find that out and get that sorted out. But there may be this residual element, is like, well, "I've been pretty fortunate." It's like, well, are you spreading that around enough? And the more fortunate you are, well, obviously, there's a commensurate moral burden there. How could there not be? But then I think that's also a you-can-have-your-cake-and-eat-it-too situation, because if you had a billion dollars, hypothetically, you might be able to do a lot of good with that. And so there's a real opportunity.

3.74 I know a lot of rich people, and maybe I don't hang around with the hedonic types, and that's probably the case. Because there are obviously people who are foolish enough in their wealth to only seek pleasure. But that's not wealth, that's poverty, and not the poverty of spirit we were talking about yesterday. It's a deep spiritual poverty because hedonism is not deep enough to work. It's also self-destructive. I mean, why not take

cocaine all the time? I mean, that's the question. If you can get it and you have the money, why not drink and take cocaine? Why not drink and take cocaine and speed around in fast cars with hookers? Why not? And the answer is, well, it's a rapidly degenerating—one answer is, it's a rapidly degenerating game.

- 3.75** Then also, that's just not going to work when you're in trouble. None of that. None of that hedonism. It's going to get you in trouble. And everyone knows that. It's like, how long are you going to party on the beach? For like, what, a week? Until you're just a husk? It just burns you to a frazzle in no time flat. And so, using your money in that way is its own punishment, clearly. And if you talk to sensible people that have money, conscientious people, they're completely obsessed with what they should be doing about the fact that they have all this money. All they want to do is figure out, jeez, I'd really like to do something useful.
- 3.76** Because once you have your house and you've taken care—really, once you hit something like, let's say, upper-middle class existence, what do you want, a 100-inch TV instead of a 60-inch TV? It's the incremental utility is very low, and you're just as stuck in your Bentley in traffic as you are in your Toyota. Everyone who hits middle class in the US is already, that's about as rich as, in some real sense, that's about as rich in terms of comfort as you can get. And so once you pile up the money after that, you think, well, "I have a moral burden that goes along with it and a responsibility." You by no means want to think that you'd like to have a billion dollars dumped on your doorstep. It's like, first of all, if you're not wise, that money will be gone so fast that you can hardly imagine it, because the criminals and the psychopaths will come flooding in and they will take you out. And so that's a very bad thing.
- 3.77** And even if that's not the case, it's like, you want that responsibility? That's like running a country, to have that much money. And if you do it badly, well, a lot of people are going to get hurt. A lot of people won't get helped, and you're bloody well going to pay. And so it's not an untrammelled benefit by any stretch of the imagination. The psychological literature makes that pretty clear. It's not obvious at all that winning the lottery is fundamentally a good thing for people. At best, they tend to revert to their pre-winning level of happiness and misery. At worst, things just fall apart.
- 3.78** Now you have \$20 million, and all your relatives are poor. Well, how much money are you going to give them? \$20,000? Well, how cheap are you? Well, and if you think that question isn't going to arise, you're not thinking. Well, how far out do you go in the relative web? Then are you helping people or hurting them by helping them in some sense? I helped my son buy a house. I thought, well, "Am I cursing him with this house? Does he really want it?" Maybe he wants the adventure of having to get the house for himself.
- 3.79** It's not that easy to give a gift to someone. That's where the idea of white elephant comes from. The Indian rulers, if they hated someone, they'd give them a white elephant. White elephants were very rare, and they were sacred. It was a great gift. It's

like, have you tried to keep a white elephant? It's, first of all, you can't let it die because it's sacred. And second, it eats like a forest every day. And so you don't want to be given out white elephants. And that can easily happen. You don't want to give too much to your kids. That's a very bad idea. All right.

Lecture 4: Courage and Goodwill

At a glance — Righteousness beyond the letter of the law — courage and goodwill.

- 4.1 "For I say unto you, that except your righteousness shall exceed the righteousness of the scribes and Pharisees, you shall in no case enter into the kingdom of heaven." Very complicated lines again. Scribes and Pharisees, priests and lawyers, for all intents and purposes. So you have to be more moral than a priest, and you have to be more moral than a lawyer. Well, the problem with the lawyers, the way they're represented in the Gospels, is they abide by the letter of the law and contravene the spirit. That's really what happens in some sense if you're a really sophisticated and corrupt lawyer. You subvert justice by utilizing the law, and then you justify it with this Luciferian rationalism.
- 4.2 So that's very, "look, I'm following all the rules. Point to what I did wrong." It's like, well, the spirit that inhabits you is unclean. "Point to what I did wrong. I'm following the rules." It's like, yeah, well, you're not an algorithmic and deterministic machine, and the rules don't apply in this case. And if you were abiding by the spirit of the law and not the letter, that is not the decision you'd make. Well, if you're a good lawyer, you can say, well, here's all the reasons you're wrong, according to the dictates of the law. Of course, lawyers need to do that because they're supposed to rely on precedent rule of law. But there are still corrupt lawyers that do that, and there's good lawyers. And the good lawyers are trying to use the law in the service of what's something transcendent. It's something like justice. And it's justice predicated on the idea that everyone is equal before the law and everyone deserves
- 4.3 their representation before the law. They deserve the presumption of innocence, which is a completely bloody, miraculous presumption. Just try applying it to yourself. It's really hard. If someone accuses you, it's very hard to presume you're innocent first. You really have to learn that. It's very difficult. People will generally convict themselves at a moment's notice. Very bad advocates for themselves, which is why it's such an absolute miracle that we have any societies at all where the legal presumption is you're innocent by presumption, even if you've convicted yourself. That's why you don't have to incriminate yourself by the dictates of your constitution. You can refuse to incriminate yourself.
- 4.4 That's amazing. It's amazing. It's miraculous that you have that right because in many societies, it's like, are you guilty or innocent? Well, you might be guilty. Off with your head because you might be guilty. Not in these biblical societies. It's like, no, no, no. If you're innocent, even if you think you're guilty, that's not good enough. Your innocence is going to be —we're going to fight to establish that you're innocent. And that's something. It's incomprehensible that we figured that out. It's so unlikely, psychologically and socially, especially when you think you're also subject to the whims of tyrants, because tyrants are perfectly happy to call the innocent guilty. That's what

makes them tyrants. And there's no shortage of tyrannical social structures in the history of mankind. That's not a miracle. The miracle is that we ever figured out how to get out of that at all.

- 4.5 And the Pharisees, well, they're the abiders by the law on the religious side in some sense. It's like, "Look how religious I am. I know all the doctrines," right? And Christ says to them that the same spirit inhabits the Pharisees that persecuted the prophets that they worship. That's one of the things that gets him crucified. That's a nasty insult. It's like, you're so religious, are you? Well, the way you act is the same way the people who killed the people you purport to admire acted. That's who you are. It's like, that's a hell of a thing to say, and often true. And it's a violation. If the lawyers are violating the spirit of the law, the Pharisees are violating the dynamic balance between the law and the prophets. And so it makes Christ very unpopular when he levels out those accusations.
- 4.6 And you can tell by looking at the stories that he was a very pointed critic. If he said something like that to people, it struck them to the heart. And then instead of repenting, which would be —the blinder you are to your sin, the more annoyed you are if it's revealed, especially publicly, that's for sure. One thing is to say, "Oh my god, am I really that bad?" And that's a terrible thing to take on. And then it's much easier to say, "No, we got to get rid of you, man." It's you're wrong, you're evil. I'm flawless and blameless in this instance. And that's a tricky thing to get right with the presumption of innocence, too. So.
- 4.7 "Ye have heard that it was said by them of old time, thou shalt not kill; and whosoever shall kill shall be in danger of the judgment." And so this is a psychological transformation of the highest order, this statement. I think it's perfectly reasonable to say that these two lines transformed the entire legal tradition of the West. That's really something for two lines. "But I say unto you, that whosoever is angry with his brother, without a cause, shall be in danger of the judgment; and whoever shall say to his brother, Raca," that means fool, by the way, "shall be in danger of the council. But whosoever shall say, thou fool, shall be in danger of hellfire."
- 4.8 So the issue, the idea here is to be—two issues. Be very careful with your accusations because they will be turned against you. And so you see this on the cancel culture front. I've seen this happen to people time and time again. They'll set out to cancel someone. I've actually tweeted warnings to people, say, "You better not do this because the mob you're pandering to is going to come for you right away." Sometimes that happened the same day. The person will come out and try to cancel someone, and then someone will go and find something they said a year ago and say, "Well, what about you? Here it is." And then they're in even worse shape because they put themselves up as moral arbiters. And all of a sudden, this past instance of misbehavior has come to light.

- 4.9 It's like, so, there is, and people have misread this, too, to say "don't be judgmental." It's like, that's a stupid bit of advice. You want to be unbelievably judgmental in the discriminating sense because your goal is to separate the wheat from the chaff. If you read a great book, it's going to be flawed. Nietzsche is a good example. There's things about Nietzsche's writing, there's statements, especially statements about women, that you might want to just think he was having an off day there, and maybe that's one-half of 1% of the writing. But then you can say, "Well, I found this phrase, and I can just throw away the whole corpus." It's like, well, you're going to throw away Nietzsche? That's your idea? That's your plan? Because you found one thing you disagreed with?
- 4.10 The probability is that he's wrong and you're right. And the probability is that, it's not that you're lazy and don't want to do the reading, it's that you found the key issue here, and now you're morally justified to remain in your ignorance. People do the same thing to thinkers like Freud. Freud is a very good example of that. Or, well, any great thinker for that matter. You justify your ignorance by finding some chaff and saying, "Well, it's all chaff and none of it's wheat." And you want to be judicious, right? And that's what you do when you edit your own writing and when you critically analyze your own thoughts. The judgment is to figure out not what to throw away—you have to—but what to keep.
- 4.11 There's a transformation of the notion of justice here. It's like, well, you killed someone, and the fact that there's a body is the indication that you're the criminal. And so it's the outcome, it's the consequence. But there's a psychologization of that idea here, and it's that, no, we're going to attempt to transform justice into something that's associated with intent, not outcome. And that's, well, you want that, because what if you accidentally kill someone? Is that a crime? Well, the person's dead. The family is not going to be very happy with that. Why shouldn't you just be killed? You run over someone with your car. It's like, well, it was an accident. Maybe you could have been a bit more attentive, but it was an accident. It's like, "I don't care. You killed someone. You're done. You're done."
- 4.12 And the family wants that because their person is dead, and there you are wandering around. Why not just get rid of you? Our answer is something like, "Well, I didn't mean it. That wasn't my intent." And then you think, well, man, we want to have a society that's associated with that principle because, well, then there's some mercy, isn't there? It's like, you get to make a mistake. As long as you're, and this isn't a universal principle, as long as that isn't what you intended, then it's not a crime. Even if it has a cataclysmic consequence. And so you're being judged spiritually. It's the transformation of the justice system from an outcome-oriented orientation.
- 4.13 We're trying to transform that back now. I watch this with just open-mouthed amazement. It's like, well, if you hurt someone's feelings, they get to say, "I'm hurt, and because I'm hurt, you're wrong." It doesn't matter what you think. It doesn't matter what you intended. All that matters is your impact on me. It's like, well, there goes the

presumption of innocence. Do we want to lose that? And there goes the judgment of intent. And god, you want to live in a society where you don't have presumption of innocence and you're not judged by intent? Oh my god, that's so awful. That's—you're at the whim of every accuser then. Satan, by the way, means accuser. That's what the word means. And so you put all the power in the hand of the accuser.

4.14 Well, that's what you want for a society? Anyone anywhere can just bring a casual accusation against you of any sort and just say, "Well, you really hurt me with your careless words"? Maybe it's even true that they were hurt by them. It's like, well, are you guilty? Well, yes. Do you have a defense? No. You don't even get to mount a defense. There's no defense because the defense would be predicated on the idea that you could defend your intent. If you dispense with the whole notion of intent and replace that with outcome, you don't even get to have a defense. You see what I mean? It's not that you're denied a defense. What's being denied is the idea that a defense exists. That's a way worse problem.

4.15 And this is a "judge not, lest ye be judged" warning here, too. And really, the idea there is not don't use judgment. It's not that. It's that, don't damn casually with judgment, because you fail to discriminate the wheat from the chaff. That's a catastrophe. That causes starvation in the most fundamental sense. It's a catastrophe. But also because of the principle of reciprocity, whatever weapon you wield will be turned against you. You know that's the case. If you attack someone, they're going to attack you. Whatever you put out to others is going to be reflected back to you. You might say it's going to be amplified, too, because there's only one of you and there's a lot of other people. If you use your sword in a certain way, then maybe 100 people will come at you with the sword in that manner, and they'll be able to say to you, "We're perfectly justified in using the sword in that manner by your own admission because you use it that way."

4.16 You need—Jung said, it's an old Christian idea, "God rules with two hands, justice and mercy." Justice alone means we all perish because do you really want to get only what you deserve? That's a bad question because you're twisted and bent and you aim at all sorts of terrible things. In a just world, you would pay for that. And if we all paid for that, the ultimate price in some sense, everyone would be found guilty and condemned to perdition. And so we just can't live under those circumstances. But mercy by itself, it's like, "It doesn't really matter what you do. It's OK." It's like, well, actually, no. And you do not want to treat children that way. "Oh, I love you no matter what."

4.17 And I get it. I get the warm, homely, maternal embrace. You're always welcome here, but it has to be tempered. It's like, just because you can go and stay in your room doesn't bloody well mean we're happy with the way you're conducting yourself. And you see that. And children, teenagers in particular, they just die without this, because they want to be held accountable. The reason they need to be held accountable, because what are you holding them accountable to? Well, the standards of society. Well, yeah, for sure. And what teenager wants to be unpopular? Like zero, right? I

mean, it's almost like a pathology of teenagehood that popularity is everything. So you want to hold them to account by a social standard, obviously.

- 4.18 But really what you're holding them account to is their higher potential self. Say, well, you can come and stay, but only insofar as you're trying to put yourself together and manifest what's highest in you. I would say that the maternal spirit, the feminine spirit—and I don't mean women, I mean the feminine spirit—is in some sense the all-encompassing nurturance of an infant. It's like, no matter what your distress is, you're welcome here. But toddlers aren't infants, and certainly teenagers aren't, and men definitely aren't or shouldn't be. To use that attitude towards infants as the fundamental guiding principle of morality itself is to fail to understand the necessity of the judgment element and the encouragement element.
- 4.19 It's like, yeah, we accept you, but get yourself together. Because if we really loved you, it isn't that we love you in all your imperfection. It's more or less that we tolerate you in all your imperfection. What we want from you is far more than that. If you're a good parent, you want more for your children and from your children than you delivered, that's for sure. You want that in the deepest sense, right? Most parents would die for their kids, and I would say, with almost no hesitation. They truly believe their children are more important than they are. And because of that, if you don't mean—if that isn't true for a parent, they're narcissistic. They're just not good parents because that just comes along with the territory.
- 4.20 You know, and it's part of that, the beauty of having children is to finally apprehend something that is clearly, in all ways, more valuable than you. And that's such a relief that you finally stumble across something like that. It's such a relief maybe, shreds the last, some of the last vestiges of your narcissism. But part of what comes along with that, too, is that you want the best for your child because you want the best from them.
- 4.21 "Therefore, if thou bring thy gift the altar, and you remember that thy brother hath ought against thee, leave there thy gift before the altar and go thy way. First be reconciled to thy brother, and then come and offer thy gift." So I really like that. It really informed a lot of my writing about doing small things, making your bed, it's cleaning your room. It's like, you want to prepare yourself for the proper sacrifice. It's like, well, you're going to the church, let's say. You're worshiping the spirit of reconciliation and peace. It's like, but you're fighting with your brother. Well, why don't you do something about that? That's where your duty lies. And maybe you're going to church just to convince yourself that you're a good person so that you don't have to reconcile yourself with your brother.
- 4.22 And then, of course, the question is, too, who exactly is your brother? Because that's a web that can grow and grow and grow. And so Christ is also making an injunction here against something like praying in public. It's like, "Look how good I am." That's activism in a nutshell, almost always. "Look how good I am." It's like, yeah, you're fixing up a lot

of other people by all appearances, but it's not so clear you got the moral authority to do that. And it's pretty damn convenient that Satan is somewhere that isn't you. It's the corporations. I don't care. It's something else, man. It's capitalism. Who knows? It's the successful, it's the oppressor. No, no. It's you.

4.23 That's also part of the Judeo-Christian revolution. I think it applies equally. Well, I don't know enough about other religious faiths to offer a detailed description. You can certainly see it in Islam. It's like the battle between good and evil. You can think about that as between you and the bad people. To some degree, there's some truth in that insofar as you are acting good right now and you can see evil in the world. But it's a little too convenient for my liking. Your best bet is to think, no, I got—I actually got enough problems of my own on the moral front. Then if any of what we've been talking about is true, it's like, if you solve the moral problems on that front, actually, then you will actually be the person that can solve those problems on the familial and the social front.

4.24 And if you're not, then not only will you not solve them, you will 100% make them worse. And so you think, well, I don't have anything important to do. And that makes, especially young people, they think they feel pretty—well, they're at the bottom of the hierarchy in some sense. Not really, because they're young and beautiful. It's like, that's something. You get old and rich. It's like, well, you're old. You'd probably trade the riches for another crack at youth. So it's not so obvious that the young don't have it all over the old. But if you're young, you also want to be rich, which is also a mistake in some real sense. It's like, what do you want? You just want to have it given to you? You don't think that would kill you in two years?

4.25 I mean, students, young students can barely handle going to college. Half of them drink themselves three-quarters to death. What would happen if they had an unlimited supply of money? You see that happening to celebrities often. You don't want all that opportunity before you're halfway ready to bear it. In any case, the idea here is, before you dare to walk into a church in some real sense, or at least to tell other people that you're walking into the church, let's say, even if that's the church of your damnable ideology, there's maybe some practical problems that you should be addressing a little closer to home, and that's exactly what this statement is insisting upon.

4.26 Well, blessed be the peacemaker. That was one of the Beatitudes, if I remember correctly. It's, well, what does that mean? And it's so fun. One of the things that's been really fun in my life is that lots of people have come up to me and said, "I've been listening to your lectures, and I really tried to improve my relationship with my mother or my father. It's really worked." Sometimes they come with that person, and they're both just beaming. They're so thrilled because every child wants a stellar relationship with his or her parents. It's the deepest longing. And every parent wants that from their child. And the gift of parenthood is that you have that opportunity. And if it's fractured and broken, it just wounds people terribly.

- 4.27 And so if you're a son of a father, which, of course, you are, of course, your father is a corrupt tyrant in 15 different ways. It's the lot of mankind. And you're going to be the same to your son. And so what do you do about that is, well, see if you can rectify it. Set that as a goal. My wife did this brilliantly with her father. She decided that she was going to fix her relationship with her siblings and her father. They were pretty good already, but she made that a conscious goal, and man, things just flipped around. It took like three years, but it improved very rapidly, and she just got it all in order. And it's so good for all of them. There's nothing about it that's negative.
- 4.28 People don't generally take that on as a conscious idea, right? Because you carry these resentments along and you don't confront them, and you don't know how, and you don't know that you should. But what would happen if you actually devoted some effort to it? You'd have to say, "Well, I have to get along with this guy. How the hell am I going to do that?" That's a real—and then in some sense, you're trying to figure out how to get along with history, right? Because for better or worse, your father's, in some real sense, the embodiment of the past. And if you can't adapt to the past, well, you can't adapt to the law. You can't adapt to the society. You can't figure out how to update it.
- 4.29 It's good practical practice. And your father is an average guy on average. And so if you can deal with him, then you can deal with the average guy on average. And you'll also find that if you can rectify your relationship with your parents, you can free yourself from confusing them with God. And lots, this is part of the Freudian nightmare, and Jung knew this, too, is that part of the reason you have to parse out God, in some real sense, is so that you don't confuse your father with God. That's very important because you can't let him go, your father, and you can't grow up if he's still God. You're still under his thumb. You see, lots of people are in their 40s. They're still under the thumb of their father.
- 4.30 You think, "Does what your father say matter to you?" "Oh, yeah, a lot. More than anything." "Does he have friends?" "Oh, yes." "Do their opinions matter to you?" "Oh, no, I don't care what they think." It's like, "Why do you care what your father thinks then?" It's like, "He's someone's father's friend, and they don't care about what he thinks. Why do you care?" I get it, right? Well, he's your father. But you get my point. It's like, who do you have your father confused with here? Exactly. And then, are you under his thumb? "Oh, yes, I'm laboring under his tyranny." It's like, that's pretty damn convenient for you because you think that he still knows everything, and that means there's someone out there who knows everything. It's not you. It's part of the benefit for you of being tyrannized is that you don't have to bear any of the responsibility of being an adult. It's a terrifying responsibility.
- 4.31 Freud said, "No man is a man till his father dies." And Jung said, "Yeah, but the death can be symbolic." That's so brilliant. He was so smart. He was so unbelievably smart. Then that's a sacrifice of the father, too, because in some sense, the act of respecting

your father is to not question him deeply. But then that traps you into this subordinate relationship. You have to sacrifice that paternal relationship. But what you gain out of that is a relationship between equals. What he gains out of that is that, as he ages, he has someone who can take care of him. It's definitely beneficial to everyone involved.

- 4.32 The father is also likely to resist that to some degree because no father, although a father would like to see his son surpass him, there's also some pain that goes with that because his success, the son's success, is also an indicator of the inadequacy of the father in some real sense. And that can set up resentment and bitterness. But still, it's still—the true paternal spirit of any father wants the son to exceed the father. So, and that means to take on the responsibility.
- 4.33 "Agree with thine adversary quickly, while thou art in the way with him." That means walking along with him. "Lest at any time the adversary deliver thee to the judge, and the judge deliver thee to the officer, and thou be cast in prison." Now, you see, I don't understand this one well. "Agree with thine adversary quickly, while thou art in the way with him." It has to be—so the way is a very interesting idea because the way is the path of life, to be on the way. I can't find my way. It's the voyage to the right destiny. So it's got to be something like, if you're in the way or on the way with your adversary, then you're walking down the same road. It's got to be something like that.
- 4.34 The adversary is testing you. If you're both in the same place and you can come to an agreement, maybe that's the modification of the manner in which you're conducting yourself instead of the resistance to that. Maybe it's something like, if you're being offered corrective advice by an adversarial judge who has your best interests in mind, then you should accept that as quickly as you possibly can. Yeah, that's got to be what it is. Because otherwise, the resistance that might be generated is something you're going to seriously pay for. Yeah, that's definitely the case. Part of the reason that I have conflict with people, because I don't like conflict at all, is because I know that conflict deferred is conflict multiplied. It's like, we have a fight. It's like, oh my god. Last thing in the world I want to do is fight with you, except fight with you forever.
- 4.35 I have my relationships with my kids and my wife. They're conducted according to this principle and vice versa. It's like, if we have a problem, man, we're going to have it out right now. But why? Well, it isn't because I want to be right, although, of course, I would like to be right because that's convenient. But I would rather be corrected than right. And I guess that's what this means. I'd rather be corrected than right. So I'm willing to take the risk that I might be wrong, even though that's very annoying, because I would rather be corrected. And then the conflict is, do we want peace or do we want war? And war goes on forever. And peace might come at a cost. And the cost is going to be the conflict. But I'd rather do it right now than carry it forever.
- 4.36 Because I've gone into many houses. You go into a house and you just don't want to be there right away. You can just tell that the place is a mess. And the reason it's a mess is because the people who live there cannot agree on anything. Should we throw that out

or keep it? We can't even discuss that. So we've got like, magazines from 1957 because no one can agree that they should be got rid of. It's like the whole house is littered with arguments that haven't happened and the bloody place is stuck in the past, and you walk in there and you think, oh my god, I'd rather be anywhere than here. The place is littered with conflict that hasn't ever happened.

4.37 And in order to sort that out, and I've sorted that out with people over decades, it's like every single one of those deferred arguments has to be had now. And you couldn't even have them one at a time when you were supposed to have them. Now you're supposed to have like 30,000 of them this week because you're on the verge of divorce. And you think, well, it's just easier to divorce. It's like, yeah, except now you find some other poor innocent sucker and saddle them with you. You just drag the whole 30,000 unsolved problems into the life of someone else. And that happens. You're more likely to be divorced the second time than you were the first time. It's very, very hard. This is why, in many ways, divorce just is not a good idea. It's like, "I married the wrong person." It's like, no, they married the wrong person. If you think the other person is the wrong person, you're probably the wrong person.

4.38 Now, I would say, not always, because now and then, and I've had clients like this, too, who got tangled up with someone who—it was just hell. No matter how hard they tried. I watched people break themselves into knots for three or four years, trying desperately, because the custody of their children, for example, is at stake, trying desperately to make peace with their partner. But there is a tiny proportion of people, the psychopathic types, the narcissists, and the borderline personality disorders, the [inaudible] disorder, the true parasitical exploitative criminals. You get tangled up with someone like that, man, you are in serious trouble. But the run-of-the-mill ordinary person, they're no worse than you. And so you might as well hash it out with the person you're with because probably you're just going to drag your damn problems into the next domain anyways.

4.39 And so Jung talked about this in relationship to marriage as a container, an alchemical container of transformation. If you want something to transmute, you have to subject it to heat. And so why do you swear not to leave? So you're stuck with the person. It's like, "I'm stuck with you. Oh my god. And it's even worse for you because you're stuck with me. And so what an awful situation that is. We don't get to run away. And so we're either going to fight or we're going to solve this." But there's also, there's something in there that's so interesting because imagine you need to reveal yourself to someone else, to you too. And that means you have to reveal what you do not want to reveal, like the terrible aspects of you. And they're terrible. If that person can run away, they will.

4.40 And so if they can run away, well, then you can't reveal yourself. And if you can't reveal yourself, well, how can you improve? And you're not even in a relationship. And one of the really lovely things about an actual marriage is you can tell your partner the truth.

You make a mistake, maybe it's a financial mistake. You were greedy and careless. Maybe it's enough. It's going to take down the bloody household because you're such a fool. And now you're just torturing yourself to death. And if you're fortunate, you have a partner and you can go say, "Here's what I did. And sorry, it wasn't good." And if she has any sense, she's going to tear a strip off you to find out why you're such an idiot. But at least you can say it, and maybe now you can jointly figure out a way to not make it a complete bloody catastrophe. And then you're not alone in hell.

4.41 And hopefully you can return the favor because the probability that she's going to do something equally stupid and reprehensible might not be quite as high, but it's certainly up there. And so then now, because she's offered you that reprieve, you can offer the same thing, and you can stumble together, honestly, upward. And you can. That works. It's definitely the case that people are better off in a marriage. All the evidence supports that. They're certainly better off sexually by a huge margin, but they're better off in every way. And it's clearly the case that children are way better off in an intact family. And the data on that are so clear that to state that that isn't the case is really—it's a willful blindness that borders on the malevolent.

4.42 So, "Verily I say unto thee, thou shalt by no means come out thence, till thou has paid the uttermost farthing." God, there's no more terrifying line, I think, in the Sermon on the Mount than that one, is that you do not get away with anything. So you know that household with the 30,000 unpaid fights? It's like, well, we didn't fight. It's like, yeah, but by avoiding, first of all, the chickens will come home to roost. And you think, well, do you believe this? Well, the alternative is this. I can take the fabric of reality and I can bend it and distort it and warp it and falsify it, and I can get away with that, and there'll be no repercussions. Well, who do you think you are? It's like, reality is that which you cannot distort. By definition, it's fleeting. If you can manipulate it, it's fleeting.

4.43 The deepest layers of reality, that's existence itself. It's being itself. And to have the presumption that you can use deception, that you can avoid, even through a sin of omission, much less an outright lie, that you can get away with that, it's like two questions. Who do you think you are? Or, what is it that is inhabiting you that you've let had its way with you that allows you to think that? And that's an even worse question. So for example, when God calls Cain out for complaining about the structure of reality, God says, well, here's really how it worked. You're having a miserable time, unlike Abel, who's doing well and everything. Here's how it really worked.

4.44 You didn't work nearly as hard as you could have. And you know it. You didn't make the right sacrifices. They were second-rate, your sacrifices, and you know it. And now, instead of taking responsibility for that, you're blaming God. And so that seems somewhat inappropriate, let's say, to say the least. But worse than that, while you're suffering because of your own stupidity, which you could realize if you would be willing to admit it, something is crouching at your door. It's sin in the Cain story. And it's represented metaphorically as a predatory, sexually aroused animal. God says, "And

you invited it in?" Which meant it could not come in unless you invited it, just like a vampire at the window. You have to open the door to evil. Then it doesn't just possess you. It interacts with you sexually, creatively. You brood upon the interaction with the spirit of evil, and you generate something creative as a consequence. And that's what you've done instead of improve yourself. So that's what God tells Cain.

4.45 And that makes Cain so angry. And no wonder, right? I mean, man, that's rough. That's brutal. It's just like the the Band-Aids are torn off, man. It's the judgment of God. And that makes Cain so angry that he kills Abel and precipitates a war, essentially. And that's the story of mankind. So. "Till thou has paid the uttermost farthing." So there's this idea that fear of God is the beginning of wisdom. And one element of that is, if you know you can't get away with anything—in fact, that payment deferred is payment multiplied—then that's one of the things that can scare you straight. It's very hard to learn that because there's part of you that thinks, "I can just bend this a little bit. No one will notice." It's like, I've never seen it work.

4.46 What do you do in a clinical practice in some part is people's lives—they meet the devil at the crossroads and they make the wrong choice. And they know it when they make it. They might hide it from themselves, but they know. Yeah. Then they forget. Then they cover it up. Nietzsche says, "If pride comes into conflict with memory, then pride wins." You rewrite your past, so you obliterate the moral error. Part of what you do in therapy is you think, "Well, OK, when did things start going wrong?" It's not necessarily that you were the fault. Sometimes people are tortured, but you want to find out, partly because you're trying to help the person sort themselves out. It's like, well, when did this all start?

4.47 You go back and you have them tell their story, and you go back, and you go back, and then you find a choice point and you think, well, "You turned left and you were supposed to turn right." And then the person thinks, "Yeah, you know what? I knew it at the time." It's like, "Yeah, yeah, you knew it at the time. And you didn't attend." When Moses walks by the burning bush in the desert, he looks and he keeps walking. And then he thinks, "No, I'm going to look." And that's when God reveals himself. It's the same thing here. It's like, you're hovering on a choice and you know that I shouldn't go there. But you don't allow yourself the revelation. You don't allow yourself to think it through. You just think, "No, I can do this."

4.48 It's like, this is true. "You shall by no means come out thence." And that's the desert, after the tyranny, or it's the tyranny. "Till thou has paid the uttermost farthing." It's like, oh my god, really? It's like, yeah, really. "Ye have heard that it was said by them of old time, thou shalt not commit adultery. But I say unto you that whosoever looketh upon a woman to lust after her hath committed adultery with her already in his heart." Well, just because you can't sleep with everyone because they don't want you doesn't mean you're not a slut. That's really what this means, right? And so it's harsh, again. It's like, the mere fact that all the women in the world don't find you attractive enough to sleep

with you instantly is not a testament to your moral virtue if the desire for that is still there.

- 4.49 And so this is another recasting of the idea of intent, right, and maybe the harsher consequence of making justice intent-based rather than outcome-based. So you don't sleep around promiscuously. Well, you can't because no one wants you, but you want to. Well, then it's the same sin. It's the same sin. Well, you can decide for yourself whether or not you think that's true.
- 4.50 "And if the right eye offends thee, pluck it out and cast it from thee, for it is profitable for thee that one of thy members should perish and not that thy whole body should be cast into hell. And if thy right hand offend thee, cut it off cast it from thee, for it is profitable for thee that one of thy members should perish and not that thy whole body should be cast into hell." Well, this is a separation of the wheat from the chaff ideas, right? You're making sacrifices. And it's very painful to learn something. The reason for that is, you have a complete model of the world all the time. That's why you're not terrified. You believe at the moment in some fundamental sense that you've mapped the world enough, and that's why you're not anxious. You think, I know enough to be sitting safely.
- 4.51 But your model of the world is by no means 100% accurate, and so you get out and you learn something new. And that means you have to retool something you already knew. So there's no progress without death and repentance in some real sense. "Oh, I was wrong, or at least I was inadequate. If not outright wrong, at least I was inadequate." You have to sacrifice something and let something go to improve. And that's really what this means, is that, better to sacrifice the part than to cling to the part desperately and end up sacrificing the whole. And it's a sacrificial motif, again. You have to make sacrifices. That's what work is. That's how you adapt to the world and to the future. You have to make sacrifices.
- 4.52 Well, what do you sacrifice? Unworthy parts of yourself. Well, what if it's your eye and you hold it in, what? You value it. Well, often it's the things you value most that you have to sacrifice that are the biggest impediments to your progress forward. You certainly see that in arguments. If you have a real vicious argument with someone and you're wrong, the reason you're defending it is because you really value the thing you don't want to give up. But then the problem with that is it's actually your worst enemy. If you value it highly and it's wrong, that's why Christ uses the example of the eye, the right eye and the right hand. That's the hand you use for everything. Better it goes than the whole thing. And so
- 4.53 that's also extremely useful to know. It's like, die a little. Die a little all the time, so you don't have to die a lot now and then, or die completely. And that's really thinking. We have biologists who study thinking. We create avatars of ourselves and we act them out in imagination so we can kill them instead of us before we embody them. And so that thought is a sacrificial process. Let's generate some variants of ourselves. Maybe we'll

even value the variants, but we're willing to kill them so they can die. Painfully, right? Your whole system of thought can die, better than that you die. And sometimes your whole bloody system of thought has to die. That's very painful, right? You just collapse into complete chaos.

- 4.54 That's the movement from the tyranny into the desert. And you're moving towards the promised land. It's like, "Out of the tyranny, into the promised land." It's like, "No, out of the tyranny, into the desert." And it's by no means obvious that the desert is better than the tyranny. God only knows how long you'll be lost there. And so it's no wonder you don't want to drop your tyrannical presuppositions, but you want to be a slave and be worked to death for nothing? Because that's the tyranny option.
- 4.55 "It hath been said, whosoever shall put his wife away, let him give her writing of divorcement. But I say unto you, that whosoever shall put away his wife, saving for the cause of fornication," so that would be unfaithfulness, "causes her to commit adultery, and whosoever shall marry her that is divorced, committeth adultery." That's a rough one for modern people. Well, it's God talking, hypothetically. It's not like he's going to ask you to do easy things. You might think, well, how should we think this through? Is divorce allowable? I don't consider myself the authority who can pronounce on that, but I already told you Jung's view on the sanctity of marriage. It's like, it has to be a vow because it's not real otherwise, if there's an escape route. When you're pushed, you will take it. You'll take it either psychologically or practically.
- 4.56 It might be the case that, just at that moment when you really should transform, you'll take the easy way out. Divorce definitely allows that as a possibility. Now, I say that with some trepidation because I have seen people, as I've said, one client in particular who got tangled up with someone who had borderline personality disorder. I really liked him. He was a good guy. I went out with him and his kids a lot because he wanted to have custody of his little kids. He was an excellent father. Good hard-working professional. He was a conscientious guy and pretty strict and dutiful. I suppose that maybe that would have rubbed some people, especially her, the wrong way.
- 4.57 I worked with him for five years trying to figure out how to negotiate with this woman who was willing to burn everything, including herself. She just tore through her father's, her parents' retirement savings, suing her husband for money he didn't possess. And so it sunk them, and they actually deserved it because she was tangled up with her father in a way that just should not have been. So I won't tell you that story. But I've been with people who've been with partners that were incorrigible. And so I would have never said to them—although it's tough, right, because it isn't obvious to me that his life was easier because he divorced her. Now, I think she initiated the divorce because that's the case in 70% of divorces, by the way.
- 4.58 So I don't feel like I'm in any position to say, well, you're doomed to your marriage. But I can make the counter-position, which is, it's an all-in game, just like your life. If you're not all in in your marriage, you're not married. There's a real cost. You will absolutely

pay a cost for that. The cost is you will not be able to communicate with your partner. You will not be driven to that level of desperation. Because the only thing that can drive you to that level of desperation is inescapability. You know, I'm either going to make peace with you or we're stuck with each other. It's like, it's hard to make peace. It's very, very difficult with yourself or with someone else. So.

4.59 "Again, you've heard that it hath been said by them of old time, thou shalt not forswear thyself, but shalt perform unto the Lord thine oaths. But I say unto you, swear not at all; neither by heaven, for it is God's throne; nor by the earth, for it is his footstool; neither by Jerusalem, the heavenly city on the hill, for it is the city of the great king. Neither shalt thou swear by thy head, because thou canst not make one hair white or black. But let your communication be, yea, yea, yes, yes, no, no, for whatsoever is more than these cometh of evil."

4.60 You hear you shouldn't swear, which people tend to think means you shouldn't say four-letter words. That is only what this means in the most tiny and peripheral sense, if at all; that's not what it means. It means that you don't have a right to swear by God that you will do good, because who the hell are you exactly, say, to make that claim, that you can carry that moral burden? And so the injunction here is, don't claim to abide by moral principles that you are not in a position to uphold. A little humility with regards to your claims goes, "I'm acting in the highest principle." It's like, "I swear I'm acting in the highest principle." First of all, you're going to distrust someone who says that right off the bat.

4.61 Maybe what you want to hear is, like, "Look, I'm doing my best. Here's what I'm aiming at. I'm probably an idiot. If I'm being an idiot, maybe you could point it out, and I'll try to change, and I won't do a very good job." That's a good attitude in your marriage, by the way. One of the things my wife and I learned—this was really helpful—if you're arguing with someone, it's incumbent on you to figure out what would satisfy you. It's like, hypothetically, "You don't agree with me; what could I do in principle to satisfy you?" "Well, if you loved me, you'd know." It's like, "No, I'm stupid. I don't know. You probably hardly know. I don't even know what would satisfy me half the time." "If I could offer you what you wanted, what would it be? Can you tell me?" "Can I tell you that, badly? I don't mean falsely. I'll try to do it right, but I'm not going to do it perfectly. I'll give you what you want, stupidly. Maybe if I do it 50 times, you'll get what you want because I'll practice."

4.62 That's extremely useful. There's a humility in that, too, that you're not offering more than you can offer, but that doesn't mean you have to offer nothing. So there's an injunction to simplicity of speech here. And that's very important, I would say, in the modern world, too, because people claim continually, for example, to be motivated by world-redeeming ideologies. "I'm standing for the poor." It's like, really? Have you ever tried helping someone who is poor? Like, actually helping them? Because first of all, the first thing you find out is that poverty is rarely caused by lack of money. It's way more

complicated than that. In fact, and it's not obvious at all, I've dealt with lots of people who were poor. Some of them were drug-addicted. If they had money, they were just done.

- 4.63 I had one client. I really liked him. He was a pretty simple-minded guy, janitor at a hospital. He eventually died from his troubles. As long as he had no money, he was OK. As soon as he got his disability check, his psychopathic friends came to visit, and they were on a cocaine and alcohol binge for three days, and he was face-down in the ditch, and that's what money did for him. When someone's poor like that, helping them is really hard because they're not poor because they lack money. It's a way worse problem than that. Now, money is not that easy to deal with, and it's a terrible temptation if you're not oriented properly.
- 4.64 "You have heard that it has been said, an eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth." That sounds barbarous to us, but one of the things you want to understand is that when that law came along, that was merciful, because the rule was, well, "you kick me and I kill you." Disproportionate response. And so the justice in this law was, no, no, justice is when you're paid back what you're owed only in kind and nothing more than that. And so it was a real limitation on vengefulness. But this is a transformation of that because the idea here is, well, that was an improvement, an eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth. At least it's proportional, right? But maybe that's not as good as it could get. And how could it be better?
- 4.65 "But I say unto you, that ye resist not evil; but whosoever shall smite thee on thy right cheek, turn to him the other also. And if any man will sue thee at the law and take away thy coat, let him have thy cloak also. And whosoever shall compel thee to go a mile, go with him twain. Give to him that asketh thee, and from him that would borrow of thee, turn not away." That's a rough one, too. You can see this, I think, more straightforwardly when you think about how you're dealing with people with whom you don't have any enmity. It's like, well, we played that trading game yesterday, and I suggested that if you're a little more generous than you might be in a trading game, that's pretty damn good for your reputation.
- 4.66 And so you might think, well, maybe when you're asked to do something, you should do a little more, or maybe you should do a lot more. Maybe you should do as much as you could more. Now, that means you don't want to exhaust yourself and martyr yourself in that endeavor because you'd just wear yourself out that way. It's the danger of trait agreeableness, let's say. But you can understand that the principle of going the extra mile might be an unbelievably useful iterative ethical principle. Then you might ask, well, how far does that extend? Do you only do that with your family? Do you do that with your friends? Do you do that with strangers?
- 4.67 Now look, if you run a business, you do that with strangers. That's what makes you rich if you're not being corrupt. It's like, not only will you get what you pay for from me, but you'll get it faster than you think you will. It'll be a reasonable price, and it'll be of

higher quality than you expect. That is definitely the pathway to success in a business. One of the things I've really noticed about businesses is that word of mouth is insanely important, especially on the negative side. Here's rule number one, if any of you are entrepreneurial. Rule number one: Do not annoy your customers. Never. One annoyed customer is a thousand people who will no longer trade with you because if they're really annoyed, they will tell everyone they know. And so, a thousand people tell a thousand people. That's a million people. And you can generate a million-people-worth of bad will by making a real bad mistake in your entrepreneurial venture. You only have to do that.

4.68 We went into a video store once, a friend of mine and I. Friend was quite disagreeable. The clerk was just, he was the owner, too. He was just unbelievably rude. My friend, who was much more disagreeable than me at that point, said he didn't take that sort of thing ever. He said, "Look, what the hell do you think you're doing? We came into your store to rent one of your videos. This is a video rental store. Hypothetically, that's what you're here for, and we're doing what you want us to do. What do you think is going to happen if you treat people this way?" Now, I don't know why he was—maybe he thought, "Oh, what the hell am I doing in a video store? I'm destined for better things than this. Who are these contemptible people who have nothing better to do than to waste their time with petty entertainment?" Something like that. So he's really nasty.

4.69 My friend told him, it's like, "Look, with an attitude like that, you haven't got a hope in hell of having this business run." It was closed in three months. Because partly we told everyone. It's like, "Hey, don't go in that video store." It's not like there aren't a bunch of other ones or other alternatives. It's like, don't annoy your customers. Do you go the extra mile? Yes. It might be the case with this new venture I'm starting with my son. He is looking at all the comments, and some of them are bitchy. It's like, well, maybe you're just having a bad day or maybe you're a narcissist, but maybe you're complaining about something that one-tenth of 1% of our customers would complain about. And so maybe we can rectify that, because maybe you're a canary in the coal mine, even if you're neurotic and touchy. And maybe we could respond to you in a way that showed you that, despite the fact that you were rude and corrosive, your concern was actually attended to.

4.70 And then maybe we could convert you. And if you convert someone that way, if they start by being your enemy, and they're a little ashamed maybe about how vehement they were in their opposition, and you respond positively to them, then maybe you convert them into an ally. When you convert someone like that, they're a way better ally because they want to pay for their sin in some sense. I mean, you don't do this instrumentally. This isn't a game. Not at all. If it's a game, it isn't going to work. But if you make it a part and parcel of your business is that your critics might not be your enemies. When the comedians we talked about yesterday go practice their jokes, the people who don't laugh aren't doing them a disfavor. It's like, they're telling them it's

not funny, and they need to know that. It's like, well, this doesn't work for me. Well, it's one in a million. Maybe we can ignore you. And you make those decisions. If there's a hundred complaints, you take that more seriously than if there is one.

4.71 But still, how do you know that your enemy isn't attempting to improve you? At least in some sense. And maybe you could get so good at dealing with your enemies that you convert them into friends. And do you really want an enemy? The answer might be, yeah, because I need somewhere to put Satan in some sense. But it's not that pleasant having enemies. And they can make your life miserable, especially if they're willing to make their life miserable at the same time. And so this is a call to a very high moral position.

4.72 "You've heard that it hath been said, Thou shalt love thy neighbor, and hate thine enemy. But I say unto you, love your enemies. Bless them that curse you, do good to them that hate you, and pray for them which despitefully use you, and persecute you." That's good. I've had my fair share of enmity, I would say, directed toward me. One of the ways that I've dealt with that, to the degree that I've been able to deal with it, let's say credibly, and I wouldn't say I always have, is I'd rather not have enemies. I'd rather not have even the people who think they're my enemies, I'd rather not have them suffering brutally and unnecessarily. Because you think, well, "Enemies, off to hell with them. They should suffer and they deserve it." I think, no, there's enough suffering. If someone who's in hell already is burning even hotter, it's not like that's going to make things better. It'd be better if we didn't have enemies.

4.73 I mean, it's convenient in some sense, like I said, because then you have a place to put malevolence and misbehavior and all of that. But do you want enemies? Probably not. Then what do you want for your enemies? Well, how about you want them to not be enemies? And not enemies of themselves, and maybe not enemies of being. You love your enemies because you want to bring them into the fold. That doesn't mean you dispense with separating the wheat from the chaff. In fact, part of, I would say, rectifying the state of enmity is to separate the wheat from the chaff in a very discriminating way. Partly why it's so useful to have across-the-aisle conversations, or conversations with people you disagree with, because you have to get right down to brass tacks. You have to make very fine discriminations. Part of peacemaking is precisely that making of fine discriminations.

4.74 You find that with kids. If you're having a conflict with a three-year-old pushing back against you, you make fine discriminations of discipline to establish peace. The more you interact with the child, the more you push back against each other, the more precisely, same in a relationship, you negotiate those boundaries. Then the more sophisticated people become, and the more secure they feel, within the boundaries. A fair bit of that can be managed by taking that which comes at you as an enemy as something that can be redeemed in you and in other people.

- 4.75 "For if you love those who love you, what reward have you? Do not even the publicans do the same?" So he's saying that, if love is just instrumental, well, I'll treat you well just because you treat me well. Well, that's not so bad, but it's not, it's not as good as—look, naive people think everyone's good. Then you get burned. Then you think, OK, I see. I'm not going to just trust you because I know I could get burned. But well, then what do I do? Do I distrust you? Am I skeptical about you? We can't trade then. What you do beyond that is like, I know you're full of snakes, but let's see if we can do something together. It's courage and the extension of goodwill, despite knowledge of potential catastrophe and enmity.
- 4.76 What's so cool about that is, well, you'd better do that, because everyone's full of snakes. But even more importantly, even if someone is pretty damn twisted, if you're not naive and you approach them in a spirit of courageous trust—and I've done this with people who are very oriented in a criminal way, and even people bordering on psychopathy—if you're straight with them, like 100% straight. It's very dangerous with people who are touchy and psychopathic because they fly off the handle in no time flat. If there's any falsity in your approach, you're in serious trouble because they are hyperalert, especially if they're paranoid to falsity. If you can extend your hand in courageous trust without being naive, that's the highest probability you have of walking that pathway with them without mutual disaster.
- 4.77 That's a good thing to know. If you ever meet someone who's dangerous, especially if they're paranoid, do not lie to them. As soon as you lie, they'll catch you because they're hypervigilant. As soon as you lie, you're done. You're in the enemy camp and you do not want to be—I had a client, he was paranoid. He had four restraining orders against him. He said someone would give him—some persona-obsessed, mid-level bureaucrat would give him a rough time in a bank. He would say, "I'm going to be your worst nightmare." And he meant it. Now and then, this is something to know, now and then you'll run into someone like that, and you'd better be prepared. It's clearly the case there's nothing better in that situation than honesty. I don't think I've ever met someone who that didn't work with and sometimes under extremely dire circumstances. So that's a good thing to know.
- 4.78 Don't be thinking you're not going to pull the wool over the eyes of a career psychopath. That is just not going to work. And if you play the lying game casually, it's like, first of all, they think, "Who do you think I am, to be sucked in by that?" And secondly, they think, "That's the best you've got?" It's like, "You don't know who you're dealing with here. I've been practicing that for 40 years. You're a rank amateur. I can see right through you."
- 4.79 "If you salute your brothers only, what do you do more than others? Do not even the publicans do so? Be ye, therefore, perfect, even as your Father, which is in heaven, is perfect." That's a rough one. But again, it has to do with this idea of orienting yourself to the city on the hill. That's right. You want to aim as up as you can manage. And that's

that, I don't know, maybe that's as close to perfection as you can get, right, to sharpen your aim, because maybe you can't hit the target, but at least you can bloody well aim right. And so that's in some real sense, what is it? Manifest the courageous spirit of your ancestors. That's "even as your father, which is in heaven," is perfect.

- 4.80 In the shamanic traditions, before the shaman, who often takes psychedelic medications, before they enter the realm of heaven and speak with the gods, they confer with their ancestors. The spirit of the god, the spirit of god, it's like the good that's common to the ancestral heroes in some real sense. That might even be true, metaphysically and ontologically, is that the spirit that animates good men is the spirit of good. We don't know what reality the spirit of good has. It has a certain, it has some form of reality. Maybe it's not a material reality, and maybe it is. I don't know. It definitely exists.
- 4.81 You want to allow that spirit to inhabit you, and that's part of that motif of rescuing your dead father from the belly of the beast. That also means that the beast is something terrible to apprehend and to behold. It also means that if you're willing to confront the beast, you find the spirit of your dead father and reanimate it. And that's really something to know. It's like, that's in you. The greatness of the past. That's in you, obviously, because it manifested itself in the past. How do you call it out? By facing the dragon. And so that's a great thing to know. You find the best in you by facing the worst. And how could it be any other way? What else would call the best out in you? It's only the worst that calls for the best. So it just seems like a straightforward proposition when you think about it that way.

Lecture 5: Aligning With the Divine

At a glance — Matthew 6 — aligning oneself with the divine.

- 5.1 good morning, everyone. So we'll start with Matthew 6 today, and we're about two-thirds to three-quarters of the way through, which is good, since we have one more day tomorrow. And so that's about where we should be. "Take heed that you do not do your alms before men, to be seen of them; otherwise, you have no reward of your Father, which is in heaven." It's very difficult to imagine that there could be a line more apropos to today's world, I would say, because
- 5.2 this is the "do not pray in public" injunction. And the question is, well, what does that exactly mean? And I would say, well, it's an injunction against virtue signaling. It's like, if, while you're doing good, you're simultaneously and immediately demanding recognition for doing so, then you have to ask yourself, are you after the recognition here, or are you trying to do good? And so the idea here is that, well, why don't you try doing it in secret, just so you can be sure that you're not exposing yourself to moral hazard, right?
- 5.3 Because you got to be skeptical, at least to some degree, of your own motives, because what makes you so pure? And one of the things that's really irritated me to no end about modern universities is that they basically teach young people the opposite of this, which is, well, you want to change the world, which—so the psychologist, Jean Piaget, brilliant developmental psychologist, the most brilliant developmental psychologist, and also a constructivist, which is interesting. So Piaget wasn't, although he's a biologist, he really didn't delve into the biological substructure of human perception and action. He believed that much of what we brought to bear on the world was, in fact, learned. But, and
- 5.4 so, Piaget is someone who the constructivist types, the Postmodernists and so forth, and the social radicals, should listen to, because in many ways he shares a lot of their philosophical presuppositions. He's no biological essentialist. So Piaget believed, for example, that part of our morality emerged as a consequence of the necessity of playing repeating games with other people, right? That there would be a natural morality that would emerge out of reciprocity and that that was socially constructed. Now, it turns out there's also a biological platform for that, because it's been going on for so long that not only does it emerge socially, but we're prepared for it biologically, just like we are prepared to learn language, even though we learn language socially.
- 5.5 In any case, one of—Piaget was also a stage theorist, and he believed that, in some sense, you would develop a system of representation of the world and then see the world through that. And then that system would undergo revolutionary transformations, some of them deeper than others. And like, it's very much akin to Thomas Kuhn's ideas, for example, about scientific revolutions. And so as we mature,

we reorganize ourselves in a kind of revolutionary way, and that's how we proceed forward. The last stage of development for Piaget—no psychologists ever talk about this and they don't seem to even know about it, which is quite strange to me—was Piaget believed that in late adolescence, in the transition from adolescence to adulthood, there is a messianic phase, now that not everybody goes through.

- 5.6 But you could think about it in some sense, too, as imagine that, to move from childhood to teenagehood, you have to stop caring about your parents so much, which is why teenagers in some sense rebel and start caring way more what other people think of you. And that's maybe a downside to teenagers, because they care so much what other people think. In fact, that's pretty much all they care about. But actually, it's appropriate developmentally because you're trying to move away from your parents who've protected you, and you can't just go out in the world and be an autonomous individual, especially if you can't get along with other people. And so you can use your peer group as a bridge.
- 5.7 You know, you have, it's your tribe in some sense. It's not a replacement for your parents, but it's another sheltering system. And then in order to be integrated into that peer group, you have to learn to get along with other people, which you should learn. Just like even if you're a star athlete, you still have to be a team player, you know? And you're not a real star unless you're a team player. You're just a highly skilled narcissist, which, you know, you can get some distance with that, but it's not optimal. In any case, Piaget knew that the move from the teenage desire to fit in above all else to autonomous individuality had this powerful motivational push behind it. And it was something like the desire to discover your individual destiny and to find your place in the world. And so there's that, well, he called that a messianic urge. "How can I save the world?"
- 5.8 And that's sort of, how can I serve being in the largest sense? That's sort of the instinctual basis for that. And so it's where that young people who are making the transition to adulthood should start thinking about their place in the broader world, but they don't know anything. They've been dependent on their parents their whole life. They might think they're successful because they're not suffering, but it's, well, that's because your parents were rich, and so was your society. It's not like you did it all by yourself. And so you don't want to delude yourself into thinking that your security and even peace of mind is a consequence of your own moral virtue. And there should definitely be some gratitude in that.
- 5.9 And so what happens when students go to university is that the people who teach them say, "Oh, man, you're ready to go, and the whole system is just corrupt. And with your youthful enthusiasm, you should and could change the world." And then the way to do that is to identify the evildoers and to protest against them. And there's no difference between that and praying in public. It's the same thing. And this is an injunction precisely against that. And the idea here is that if you're trumpeting your

virtue, especially if you've set yourself up as a moral avatar with none of the preconditions, it's like, you know what you're like when you're—there's some really disciplined 18-year-olds, but most of those people are nowhere near as disciplined as they're going to get, even if they're already disciplined.

- 5.10** And then your run-of-the-mill 18-year-old is just not disciplined at all. I used to ask my students regularly—we'd run through an economic exercise, like, how much time do you waste every day? And the median answer was 8 hours. And so I'd go through an economic analysis. What's your time worth? They'd figure much less than it's worth. Undergraduates' time is probably worth \$50 an hour. I mean, they couldn't make that right then. But, you know, your time when you're young, you can spend preparing yourself for the rest of your life. And so, even if you can't get paid for your time now, that doesn't mean it's not valuable. Your time when you're young might be more valuable than any other time in your life because everything flows from that. So \$50 an hour, especially for someone who's smart and young, is not an overestimate. It's probably a radical underestimate.
- 5.11** So it's like, well, that's \$400 a day, it's \$3,000 a week, it's \$12,000 a month, it's \$150,000 a year. So that's what you're doing. You're wasting, you're literally wasting \$150,000 a year with your absolute inability to do anything but waste 8 hours a day. And that's like, probably takes you 4 hours a day just to keep yourself alive, you know, to eat and cook and shop and clean and all that. And so, you're only awake for 16 hours. And so you're wasting literally two-thirds of your life. But you're a protester. It's like, really? Really? That's how you're setting yourself up here?
- 5.12** You're going to go out and complain about what the evil capitalists and the satanic mills and, you know, the despoliation of the planet by the industrial economy, and you don't know how anything works. You've never had a job. You're completely undisciplined. You've never had a family, probably haven't had a successful long-term relationship, right? You're just a pup. And your idiot professors are telling you, well, not only is the world so corrupt that you should do nothing but complain about it, but that you're actually the person that should be doing that.
- 5.13** And then there's no indication whatsoever of—I used to talk to my professor colleagues about this all the time. It's like, what? Why are you beating the activist drums? Like, these kids, they don't know anything. That's why they're in university and you're supposed to be teaching them, not telling them that they already know, and just because they can get in touch with their own idiot pity that they're somehow moral avatars in the world and that that's the noblest thing they could be doing. It's like, well, hence, we're in this current situation. And back to the Sermon on the Mount.
- 5.14** "Take heed that you do not do your alms before men, to be seen of them; otherwise, you have no reward of your Father, which is in heaven." So, and this is, again, this issue of aping moral virtue. So here's something to think about. So, competent, conscientious, creative, industrious people—and that would include the managers and

the entrepreneurs and the scientists and the artists —are productive and generous, and as a consequence, both of those. Productive. The best definition of Christian charity I ever read was productivity and generosity. Both, right? Not just generosity, and certainly not just generosity with other people's money.

- 5.15** Once the idea of reputation can be established, let's say, so what's more important to anyone than anything else is their reputation. And the proper way to build a reputation is through productive generosity. And that means that people can be known to be productive and generous. And people who are productive and generous are often confident with the kind of confidence that competence bestows upon them. But that opens up an avenue for manipulators. And the avenue is to ape competence, to act like you're competent when you're not, or productive and generous, say, when you're not. And that's what narcissists and Machiavellians and psychopaths do.
- 5.16** Like psychopaths, for example, they tend to be low in trait neuroticism. They tend to be rather fearless. And one of the things that marks someone as competent is that they're confident. And that means they lack anxiety, for example. And so a narcissist can act competent, and a narcissist, technically—this is high in extroversion and low in agreeableness and low in neuroticism, OK? And if you add low conscientiousness to that, you get someone who's bordering on psychopathic. Because they're charismatic, they're fearless, they're only out for themselves, and they're completely—they won't do what they say they're going to do. They're completely —that's the conscientiousness side of it.
- 5.17** And so the narcissists and the Machiavellians and the psychopaths, they ape competence. And so there's a niche there. Once you set up a reputational structure that's supposed to benefit people who are competent, you can game it, and the narcissists game it. And the best way to game it is to pretend that you're good when you're not. And the best way to do that is to do this, is to do all your good deeds in public and to call attention to them. And so that's why the emphasis here is to do it privately, right? And to do it at least until you've got yourself under control. You know, there's a bit of a conflict between that and the idea of being a light on the hill, right? But you want to avoid moral hazard.
- 5.18** "Therefore, when thou doest thine alms, do not sound a trumpet before thee, as the hypocrites do in the synagogues and in the streets, that they may have glory of men. Verily I say unto you, they have their reward. But when thou doest alms, let not thy left hand know what thy right hand doeth; that thine alms may be in secret; and thy father, which seeth in secret himself shall reward thee openly." You can see also that that's an antidote to narcissism, too, is you want to do the right thing. And maybe you also want to see how that works without having to compel everyone to view it, you know, which is, that's a danger to you, too, because you don't want to have your status—you do not want to have your status elevated beyond your competence. That's a big mistake. It's a real temptation, right, to have that happen.

- 5.19 But you don't want to be put in a position by yourself or other people in a hierarchy of competence and authority before you're bloody well ready. And so this is another call to radical humility, even on the side of doing good. So there's a call to subtlety here, you know, and to, well, certainly this whole section is an anti-narcissism section, fundamentally. "Do not let thy left hand know what thy right hand doeth." It's so interesting because there's even some emphasis here that you might want to even go so far as you keep the good things that you're doing secret from yourself, you know, because why is that? Well, can you trust yourself? That's right. Can you trust yourself not to aggrandize yourself, even if you are doing good things and they're working?
- 5.20 And the answer to that might be, well, probably not, you know. That tilt towards narcissism and grandiosity, that's going to be there within you, and you want to do everything you can. You really want to do this if you start to understand it, because the long-term outcome for narcissism, the narcissistic types and Machiavellians and psychopaths, it is just not a pathway to success, despite what people say. You know, "All our CEOs and politicians are psychopaths." It's like, well, actually, no, they're not. And certainly they're no more psychopathic than the people who are making those accusations, that's for sure.
- 5.21 I mean, most of the people I've met in Washington, I don't care if they're Democrats or Republicans. You know, it isn't obvious at all that they're not better people than you, you know, and it's a job that requires, at least to some degree, especially for competent people, a fair bit of sacrifice. Because if you're a congressman, it's like, you want to go and be publicly elected to your job every two years? You know, and if you're competent enough so you have a shot at electoral victory, you probably had a life already. You probably had a job, you know. You had your financial resources at hand. That's not true of every single person, obviously, because some people can use that as just a ladder to power. But for most people it's not.
- 5.22 In any case, you want to—you don't want to put yourself in a position where even your proclivity to do good can be used by the worst part of you to ratchet yourself up the hierarchy of reputation, narcissistically. It's really a bad idea, and not just for everyone else; it's certainly a bad idea for everyone else, but it's a really bad idea for you. One of the things about psychopathy is that psychopaths are not successful in the medium to long run. One of the hallmarks of psychopathy is failure to learn from experience. And so psychopaths will put short-term, impulsive, hedonic gratification at the forefront of their priority of perceptions, let's say, or their hierarchy of perceptions. And what that means is they do stupid things and lie, and then they get in trouble, and it happens over and over and over and over, and they don't learn.
- 5.23 And so they betray themselves exactly as much as they betray other people, or more so, and for exactly the same reasons, because they don't treat themselves as if they have any continuity over time. And the typical psychopath also has to move all the time, because you can fool someone, you know, twice or three times, even if they're

patient. But once they figure out, figure you out, it's like, "Oh, I see, I can't trust you." It's like, well, once everyone around you knows that you can't be trusted, once one person knows you can't be trusted, other people know real quick, because one of the things we definitely do as human beings is alert each other in our social network to the presence of untrustworthy people. The typical psychopath is a drifter.

5.24 And the reason for that is, well, you have to drift because people figure you out. And maybe if you're hyper-intelligent and you're not a psychopath right to the core, you can get away with it more frequently, but there's just no evidence whatsoever that it's an effective strategy. And you hear these accusations that, well, like I said, that social hierarchies, human social hierarchies, especially those in the West, are predicated on "nothing but power." It's like, well, no, that's what psychopaths do. And they're not successful. They're a small proportion of the population. They exist on the fringes. They can fool some of the people, some of the time. Psychopathic men are particularly good at fooling young women because young women are attracted to competence and confidence. And the narcissistic psychopaths are very good at aping that. So, look the hell out. And so that can be very attractive because it seems like the real thing. Well, yeah, it seems like the real thing because they're mimicking it.

5.25 "And when thou prayest, thou shalt not be as the hypocrites are; for they love to pray standing in the synagogues and in the corner of the streets." Same thing there again. That's the activist issue here. And that's why, again, Christ is not a revolutionary. He's not a political revolutionary. Period. The end. That's just not how this story is laid out. "And in the corners of the streets, that they may be seen of men." Yeah, I've been in the midst of these student demonstrations many times, you know, and sometimes more women are there than men, but there's always some men in those woman-dominated protests lurking behind the scenes. And I tell you, the women can be absolutely reprehensible. Screaming 18-year-old harpies. Terrible, terribly misbehaved.

5.26 But the men that are in there with them, those guys are bad news, man, because they're in there to exploit those young women. That's 100% "I'm on your side." It's like, yeah, yeah. This is not a—with a friend like that, you do not need an enemy. I got reasonably good at spotting dangerous people as a clinician because there were, well, I needed to get good at that. And in these protests, I'd see, like, three or four of these guys, and I'd think, "Oh, boy, you are seriously, you are seriously bad people." Not misguided, you know, not just ignorant, not just young, but like, no, no, no, you're a serious predator. You know?

5.27 And another thing that we need to know, too, is that there is a small percentage of people who are like that. It's probably 1% of the criminals are responsible for about 70% of the crimes. They're experts, and they're just criminal in everything they do. Some people in jail, they did something stupid, you know, they did it once or twice, but some of them are the careerist types. And most people aren't like that, you know? And when the Antifa types took over, I think it was Seattle, the mayor said something like—

and they set up a "new state" in the middle of the city—the mayor said something like, "Well, it'll just be the summer of love." Which, by the way, ended in 1967, when the Hell's Angels that the Rolling Stones hired as security guards, thinking that "the working class could just ally themselves with the bikers," because, you know, bikers, they're just misunderstood. It's like, and they stabbed someone at Altamont, and that was the end of—that was a rock concert—that was the end of the summer of love.

5.28 And when this all happened in Seattle, I thought, yeah, it'll all be roses, sunshine, and hippies when the lights are on during the day, but you just bloody well wait till the night time comes, and the criminals think, "Oh, look, all we've got are naive people all gathered in one spot. We can just go in there and just exactly have all the fun we'd love to have." It's like summer love. Yeah. Nights of hell and days of what, wine and roses? So bloody naive. And then that naivety cloaks itself in the guise of moral virtue. "I think the best of everyone." It's like, fair enough, man. If you're courageous and you're willing to invite the best of someone out, no problem. But if you're just naive, you're just fruit for the picking, and you're an invitation to exploitation.

5.29 And if your naivety is a consequence of willful blindness, then you're morally culpable for the outcome. So, "We should defund the police." It's like, yeah, you just go right ahead. You think the police are bad? You wait till the psychopathic criminals come knocking. You're gonna learn what lurks in the dark corners of the world. You know, and then the people who do this, too, you also have to ask yourself, especially if they're willfully blind in their naivety, it's like, what makes you think you're not inviting those people to triumph because there's a part of you that would just like to see everything burned to the ground? And so that's definitely the case with so much of this idiot activism. It's like, well, you know, "Capitalism is evil. We should destroy it." It's like, well, who are you going to get to destroy it? You know, how about the psychopathic criminals? They're good at destroying. They enjoy it, right?

5.30 That's Batman's Joker. You remember there's a scene in the one Batman movie. Maybe you remember this. I think the Joker allies himself with the Mafia. They're pretty bad, the Mafia, but at least they're greedy. You can trust them. It's like, they like money. You can understand that. And I think the Joker gets half the money, then he just burns it. And the criminals are shocked, right? Well, they've gazed upon the face of true evil in that situation. It's like, "No, no, you guys aren't evil. You still want something. I'm a whole different category than that. I don't want anything. In fact, I want there to be nothing. I'll even destroy. I'm way more criminal than your criminality." So that's the bottom rung of this kind of destructive psychopathy.

5.31 "For they love to pray standing in the synagogues and in the corners of the streets." Standing in the synagogues. So that's the religious hypocrites who wear their Christianity or their Judaism or their Islamic faith as a marker of their cardinal moral virtue. Instead, you know, the Jesus prayer in Christianity is repetition of the lines, "Jesus Christ, have mercy on my soul, a sinner." Right? It's this reminder that you're not

a moral paragon, especially not compared to God. And so if you think that going to church elevates your moral status, it's like, well, that's the opposite reason for going to, to be going there. You're supposed to be going there as a penitent. That's what a penitentiary is, right? It's full of people who should be penitent. To be penitent is to repent of your inadequacies and your sins.

5.32 And so if you think that going to church, the mere fact that you're seen in church, indicates your moral propriety, then you've got the wrong idea. It's complicated, right? Because part of the reason people do go to church and sacrifice themselves to do that is to indicate to other people that, despite their idiosyncrasies and their deviation from orthodox doctrine, they're willing to subjugate themselves to the collective will. And that's a really important thing, you know? Because you might think, well, "I can't go to church because I don't exactly believe that." It's like, that's a, in some fundamental sense, that's not the point.

5.33 You still have to get along with other people. You still have to signal to other people that, well, despite the fact that we don't agree on everything, there is some things we should do together. We have to subordinate ourselves to that collective enterprise. And so then to be pleased with yourself to some limited degree because you're willing to make the collective effort, that's reasonable. But to use the church as a means of elevating yourself in the hierarchy of responsible authority, that's the opposite of what you should be doing there.

5.34 "But thou, when thou prayest, enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut the door, pray to thy Father, which is in secret; and thy Father, which seeth in secret, shall reward thee openly." And so that's an interesting thing, too. There's a twist into the psychological here in a real sense. It's like, well, even if you do want to move up the hierarchy of responsible authority, then according to this injunction, the best way to do that is to commune with yourself in private. And the communion is something like, OK, a simple prayer is something like, "What am I doing that's stupid and wrong, that's making things worse?" This is an extremely useful thing to do on a regular basis.

5.35 You can do this when you're having an argument with your partner. Separate because it's intractable. You think, OK, I'm an idiot. I did something to make this argument likely, even though the other person's 95% wrong. I probably did something that was stupid to increase the probability that this will occur, that this occurred, or that it isn't resolving. What is that? It has to be a real question, right? You have to want to know the answer, which is a dreadful thing, because do you want to know the answer? The answer is generally no, it's the last thing you want to know.

5.36 So you think, "What am I doing that's stupid and wrong? That I could change? That I would change?" And really narrows it. There's real humility in that, right? Because first of all, you have to admit you're doing something wrong and stupid. And then the next thing you have to admit is that some of those things are things you could do something about, but that you're too stupid to do anything about them. And so there's an even

smaller subset of the reasons you're stupid that you might be willing to change. And often this is something painful for people in clinical therapy, often, especially behavioral, because what you do in a cognitive behavioral therapy session is, well, try to find out what is bothering the person, what habits they have, for example, that might need some rectification. I often concentrated on helping people bring some order to their immediate environment.

5.37 So I had one client, for example. He lived at home. He was, like, 35 and his room was just a mess. He was a bloody teenager, a bad teenage, badly behaved teenager, which is really bad when you're like mid-thirties. And he knew it, and he was going to have a child out of wedlock, and as a consequence of carelessness, which is what you'd expect. But he also didn't want to screw up this child. And so he kind of more or less figured out that he should probably try to grow up, so the idiocy didn't cascade down the generations. And we concentrated on having him clean up his room. And he obviously was in some weird relationship with his mother because she let him live in the house and have the messy room of a teenager, even though he was 35. So that's a little too close, you might say, from the Freudian perspective.

5.38 And so we talked about him cleaning up his room, which is trivial, but not, because he didn't do it for, like, 35 years. So obviously it's not trivial. You discuss that in a session with someone; you think, well, what do you think? Is this worth proceeding with? And they have to be on board. You can't suggest it even, in some sense. You can strategize, but they have to be on board. And then you think, well, how might we move towards this incrementally in a way that you might actually do it? And so I think, with a first task, you often set people tasks as a cognitive behavioral therapist. Like, it's called collaborative empiricism. OK, so we kind of got the problem set, and now we have some strategy. Why don't you go try out a chunk of this strategy? And then just come back and we'll talk about, well, how it worked. And if it didn't work, we'll reevaluate.

5.39 So the goal was, I think he was supposed to vacuum the rug in his room or something. So he got the vacuum cleaner, and he brought it not into his room. He got it to the door. It was one of those upright vacuums. And then he left it diagonally across the door frame so that he had to step over the bloody thing. And then he left it there for a week. And then he came back and he said, "Well, you know, I was supposed to clean up my room, and I got the vacuum cleaner," but he couldn't bring it over the threshold. You know, it's symbolically very important because to move it over the threshold is to bring the cleaning device into the room and to start cleaning up.

5.40 And there's a very common mythological motif when the hero first encounters the giant. So that's the tyranny of society, or the dragon, which is chaos itself. He or she often turns tail and runs, and it's like, well, no wonder. And you can encounter that in all sorts of situations, you know, where you're trying to get something done and you find you're avoiding it. It's like, that's the first—because there's something important there. Even if the task itself seems trivial, it's connected to something much bigger. And

so there's part of you thinking, "No, no, we're not going there." Anyways, it was very much of a humiliation for him because, really, you're 35. You can't get the vacuum cleaner into your bedroom? It's like, what the hell's wrong with you and your family?

5.41 And the answer is, man, a lot of things. And he was deciding to confront that. And then what you do, and this is what you can do with yourself, too, is if you set yourself a task that's trivial and you don't do it—maybe it was too trivial to be interesting to you. Probably not. Probably you haven't humbled yourself enough. I think what we did instead is, I think I had him clean out one-quarter of one sock drawer. And that was the first step. It's like, you know how horrible it is to realize that that's where you have to start? You know, Jesus, it's so dismal. It's no wonder people wouldn't want to see that, you know.

5.42 But the plus side, and this is also worth knowing, is that if you do find a purchase point and you start, you can ratchet yourself forward quite quickly. It's not linear. It's exponential once you start moving. And so even if you're moving slow to begin with, as long as you're moving, it can start doubling pretty quickly. Failure's like that, too, unfortunately, on the other end. But, yeah, so.

5.43 "But thou, when thou prayest, enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father, which is in secret; and thy Father, which seeth in secret, shall reward thee openly." Why the father, eh? Because why the father? Why not God the mother? Well, in this situation, I would say, is because God the mother—so the divine maternal, let's say—is accept, is an accepting force, in the most fundamental sense. It's like, you're OK the way you are, which is great if you're an infant. But the paternal spirit is more something like, well, it's like the call to adventure. For Abraham, it's like, "Get the hell out there in the world. Move forward."

5.44 And so what you're trying to do in a situation like this is to commune with the eternal part of the spirit that pulls you towards increased development and self-revelation, right? So it's, you're appealing not to being. You're appealing to becoming. And so that's conceptualized, symbolically and appropriately, as the masculine end of the divine calling. And I think that's perfectly appropriate. You know, it's like you're trying to, you're really trying to allow the spirit of the adventurous heroes of the past to take its dwelling place within you. And you do that all the time. You go to movies. Movies have heroes. Why do you go see movies? Well, it's because you're trying to open yourself up to the embodiment of that heroic spirit.

5.45 And you find that really gripping and engaging because, otherwise, why would you pay to go see—why do you pay to go see movies? That's worth thinking about, right? They're so intrinsically compelling that you'll sacrifice your time and your energy and your leisure to go see them. Well, why? Well, because there's a call in them. Sometimes it's a call to not be the antihero, right. To find out the satanic path in some real sense and to pick the opposite. But often it's, well, you watch the hero.

- 5.46 And when my kids were little, I used to take them to scary movies, and sometimes too scary, by the way, and I would tell them, "Watch the hero." Like, you're going to be afraid, and fair enough, but watch the hero because he'll get through it. And then it's not scary because what you—in fact, it's the opposite of scary because what you see is someone confronting something that's really scary, genuinely scary. My son, we took him to the Lord of the Rings, and those Nazgul, you know, the wraiths of the dead—he didn't like that. He really didn't like the wraiths of the dead at all. It's like, ah, they made this horrible screeching noise. And it is scary, but the Hobbit can conquer them, even though he's only the size of a child, right? And so that whole process is salutary, not terrifying.
- 5.47 And the Lord of the Rings and the Hobbit, those are unbelievably old stories, right? The story of the encounter with the dragon and with the evil that the dragon represents — we don't have an older story than that. The oldest story we know that's written is a Mesopotamian, one of the oldest stories, Mesopotamian creation myth. And it's basically St. George and the dragon. It's a variant of that. It's the oldest, it might be the oldest mammalian story, right? Us against the lizards, you know? So, in some real sense, it's like 250 million years old, like, in some really deep sense. And so.
- 5.48 "But when you pray, use not vain repetitions, as the heathen do." So this is, the prayer isn't supposed to degenerate into a meaningless ritual. Now chanting can be used effectively, like singing can. There are ritualistic approaches that can open yourself up to a revelation of information that's beyond your current conceptualization. But it's not supposed to degenerate into a meaningless babble. "For they think that they shall be heard for their much speaking." That's a nice line, a very comical line. It's like God isn't impressed by sheer volume of communication, right?
- 5.49 "Be not ye therefore like unto them; for your Father knoweth what things you have need of, before you ask him." Ask him. So it's not as if you have to explain to God what you need. What you really have to do is the opposite, in some sense. Is open yourself up to the revelation. And you might think—I don't know how religious any of you are. It doesn't really matter because these ideas represent truths that are true at every level in some sense simultaneously. You say, well, do you pray and open yourself up to revelation? Well, I don't believe in God. That, first of all, that is not the question that I just asked. You don't believe in God. Do you pray and open yourself up to revelation? And the answer to that is yes, if you think.
- 5.50 And because this is what you do when you think, and it's a mystery, you ask yourself a question. Well, why think if you know the answer already? So you have to specify the question. Then you specify the question, and then you get an answer, and you think, "How is that possible?" Because you didn't know the answer and you're you. And then you pose the question and then you get the answer. And there's no difference between that and a prayer, not if it's genuine. Because if it's genuine, it's a real question, and that's an admission of ignorance. You say, "Look, I know some things, but I don't know

enough. There's things I don't know. I'd like to know some things about the things I don't know." Well, how is that going to happen? Because you don't know them.

- 5.51** And the answer is, well, a thought appears in the theater of your imagination. It's like, well, where does that come from? Well, "I thought it up." It's like, that's really not a very good explanation. It's just, first of all, it might be a misattribution. You thought it up. Why didn't you know it to begin with, then? How is it that you could disclose to yourself something you didn't know? Well, the phenomenology, Jung said, you know, people think they think, but what happens is that thoughts appear in the theater of their imagination, like a table appears when you walk into a room. It's just there. And you can set yourself up so that you can receive the intuition, but you have to be open to it.
- 5.52** And the distinction between that and a revelation is, well, maybe the distinction is to what source you attribute that, but to what source do you attribute it? It's like, you didn't know something. You posed a question. It's a genuine question. And the more genuine the question, the more likely you are to receive an answer. That is certainly 100% the case. I told my students when they're writing essays, it's like, don't write an essay about something you don't care about, because it's a lie right from the beginning. And then if it's not about something you care about, and you're bored writing it, just imagine what it's like for me to read that. And then I'm supposed to pretend that you care, and I'm supposed to pretend that I believe that, and that because I believe it, I care. And so the whole thing is a lie.
- 5.53** If you ask yourself a serious question, you're likely to get a serious answer, and that's a mystery. And maybe it's a miracle. And then you have to sift through the answers, because just because a thought appears to you doesn't mean it's right. Because you're kind of twisted and bent, and you've already gone along with some thoughts that maybe didn't come from the right place. And so, you can be deluded by the force of a revelation. That happens in psychosis, pretty much nonstop. Paranoid people are deluded by the force of their own thoughts continually.
- 5.54** And so there's an idea—it's a Gospel idea, too, I believe—that you have to test the spirits to see if they're of God. It's like, "OK, I asked myself a question. I got this answer. It's pretty compelling, but I'm a twisted thing, man. And just because that answer popped up, maybe it's an appeal to my narcissism in some way that I didn't expect." And so then you want to think about the revelation. That's critical thought, right? You want to set up an adversary and say, "OK, we're going to hammer away at this and see if it's the real thing." Maybe you can discuss it with other people.
- 5.55** That's what you do when you edit, but that's also what you do when you have an honest conversation with someone who disagrees with you. Right? It's like, well, here's a proposition. I'd like to believe it because maybe it shines a positive light on me and because it's comforting, but I'd rather that it was solid, and because maybe I'll need it in a time of crisis. So maybe we should see if it's solid. So you want to bring—you want

to assemble some foes against it to see if they can take it out. And that's why you dare talk to other people who disagree with you. That's why you dare think. It's because you want to make sure that your tools are battle-tested. Because at some point, man, if they're not, a bad situation can be way worse. And that's definitely happening.

5.56 "After this manner therefore, pray ye." OK, so this is the Lord's Prayer. "Our Father, which art in heaven, hallowed be thy name." OK, so what does that mean? Well, heaven is a hierarchy of value. That's a good way of thinking about it. Or maybe heaven is the pinnacle of the hierarchy of value. Or maybe heaven is the spirit that shines through every level of the hierarchy, if it's properly constituted. And maybe heaven is the place that you're at when you're doing the right thing at the right time, and everything's going well.

5.57 You know how you have times in your life where that's the case. It's like, that's the Dao, in some sense, manifesting itself. It's like, everything's come together, and you're in accordance with the patterns of existence in a musical sense, and everything just opens itself up to you, and that's a vision of heaven. Or maybe that's—you've got one toe in the door. It's something like that. One of the things I used to do with my clients is, you know, I'd have them just watch their lives. It's like, OK, you're depressed. Are you depressed all the time? And the answer to that sometimes is yes. But even then, there's variation, right?

5.58 Sometimes it's catastrophic, often in the morning for people who are truly depressed. But they'll see, if they track themselves over a week, that sometimes they're unbelievably miserable. And when they're like that, they think they're always like that, because that's part of being miserable like that. But they'll also notice that there are times when they're not. And so then one question is, well, what are you doing then? Like, obviously, something's opened up to you that's more positive. Maybe you could practice being there more often. And so that's a matter of attention.

5.59 So you, first of all, you have to think, OK, sometimes I'm nearer to the light, and sometimes I'm farther away. And so how do you tell that? Well, sometimes it's more like hell. How's that? How's that for evidence? And then you might think, well, maybe I could do fewer of those things and more of the things that move me in a positive direction. And a tremendous amount of that is attention. And the decision to start paying attention to that, because you can see. You try this for two weeks; just watch yourself and your life, like you don't know who you are or where you are. So you got to pull yourself back and you got to watch and then notice. It's like, was this working or is this not working?

5.60 And it's a tough thing to do because you want to insist that what you're doing is working. And that's fine if it's working, but if it's not working, maybe you shouldn't be insisting, because maybe that's part of, well, certainly that's part of, what? That's your own tyranny, man, doubling down against you, that's for sure. And you want to be right because being wrong is a pain. You know, if you're going the right way, well, that's

simple. If you're going the wrong way, there's a lot of wrong ways. And there is—it's a really difficult thing to order and organize all those wrong ways and to pick out the right way from amongst them. You don't want to find out that you're wrong. It's really annoying. It makes you anxious. It takes you apart. But there's nothing worse than traveling efficiently down the wrong road.

5.61 "Our Father, which art in heaven." OK, so the other idea there, too, is that there's a pinnacle of spirits to imitate. There's a pyramid of spirits to imitate. And there's something that's superordinate—that's the fundamental claim of monotheism—and that that's the thing towards which you should orient yourself and allow to inhabit you. And that it should be hallowed. Well, why hallowed? Well, hallowed means held as sacred. And you might think, well, "I don't hold anything as sacred." It's like, well, then you're confused. Then you have no priorities, because if everything is of equal importance, then you're scattered everywhere, right? "I don't know what to do." Why? Because everything's meaningless, which means equally meaningless. Or, "I can't tell if this is more important," or this or this or this or this or this or this or this. And that definitely makes you anxious.

5.62 In fact, in some real sense, anxiety signifies that that's the current state. Because you get anxious when your body is concerned you're going to expend too much energy counterproductively. And if you're pushing yourself in 20 directions simultaneously, and some of those directions conflict, then you're burning up your energy, your stores, with no necessary assurance of replenishment. So you should be anxious. So it's so interesting. Directionless and anxious are fundamentally the same thing. Directionlessness and hopelessness are also the same thing, because, as we've already discussed, you experience positive emotion in relationship to a goal.

5.63 And so, if you have a goal hierarchy, so that's a heavenly hierarchy, and there's something that really beckons at the top, and you're moving towards it, that makes you hopeful, and that's positive emotion. Hope—that's the antidote to depression. You know, maybe you quell anxiety because that's not helpful, but hope is the antidote to depression. And so, to hallow something is to celebrate it, to put it in the highest place, to imitate it, to sacrifice to it, to bow down to it, to imitate it, to embody it, all of that. And when you understand that, then you start to understand, well, in some real sense, what worship means.

5.64 It doesn't mean to announce that you believe a bunch of things that you don't believe. That is also not what faith means. That's just foolishness. Well, it's not always just foolishness because you can try to believe something before you actually believe it. You know, as a practice, you know. You can practice having courageous faith in people, even if you're doubtful and cynical. And that's not—that doesn't have to be delusional. It can be the attempt to take the next step, but it can be delusional.

5.65 "Thy kingdom come." Well, that would be good to organize everything in the proper manner, to subdue everything in the proper hierarchy, to let that spirit. So here's a way

to think about it. So when Adam is chased out of the Garden of Eden, he won't walk with God because he knows he's naked. And that's what he tells God, because God calls him and says, "Do you want to go for a walk?" Which, apparently, Adam was accustomed to doing. And Adam says, "No." And God says, well, "No? First of all, I'm God. And second, why would you not walk with God?" And Adam says, "Because I'm naked."

- 5.66 And it's so profound, that story. It's like, well, why wouldn't you dwell in the highest place? And the answer to that is, well, you're ashamed, and you don't think you have it in you, and you don't think you're worth it. And that's all tangled up in that idea of nakedness. It's like, because nakedness is the revelation of your fundamental inadequacy and vulnerability. People often have nightmares about being naked on a public stage. That's why people, in some sense, are also often terrified of public speaking. It's because they're afraid that all their inadequacies are going to be exposed to judgment.
- 5.67 And if you're self-conscious, you're miserable. Those things are so closely allied. And so, if you can walk un-self-consciously in the garden, then you're in the kingdom. And that's a good thing to know, too, because you can see, too. It's like, when is it that you're pursuing what's best, even by your own judgment, let's say. Honest judgment. You're pursuing what's best, and you're not self-conscious. You can notice that because maybe you're at a party. I don't know where it is for you. Maybe it's when you're walking in the forest. Maybe it's when you're doing something artistic. Maybe it's when you're taking care of kids. A lot of that's going to depend on your temperament. Maybe it's when you're doing your duty and working. And like I said, a lot of that's temperamental. But you can notice,
- 5.68 when am I not watching the clock? When does my sense of time disappear? When am I not focusing on my own inadequacies? When am I immersed in what I'm doing and noticing that's really important because you think, "Ah, I don't know what it is or why that's the right place for me, but that's the right place." And then you think, well, maybe, maybe you start practicing and you can get 2% better at that a month or 2% better a week because you make it a priority. And then, maybe instead of that being 5% of your life, it's like then it's 20% and then it's 50% and then it's 90%.
- 5.69 And then when it starts to hit 90%, then it gathers in other people and think, well, what's the limit to that? What's the uppermost limit to that? Well, that's the uppermost. The uppermost limit is the kingdom of God. That's just a definition. And then the question is, well, to what degree is your own striving capable of bringing that about? And the answer is, why don't you find out? And that's the adventure of your life, to find that out. And so, unless you want to bring about hell, which you certainly can do.
- 5.70 "Thy kingdom come, thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven." Well, that's the propagation of the highest value all the way down the hierarchy. So you run your own

life by the principles of the divine. Let's say you run your family that way, you run your businesses that way. It's there at every single level. That's Jacob's ladder, right? That's the hierarchy that stretches down from heaven to earth. It's not just God and people. It's God and what? What would you say? It's God and state. It's state and city. It's city and community. It's community and family. It's family and the individual and all of— and then all of the practices of the individual, all of that.

- 5.71** The whole thing has to be imbued with what's in the highest place. And then it's the whole thing that's elevated to the highest place. That's the idea. So there's nothing. And in that circumstance, there's nothing—that's so cool too. There's nothing that's trivial then, because you know you're bored. "Oh, my God, my life's so trivial." It's like, well, are you not doing something that's not trivial? It's like, if your life is trivial and you're bored, it's like, well, that's because you're not doing anything meaningful and important. That's just a definition, right? And so, and maybe that's because you want to shirk the responsibility or you're nihilistic.
- 5.72** People have their reasons to be nihilistic and bitter. But if it makes you bored and unable to engage in life, that doesn't really seem like a cure. Maybe it's better than being naive. It's not better than the alternative. So if you're bored with your dismal routine, you got to ask yourself, well, maybe it's not serving. Maybe. Obviously it's not serving something you find compelling. And then you might think, well, "How do I find something compelling?" Well, first of all, you want to. You open yourself up to that possibility, and then the other thing I would say, and this goes back to the Beatitudes, is, why don't you look in your misery? There's plenty of that. Things are making you bitter and cynical. The state of the world, the state of you, the state of your friends and your family. It's, like, fix it.
- 5.73** Obviously you find that meaningful because otherwise it wouldn't make you suffer. And so that's a good thing to know, too, is that your problem—it's so interesting, and you see this inversion constantly in the Sermon on the Mount—it's possible that your salvation is to be found in your problems. There's an ancient line of speculation that's developed that thought for thousands of years. Jung, Carl Jung, followed the development of alchemy, which was the prodromal dream to science. And there's a dictum in alchemy, "in sterquiliniis invenitur," and it means "what you most need will be found where you least want to look." And that's, oh, terrifying. But then you think, well, it's got to be the case, too, because maybe the things you're ignoring, and therefore don't know or won't allow yourself to know, is what's keeping you ignorant and miserable.
- 5.74** Well, where are those things most likely to be found? Well, where are you most afraid to look? Because you haven't looked there and you don't want to. And so, of course, that's where you're blind. And then the question is, do you want to be blind to the things that are most horrible? And the answer is, well, yes, obviously, because they're so horrible. It's like, yeah, but, man, they're coming your way, and if you think you can

hide, well, good luck with that. First of all, horrible things find you no matter where you hide, and they might even be better at finding you if you're hiding. That's certainly possible and highly likely.

5.75 And second, you're not preparing yourself, you know. And who knows what you could take on if you prepared yourself. We wouldn't be here if we weren't capable of taking on the worst. And human beings really do. You know, we're mortal and vulnerable and we know it. Every single person who's ever lived had to contend with the fact that we're confronted by death. And not just death, but hell as well. If you think about that as the dwelling place of the malevolent, that's definitely, that's right there, and the fact that we're here at all means that we're part of an unbroken chain of creatures who managed that successfully. So clearly, clearly we can do it.

5.76 And so, and then the clinical evidence is just completely bloody clear, and so is the research evidence. You don't even use the same psycho-physiological systems to approach a challenge if you do it voluntarily versus having it thrust on you. Same magnitude of challenge, completely different pattern of motivation and emotional activation if you take it on voluntarily. And so should you take on what's the worst, voluntarily? Well, it's going to come anyways. And then maybe if you take it on voluntarily, who knows what you can transmute it into. And you know perfectly well, you know this absolutely 100%, that the people you spontaneously admire—I don't care who they are, unless you're pointed down in a very terrible way—the people you spontaneously admire, and so they call to you underneath your cognitions. The people you admire are definitely the people who take their burdens on voluntarily. And then

5.77 it's even more subtle than that. In some sense, the people that you really admire are really badly broken people who are impaired in 15 different ways, who still do that. And so you could definitely be one of them. "Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven." Bring that all down to the lowest level, right, the level of detail. "Give us this day our daily bread. And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors." That's an ethical issue, too. And there's an equation here, too. It isn't, "and forgive us our debts." It isn't blanket absolution; it's reciprocity. It's like, to the degree that we're capable of manifesting a judicious mercy, let that also be applied to us.

5.78 And I would say it's definitely the case that if you want to set up the world so that it judges you helpfully and forgives you in a manner that allows you to be redeemed, then you practice doing that with other people, and then they reflect that back to you. And so, obviously that's the case, you know, and we see that even—I mentioned this before—you see that even in chimpanzee troops, is that the males and the females with authority are the ones who are reciprocal peacemakers. That's the most appropriate basis for the establishment of a stable polity, even among chimps. And so it is definitely the case that you will receive what you give.

5.79 It might even be better than that. You know, if you're very good at giving, you might receive back more than you give. And I think we all know that, too, because you can ask

yourself this question, you know. It's said that it's better to give than to receive. And it's hard for kids to grasp that concept, and adults, too. You think, "No, no, I just want the gift." It's like, well, if you watch yourself, I think, and I don't think I've ever met anyone who wasn't seriously in trouble for whom this wasn't true. I don't know if there's ever anything that strikes you more to the core, in the most positive way, than to find out that if you made a sacrifice for someone else, that it really had a positive impact on them, like a positive and growing impact, you know?

5.80 And to the degree that you're a parent and a good parent, well, your whole life is that. If you're a good mentor, it's the same thing. And one of the great pleasures of being a professor or running a business, for that matter, is that you can take promising young people and you can help. Not help them, exactly. You can, I don't know, you can expose them to a wider range of potentially open doors or something like that. And you can also use this judicious criticism, say. This is a very useful thing to know, by the way. If you want to improve your life and the people, the lives of the people around you, this is something that's unbelievably useful, and you can learn to do it quite quickly.

5.81 You want to watch the people around you. And when they do something that you think is part of the kingdom of heaven, let's say, something you'd like to see them do more of, not for an instrumental reason, but because you see that right then and there, they're in the right place, doing the right thing, and you say to them, "I saw what you did." And you say it in detail. Here's exactly what you did. "I saw you tell your son; I just saw what you did for your sister." Like, you were really paying attention there. You did something nice. This is exactly what you did.

5.82 You cannot believe how positively people respond to that, because people, they'll sneak out something good because they're afraid of it and they're afraid. Nietzsche said, if you want to punish someone—this is good to know, too—if you want to punish someone, you don't punish them for their sins because they are actually relieved about that in some fundamental sense. You wait till they do something good, and then you punish them. And if you do that in a marriage, so maybe you're a jealous husband and your wife is attractive, and you punched above your weight, and you're afraid somebody else will steal her, because if she had any sense, she'd let that happen.

5.83 And so every time she makes herself attractive to go out, you either don't respond positively, you damn with faint praise, or you say something cutting. You do that a hundred times, and your wife will no longer be attractive in your presence, and then you'll be all bitter. It's like, "Look how she let herself go." It's like, "You paved the road, man. And every time she did something that was an alternative to that, you put a dart in her heart." And you do not have—you can train a dog to starve to death by hitting it on the nose with the newspaper when it approaches its food dish. You do that 30, 40 times, the dog will stop eating.

5.84 So that injudicious use of punishment, that's—if you want to make your family pathological, that's the best way to do it. You just keep your eyes open, and whenever

anybody around you does anything good, this is the Oedipal family in a nutshell. Oedipal mothers who have all their identity and their children, and who believe that their maternal compassion is the be all and end all of life, and who haven't dared to forge their own destiny, every time one of their children does anything that's indicative of that daring move forward out into the world, they will either contaminate it with terror or punish it. And I've been in families like that, sometimes for decades, and watched how unbelievably, brutally catastrophic that is. That's the return of the great she-devil Tiamat, the story of Mesopotamia, this horrible devouring force that destroys consciousness and will, all under the guise of compassion. God, brutal.

5.85 "And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil." A paradoxical reference to God. It's like, why ask God not to lead you into temptation? Well, it's called a humility. Again, this is God, and God only knows what he's up to. And so, you're fortunate if something isn't put in your path that tempts you in a negative way. And so maybe you pray in the real sense that you're not subject to temptations beyond your ability to control.

5.86 You know, the prayer there, I think, is a useful one, too, because one of the things you want to do, if you're trying to control a bad habit, for example, is you want to be open to the realization of where you shouldn't go if you're trying to control the temptation. So, for example, maybe you're trying to quit drinking and you're invited to a party. It's like, well, there's a temptation. And maybe if you're humble enough, you think, I'd really like to go to this party, but probably I wouldn't be able to handle it properly. Probably I'd just use it as an excuse.

Lecture 6: Aiming for the Highest Good

At a glance — The Lord's Prayer and aiming at the highest good.

- 6.1** "But deliver us from evil, for thine is the kingdom, and the power and the glory, forever." Yeah, well, and so that's also a reminder, let's say, that something superordinate and valuable exists, the city on the hill, at least in potential, right? This shining place of potential. And you do orient yourself to that, the idea that you're moving from the tyranny—this is the Exodus story—into the desert, toward the promised land. That's just life, right? Because you're tyrannizing yourself and you exist within a tyranny in some sense in the social community because it's corrupted to some degree, and you're subject to it.
- 6.2** Then if you abandon the tyranny, your own tyrannical presuppositions, for that matter, you don't just get to the promised land, you go into the desert because now you're confused and aimless and things have fallen apart, and that doesn't seem to be an improvement. Once you understand that that's actually the pattern of your journey through life, then things get a lot easier because you think, well, look, I want to aim up because I want to go somewhere. I want to be aiming at one thing, and hopefully it's better. But there's a price I'm going to pay for that, and the price is successive realizations of my own inadequacy, and that's going to destabilize me, and sometimes in a profound way. But that's part of this process of moving uphill.
- 6.3** It's up the mountain, down into the valley, up a higher mountain, down into the valley, up a higher mountain. But there's no mountain to mountain. It's not just one leap forward after another with no intervening period of chaos. You have to reduce yourself. Like, once you realize you're wrong, it reduces you to a state of uncertainty. And there's torment in that. Really, really. Because your body responds as if you're in the desert. You don't know where to go. There isn't any food there. There isn't any water. It's dangerous. And you respond physically to that with hyper-preparation for activity. It's physiologically demanding and very emotionally uncomfortable. Definitely is the price that you pay for a redemptive realization.
- 6.4** But another thing I would say about that is, however, if you're continually open to incremental improvements, you can get to the point where the revelations are small enough so that mostly they're just interesting, rather than terrifying. It's small revolutions. If the revolution is small enough, then it's just interesting, because a little revolution is interesting. If you listen to a piece of music, you don't want it to be 100% predictable. You want it to do something a little interesting. Wakes you up and it's like, "Oh, that's so cool that that happened." You don't want the piece to just—you don't want a rap song to turn into a classical piece all of a sudden or just into noise. But an interesting variation, there's a level of optimal transformation.

- 6.5 That's the zone of proximal development. When people say they want to be in the zone, it's a reference to that concept. And the zone of proximal development is the place you stand when you're transforming optimally. The signal for that—this is really worth knowing—the signal for that is the sense of meaning. And so you say, well, is meaning real? Is life meaningful? It's like, no, you just got it wrong. It's the most real thing. And why? Well, because existing on the edge of that transformation is what prepares you to do battle with the worst things, tragedy and malevolence. Are they real? Was pain real? Is suffering real? Well, obviously. We act like that's the—is pain real? Try to deny it with all your rationalizations and see how far you get. It'd be lovely if you could do that in some sense, although you'd just die if you could.
- 6.6 But you know what I mean. It's pain and anxiety. Everyone acts like that's real. So you think that might be the most fundamental reality. It's not. It's whatever can overcome tragedy and malevolence is more powerful than tragedy and malevolence. And that sense of engaged meaning is the signal that the process that would overcome tragedy and malevolence is at play within you. That's something to know, man. And you think, well, how can it be otherwise? How could we be constituted so that what grips us most deeply isn't that which would most propitiously aid in our survival? Obviously, it has to be that way, and particularly, obviously, under the direst of circumstances, because that's when it's most necessary.
- 6.7 And so people undermine their own sense of meaning with rationality. They think, well, in two billion years, the sun is going to expand and swallow the earth, so why do anything? That's the apocalyptic nightmare in some sense. Fair enough, because you have to wrestle with the paradox between finitude and meaning. That's a tough one. But I would say, well, you don't think that way when a child is crying in front of you. You don't think, well, the sun is going to consume the earth in two billion years. Who cares if you starve? No one thinks that.
- 6.8 And the reason they don't think that is because just because you can pick a time frame, or a conceptual frame that makes everything you do meaningless, doesn't mean it's meaningless. It just means that you picked the wrong time frame. That's another thing to think about, too. It's like, if what you're doing is dull and meaningless, one possibility is that you're not placing the right frame of interpretation on it. The fact that it's dull and meaningless is an indication that the framework is inappropriate. Now, it could be also that you're stuck in a tyranny. There's other reasons, but that's one reason.
- 6.9 If you're sitting listening to a symphony, you might say, well, I've got practical things to do, and you get distracted and you can't listen to the symphony. And you might think, well, the symphony is going to end. Why should I listen to it at all? Or you could do that while you're dancing. It's like, well, that seems stupid. It's like, it's time to dance, not to be thinking about tomorrow. It isn't that you're being blind to the future, although it could be that, but you're not going to be able to dance in the real sense if you're blind

to the future. That just doesn't work because you're just not a good dancer if that's the sort of person you are.

- 6.10** You need to be able to have taken care of things well enough, so that you can concentrate on the present and you can immerse yourself in it completely. The more you've actually taken care of the future in the deepest sense, the better you are at focusing on the present. That's actually a major theme that's developed in the Sermon on the Mount, because as we'll see, Christ tells people in terms of how to live as well, focus your attention on the highest thing, 100%. Having done that, pay maximal attention to the present, and you get your cake and eat it, too, that way. There are also preconditions for one another, because if you're going to pay attention to your wife, for example, in the deepest possible sense, you're only going to do that properly if you're oriented towards the highest good in your relationship.
- 6.11** The structure that directs your attention is —this is new discoveries—the structure that orients your attention is your ethical framework. Those are the same thing because it's a hierarchy of perceptual prioritization. With your kids, what are you going to pay attention to? Well, how about the good things they do? Now, you're going to attend to some of the things they do that aren't so good because you've got to put a halt to them, but that's within a broader framework of facilitating the good things they do. Then the better you are at knowing what's good, the more accurate you're going to be in your perceptions of what's good in your children, obviously.
- 6.12** How could it be any other way? You do target your perceptions to your goal. Obviously. Think about what you do when you drive. You limit your perceptual world to all those things in the world that allow you to make progress towards your goal. And you're driving all the time. Well, maybe not when you're asleep, but then you're dreaming, so even then.
- 6.13** "For if you forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you." That's a reciprocity statement, again, except there's a disjunction in level of equality there. So the idea is that your conscience calls you out, and there's no escape from that. And that's a very interesting thing because, well, it's your conscience. Why can't you just tell it what to do? And you can't. If you do, it just gets worse. It doesn't get better. It's like an autonomous entity within you that's orienting you, and some of that is orienting you towards social belonging. Your conscience can be too demanding. You can have a pathological relationship with your conscience, but fundamentally, it'll call you out.
- 6.14** Then you might say, well, there is a line of Christian speculation that the entity conceptualized as the Holy Spirit manifests itself in no small part as the conscience. That's the spirit of the divine within, the judge within. It's not you, that judge. It's abstracted away from you in some sense, and you're subject to it. You don't have to follow its dictates. You still have free will, but it'll tell you. Then you might ask yourself, well, how do you stop from being tortured by your conscience? The answer is, at least

in part, well, that depends on the quality of your relationship with other people. To the degree to which you're harsh and narcissistically judgmental in an attempt to elevate your own moral status in an undeserved way, your conscience will torture you to death. Precise proportion.

- 6.15** It's interesting, too, because that also implies that one of the best ways to rectify your relationship with yourself is to rectify your relationship with other people. Is that there's no difference between those two things, not in the most fundamental sense. Sometimes that's even easier because most people are better at being good to other people than they are at being good to themselves. That's not a bad place to start. You can learn how to treat yourself properly by learning how to treat your kids properly, because you think, well, they need a father or a mother. It's like, so I'd better treat myself properly because otherwise my kids won't have a parent. You can get to love of yourself through love of others. I think it's the most effective possible way.
- 6.16** "But if you forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses." This is not a call for a stupid blanket forgiveness where everything you do is OK. When Christ comes back in Revelation, he is a judge with a sword, and virtually no one passes the judgment. That's because the image of the divine is a combination of judgment and mercy, constantly operating together. It's like, and you do that when you're trying to sort something through with a misbehaving kid. You don't say, well, "Go to hell, kid." You say, well, "Here's some things you did right in this situation, but here's some things that could bear some improvement. So let's walk through them and figure out exactly what you did wrong and what you could have done instead."
- 6.17** That's all within an overarching container of encouraged movement towards something better. So the forgiveness is not in the absence of judgment. That also makes ethics far too easy. It's like, "I don't care what you. I forgive you." It's like, that really doesn't require a lot of work on my part, especially if I'm not called upon to pay for my forgiveness. And you can be called upon to pay for your forgiveness constantly, because if you let people get away with things around you that they shouldn't get away with, then you're definitely going to pay for it. That's especially true in your immediate relationships, especially with your kids.
- 6.18** If you let them rule the roost when they're three, first of all, how demoralizing is that for a kid? It's like, "I'm three and I'm in charge." It's like, "I already hit the pinnacle. And these adults, that's what I'm going to become? They're stupider than me." You think, well, you don't want to interfere with the flowering of your child's spirit. It's like, well, they're going to be an adult for most of their life. One of the things you should model is that that's way better than being a child. Not that there's anything wrong with being a child. Children are quite remarkable and miraculous, but that's not the point.
- 6.19** They still don't know what they're doing. That doesn't mean they're stupid by any stretch of the imagination or that they're not attentive. But you need to help them understand that who they are is beyond who they are, right? Way beyond who they

are. Then that gives them a horizon of opportunity, too, and something to strive for and some wish to become adult. Peter Pan, he doesn't want to grow up. Well, why? Well, he's magic, and he's the king of the Lost Boys, and he's got Tinkerbell. I call her the porn fairy, which I think is quite funny. And why would he want to grow up? All that magic disappears, but he doesn't get Wendy. He doesn't get the real woman. The Lost Boys, well, they're all lost, and the kingdom that he rules doesn't exist. It's all in his imagination. And he thinks of adults as Captain Hook, tortured by mortality and tyrannical. Who wants that? It's like, well, that's not a good vision of adulthood.

6.20 "Moreover, when you fast, be not, as the hypocrites, of a sad countenance; for they disfigure their faces, that they may appear unto men to fast. Verily, I say unto you, they have their reward. But thou—" They have their reward. That's a joke, by the way. This is an injunction against martyrdom. It's like, you can tell how good I am. Look at how much suffering I'm doing for you. And then that's another narcissistic trick. It's like, it's the attempt to utilize pointless suffering. Well, to blame it on you first. "Look at all the sacrifices I have to make for you." And then to use it as evidence of higher order moral striving and moral superiority. And that's what's being warned against here.

6.21 Don't exploit the evidence of your own suffering to elevate yourself up the heavenly hierarchy. That's the idea here. Or you'll get your reward for that, the reward of the martyr, of the false martyr. "But thou, when thou fastest, anoint thine head," that's to shine with oil, "and wash thy face." Look like you're together when you're making a sacrifice. "That thou appear not unto men to fast, but unto thy Father, which is in secret. And thy Father, which seeth in secret, shall reward thee openly." So that's another movement towards the psychological in some sense, or the spiritual or the internal. That's this part of a psychological dialectic instead of a social display.

6.22 "Lay not up for yourselves treasures upon earth, where moth and rust doth corrupt, and where thieves break through and steal." OK, so this is a description of what constitutes true riches. There's another line here. Maybe it's coming right up that man cannot serve Mammon and God, cannot serve wealth and God. People who like to think of Christ as a revolutionary, like to think of that as an anti-capitalist ethos, and that's not what it is at all. It's something much more profound than that. It's that you see this often. Imagine you're rich. Think, OK, you're rich, you're protected. It's like, well, yes, you're not hungry. You don't have to worry about shelter. You might have to worry about maintaining your wealth, and that can be a real worry. But you're not starving and you have shelter and your children have the opportunities that wealth can bring them.

6.23 But the fundamental problems in your life, they're still there. Are you going to get along with your wife? Maybe not at all now that you're rich because that can tear people apart. You're still going to face death. You're still going to face the deterioration of your parents. All the fundamental problems in life can only be addressed to a limited degree with material wealth. I am absolutely 100% not trying to devalue material wealth. I

mean, there are a billion people on the planet who are, like, they're burning dung and they don't know what they're going to have for lunch. This is not good. We do not want that. You're a fool if you despise abundance. You're a fool, and you're a perverse and corrupt fool as well.

6.24 But the truth of the matter is that there are things that are better protections against catastrophe and malevolence than wealth. Character is that, by definition. You might say, well, in a just society, those of a good character are more likely to advance. We actually know this is true because one of the best predictors of success in a capitalist economy is conscientiousness. If you do what you say you will do, you are much more likely to be successful. And so, character is that which generates wealth. And so then, if push comes to shove, imagine that you could be wealthy or you could have your character, or that you could sacrifice your character to be wealthy. Well, it's a bad trade because the reason you want to be wealthy to begin with is to get what only character in the final analysis can deliver. And so that's why this statement lays itself out the way it is.

6.25 "Do not lay yourself, lay up treasures on earth, where moth and rust can corrupt and where thieves break through and steal. But lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where neither moth nor rust doth corrupt, and where thieves do not break through nor steal." So it's a call to a higher form of adaptation, right? Well, if you surround yourself, if you act in a way that ensures that you're surrounded by people who love you and who want to interact with you at every moment, then even when things move up and down, say, sociologically or politically, you're best positioned, in every possible sense of the word, to ride through the chaos. It's way better. And so don't sacrifice your potential, your potential to do good, and the possibility of doing good for the rewards that might be attendant upon doing good because they're not permanent.

6.26 Now look, part of the reason we care about our reputations is because we learned. Creatures who can see the future, that's us. What did we learn? How do we protect ourselves against catastrophe? The answer is by storing our reputation in the souls of other people. That's how we do it. I'll give you an example of that. We're hunters, human beings. We're throwers. Our whole body is a throwing and aiming platform, and we've been hunting forever, and we hunt in groups. Chimps hunt, by the way. It's a very old activity, hunting. Who knows how long for human beings. It's tens of millions of years. It's unbelievably old. We've been using fire for at least three million years to cook meat. It's transformed our whole physiology because, compared to a chimp, we have hardly any digestive tract and way more brain. The reason for that is because we eat meat and because we learned to cook it. It's a very efficient form of food provision, and we hunt.

6.27 But we're not that big, and it's not easy for one person, a man, to take down a mammoth. It's not that easy for 20 naked apes with spears to take down a mammoth, but we killed all the mammoths. And so we got pretty good at it. But in a group, any

given hunter on any given day, no matter how skilled, even in a group, has a pretty low probability of bringing something down. But the group as a whole has a pretty high probability. And so the way that hunting tribes work is that they know who the good hunter is. But if you're a good hunter, it's incumbent upon you, once you bring down an animal, to tell all your friends how lucky you were and how stupid you are and why this was just a fluke, to put yourself down and to give other people a better selection of what you've produced than you take.

6.28 And you could say, well, biologically, why would you do that? It's like, well, you're hungry today, so here's some food, man. I'm hungry tomorrow, and tomorrow it might be stupid you who lucked into the antelope or the mammoth. We literally store our future food in the reputation we have among other people. That doesn't rot. It isn't stolen. It's not eaten by other animals. It's as permanent a storage mechanism as we could envision. That's alluded to here, this heavenly domain is the domain of—it's the domain of ethical action. And so the idea here is, you strive forward in the most ethical possible manner. And by doing so, that's how you gain the real treasure.

6.29 And then it's not just security, the security you have in being the trading partner with competent other people, but it's also, well, esteem. People want to have you around. They invite you to do things with them. They invite you along on their adventures, and it's all genuine. How is that not wealth? When people envision what wealth could buy, if they have any sense at all, that's what they envision. The problem with doing it with money is, and you see this happens to people who gain money rapidly, say, or celebrities, is like, once you have the wealth, are those friends? And sometimes the answer is yes, but the moral hazard is obviously there. It's not, well—and that's what this all means—it's not the most effective treasure. Character is. Period.

6.30 I think that all the lines of evidence support that idea. The biological lines, the economic lines, the theological lines, the philosophical lines. It's like, this isn't a proposition. This is a description of the true nature of reality. So there isn't anything better than being good. And you think, well, of course there isn't because that's true by definition. The best thing to be is what's good. And then you might think, well, why would you ever doubt that? Well, it's because you doubt there's good. Do you doubt there's evil? That's a lot harder question. And if you do, you're a fool, and you're probably a fortunate fool. But if there's evil, well, then there's good. It's at least the opposite of what evil is. And evil is real. It's not the most real thing, but it's in the top two.

6.31 "For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also." Well, that's also such a useful line, too. It's like, well, what's more important to you? Your character and your reputation or your wealth? You're going to be called upon to make a decision between those two quite often, maybe daily. And then you need to know because you might think, well, I could just bend things around here. Save me a million dollars. Why wouldn't I bend it? It's like, what's more important to you? And what makes you think

that bending things like that is actually going to, well, let's say, protect you? Well, there's pride in that, too. I can get away with it just this once. It's like, yeah, no, that isn't how it works.

6.32 "The light of the body is the eye. If therefore thine eye be single, thy whole body shall be full of light." Yeah, amazing lines. "The light of the body is the eye." OK, so what does that mean? Enlightenment, illumination, daylight, vision, envisioning, all of that, visionary. It's all eye-focused. Why? Well, we're awake during the day. We're not nocturnal creatures. And so consciousness for us is associated with the light because we're conscious during the day. And why visually? Well, we're visual animals. The only animals that see better than us are birds of prey. That's it. And here's something so cool, too. Among our primate relatives, the primates with the best vision are those that have the most poisonous snakes around. And so that's cool because part of our visual system, especially the bottom half, is optimized to detect poisonous serpents. And so the snake gave us our vision. The snake and the fruit gave us our vision. We see colors because we're fruit-eaters and we can discriminate between ripe fruit and leaves.

6.33 And so, as it is laid out in the story of Adam and Eve, the scales fall from eyes and our eyes open up. We become enlightened and illuminated because of eating the fruit of the tree that's offered by the snake. It's like, yeah, that's exactly what happened on the evolutionary front. So that's pretty damn funny. And so the eye is—now, the eye is a very interesting symbolic phenomenon, representation, because the eye isn't the Luciferian intellect, right? Because you might think, well, attention and cognition, or attention and thought, they're the same thing. They're not. Thought follows attention. Attention is primary. And that's why the heavenly hierarchy is a hierarchy of the prioritization of attention. You should pay attention to what's important, but you also do. The fact that you pay attention to it indicates that, in your hierarchy of ethics, that's what's important.

6.34 Then the question is, what should you pay attention to? That's, well, that's the question that's being asked here. You should focus your eyes on a distant star and navigate forward in that manner. Then you see, then what reveals itself to you, is that which is in most accord with your aim. And that's actually how you're set up physiologically. Think about it. You're driving down the road. What do you see? You see everything that's relevant to the car. You don't pay any attention to anything else, and you shouldn't. And so what it means is that when you focus on your destination, the world reveals itself as a place of, they call them affordances, that will move you forward and also obstacles to your pathway.

6.35 That's literally how perception works. Specify your aim, the world lays itself out in accordance with your aim, and then things will object to your aim. Those are objects. They get in your way. And then you can interrogate the object to find out how to maneuver around it or how to utilize it as a tool. Then it's no longer something that objects. You can learn from that. That's the scientific enterprise is the interrogation of

what objects, the objective world. That's so useful to know, and it's deeper than that, because not only once you specify your aim, not only does the world lay itself out in accordance with your aim in terms of your perception, but so do your emotions, because when you specify an aim and you see a pathway forward, you feel positive emotion. When you see an obstacle or something you don't understand, then you feel negative emotion.

- 6.36** Those are markers for those things. Positive emotion says, pathway open. Negative emotion says, stop or danger here. And so you specify your aim; you lay out the landscape of perceptual objects, and you lay out your emotions. And so then the whole question starts to become, what are you aiming at? The word sin, and the equivalent word in Hebrew, by the way, from which the word sin wasn't derived, because sin was derived from a Greek word, "hamartia", which is the archery term. The Hebrew word, I don't remember, but it has the same etymological history. Sin means to miss the target. It's hamartia; it's an archery term. That means to miss the target, to fail to hit the target.
- 6.37** How? No target. There's one way. How are you going to hit the target if you don't have one? Maybe you have 20 targets. You're not going to hit them simultaneously, and it's just going to be distracting. Or you have a target and you aim somewhere else. Well, and that's a really useful thing to know, too. That idea is that, well, to be in sin is to not have specified the target or to take aim properly. And so, "the light of the body is the eye," the eye, the attention. Horus, that Egyptian God I talked to you about, the eye that everyone knows, the famous symbol of the Egyptian eye. That's Horus. Horus was also a falcon who could see everything. And the Egyptians knew, the Egyptians believed that the proper sovereign was half Horus. So half the eye, the attentive eye, the living eye.
- 6.38** On the back of the American dollar bill, there's a pyramid, and at the top of the pyramid, there's an eye, and the pyramid top is detached from the pyramid. That's because the eye is not part of the pyramid. It's the thing to which the whole pyramid is subordinate. Pyramids have that structure all over the world. The Egyptian pyramids had a cap on it. It was a gold cap, if I remember correctly. That's because the Egyptians knew that the thing at the top of the hierarchy was not part of the hierarchy. The Washington Monument in Washington, which is the centerpiece in Washington, it's a Neolithic phallus in some real sense, a stone monument that has a pyramid on the top. The pyramid on the top has an aluminum cap. The reason it's aluminum is because aluminum was more expensive than gold when they made the Washington pyramid.
- 6.39** It's all this attempt by people to think, well, what should be at the top? What's at the top? The eye, the sun, the falcon, vision, enlightenment, illumination, the star, all of that associated with vision. Vision is so important to us. Like our eyes, for example, our eyes are evolved. We have these very obvious whites. It's a very peculiar element of human eyes. Why? Because that enables other people to really see our eyes. Why do

you want to see someone's eyes? Because you know where they're pointing their attention. And why do you want to know that? Because then you can see what they're up to. And as soon as you can see what they're up to, you can be up to that, too, and then you can understand them. It's like, "Aha, I see what you're up to. I've got your number." And sometimes that can be really playful and fun, but sometimes it can be, "I know what you're doing now because I see where you're pointing your attention."

6.40 And so what that means is, in our whole evolutionary past, all those people whose eyes did not signal their intent either failed to reproduce or were killed. That's how crucial this is. We align ourselves with vision. If you and I share a vision, well, first of all, we know what that means, and we use a visual metaphor, but it also means that we've brought our deepest self physiologically and spiritually into alignment. We've both agreed that that's the hill we're climbing. So now I can understand you because, if you have that goal, you see the same things I do, and you respond emotionally the same way. And so now I know who you are. You're just like me. It's a mirror. And now we can cooperate and even compete. Because if you're playing basketball against another team, the goal is the same. Fundamentally, it's to play basketball. I mean, there's a sub goal which is winning, but the goal is the same. And so you can compete without conflict when you have a shared goal.

6.41 And so it's crucial. And then you might say, well, what is the shared goal that should unite a whole society or a person? And that's partly what the Sermon on the Mount is about. It's like, what should you be aiming at? Well, it's something like the city on the hill. And that's the kingdom of heaven that's within, but also without at the same time. It's the alignment of the psychological and the social. And that brings harmony. That's the definition of peace, but not just peace, right? Prosperity. And not just peace and prosperity, but I would say peace, prosperity, and joy all together at once, and maybe security and a place for children to play and all of that.

6.42 "But if thine eye be evil, thy whole body shall be full of darkness." OK, well, that's an echo of the same thing. If you're looking down, if you're aiming down, if your vision is dark, everything about you is dark. And that's because the highest vision encapsulates everything, literally. So, "If therefore the light that is in thee be darkness, how great is that darkness?" Well, you ask yourself, how do cataclysms like the Nazi war come about? And Hitler, he shot himself when Berlin was in flames, when the Germans had abandoned him and betrayed him, and when Europe was in ruins and when the whole world was brought to the brink of apocalyptic disaster. That's exactly what he was aiming for.

6.43 So, "How great is that darkness?" It's not death, that darkness. It's way worse than that. That's why the notion of hell exists, is because there are things that are far worse than death. And definitely the apocalyptic catastrophe that unites hell and death in some sense, that's worse. And so the notion of "how great is that darkness?" It's like, well, how far is down? And the answer is, well, things can be better than they are all the

time, no matter how good they get. But I don't care how deep, and I saw this in my clinical practice all the time, I don't care how miserable you are. You might think you've plumbed the depths of misery. There is a stupid thing you could do that would make it worse. And then when you do that, there's another one you could do that would make it worse.

- 6.44 And that's why hell, in some sense, metaphorically, is a bottomless pit. And it's eternal in some sense, because if you're there, it lasts forever. You know what that's like. It's a peculiarity of life. If you're happy, it's like, the days, they just zip by. But if you're miserable, it's like tick, tick. Time just expands and the pain fills all the crevices and it expands out into the eternal.
- 6.45 "No man can serve two masters." This is a call to this monotheistic union of vision and the pyramid with the integrated pinnacle. "For either he will hate the one and love the other, or else he will hold to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and Mammon." Mammon is wealth, essentially, and that desire for security. This is not an anti-capitalist ethos. It's not. One of the things that's very striking about Jewish culture, and Christ was a Jew, is that the Jews really celebrate celebration. They're in love with embodied life. They're not like the Buddhists who are trying to abstract themselves away from the world and say, well, separate yourself from both pain and joy and pull yourself away from the world. The Jews are in life, and they celebrate life more abundant. The celebration, the feast, the family, all those things that are the joys of life.
- 6.46 And Christ is a Jew, and he's also someone who's presented in the Gospels as someone—he hangs around with the ne'er-do-wells, and he drinks wine, and he makes wine at feasts, and he goes to weddings. It's like, if there's a time to have a party, well, he's in on the party. And maybe in some fundamental sense, the party is what it's all about. There's an image of paradise that it's an endless divine banquet, or it's a place of eternal play. There's something about those images that are very profound. This isn't an ascetic ethos. Now, it might be that there are circumstances under which you should put severe constraints on yourself, like in a monastic way, to discipline yourself. That's clearly the case when Christ spends 40 days in the desert, for example; that's exactly what's going on. You want to put some damn serious constraints on yourself to get yourself together.
- 6.47 But the point of the constraints isn't so that you'll be constrained and miserable. The point of the constraints, voluntarily accepted, is so that you'll be disciplined and productive and generous. Well, then that's what you should go do. I have learned, to some degree, when I lectured at Harvard, I lectured about terrible things for a long time, about atrocity and Nazi atrocity and Soviet atrocity. If it was atrocious, then I'd lecture about it. And I had this voice in the back of my head that always said, "If you really mastered this, you could do it with a sense of humor." And I thought, "How the hell can I talk about like Auschwitz with a sense of humor?" It's like, those things just don't seem commensurate, but the voice never went away. And I did learn that, if

you're a master, if you're a master of something, you do it with the lightest possible touch, and to leaven it with humor is a sign of true mastery, which is why we like comedians so much.

6.48 When Christ in the Beatitudes talks about having this, to be the savor, to be the spice in things, it's an injunction towards that, this playful provocativeness, along with a deep seriousness, the melding of those two things. That's a real sign of mastery. "Therefore, I say unto you, take no thought for your life, what you shall eat or what you shall drink; nor yet for your body, what you shall put on. Is not the life more than meat, and the body more than raiment?" And this is definitely Christ the hippie. It's like, tune in, turn on, drop out. Get rid of all that social pressure and just be this free thing. And no, that is not what this means. It isn't what this means at all, because that isn't where this phrase ends.

6.49 "Behold the fowls of the air, for they sow not, neither do they reap, nor gather into barns," so they're not secure. "Yet your heavenly Father feeds them. Are you not much better than they?" Well, birds are guided by instinct, let's say, and they do quite nicely. And so, and "which of you by taking thought can add one cubit unto his stature? And why take you thought for raiment?" Clothing. "Consider the lilies of the field, how they grow. They toil not, neither do they spin." They don't make their own clothes. "And yet I say unto you that even Solomon, the greatest king in all his glory, was not arrayed like one of these. Wherefore, if God so clothe the grass of the field, which today is and tomorrow is cast into the oven, shall he not much more clothe you, O you of little faith?"

6.50 Now, this is when it starts to twist. It's like, because right so far, it's hippy all the way, man. It's like, you don't need clothes. You can frolic naked in the fields and don't be thinking about tomorrow because it'll just take care of itself. It's like, if. Well, first of all, the first reference is to faith. So now all of a sudden faith enters this, right? It's like, you get to do what you should do, what's being recommended, but you have to have faith. And then the question is, well, why? And faith in what? "Therefore, take no thought, saying, what shall we eat? Or what shall we drink? Or wherewithal shall we be clothed?" It's an injunction against that obsessive concern with security and maybe even an obsessiveness about duty because there are sins of conscientiousness. "All we are going to do is work to make sure everything is exactly right all the time."

6.51 Then there's a fear in that, and that fear is a reflection in some sense of lack of faith. But conscientious and dutiful striving is also indistinguishable in some sense from sacrifice. And so these are very tricky judgments. "For your heavenly Father knoweth that you have need of all these things." Now, this is where it flips completely. This is the non-hippy part. "But seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness, and all these things shall be added unto you." Here's the idea. This is the idea. It's like, aim at the highest possible good in every possible way. That's the "be ye therefore perfect, as

the Father in heaven is perfect." Get your aim right. Concentrate on that which is the highest.

- 6.52** Philosopher Kant said, "You should act in a manner so that if everyone duplicated your action, that would be the best possible outcome." There's something about that that's almost exactly right. It's like, you want to act right now in a manner that's in your best interest, but you are extended across time. It has to be in your best interest now and tomorrow and next week and next month and next year and when you're old, all at the same time. Then it also has to include everyone else because after all, there they are, in all their trouble and possibility. And so all that has to be integrated. And so you're aiming at something that integrates across all of that simultaneously. And that's this kingdom of God and his righteousness.
- 6.53** We already went through what righteousness means. And so here's the idea. If you get your aim right, and you get your practice in relationship to that aim right, and so you take that more seriously than anything else, that's what your eye is singly focused on, then you can let the present go without worry. There's an element in here that unites love and truth in some sense. Imagine that to seek the highest good is to act in the spirit of love. And so let's say abundance for all, abundance and joy for all, despite the catastrophe of their suffering, something like that. You've dedicated yourself to that, despite all the counterevidence. Then you have truth to serve in that task. Then if your aim is right and your words are true, then you can not worry in the moment. You can just say what you believe to be the case, and you can have the faith that that will work out better than anything else.
- 6.54** I do believe that's true. I also believe that that's the adventure of your life. It's like, if you're acting in truth oriented towards the good, and if it's you acting, that's you. You get to have your life. By letting go of your life, and that's the other part of this—in some sense, I'm not going to be concerned about protecting myself and making sure I've got what I need and making sure my family's got what I need or what they need. You can understand the attraction of that, and maybe it's better than just a hippie-like carelessness, but it's not the best approach. What's being outlined here is the best approach. This is the best approach in all possible ways.
- 6.55** "Take, therefore, no thought for the morrow; for the morrow shall take thought for the things of itself." There's time to do everything, if your aim and orientation is proper. That's the idea. What you want to do, once you have yourself oriented properly, is maximally focus on the present, and that'll make sure that the things in the present take care of themselves. But this is all presuming the existence of that whole heavenly hierarchy around you. You're oriented properly in relationship to yourself. You're in the right relationship with your significant other. You're nested inside a functional family. That's nested inside a community. All of these intermediary forces, in some sense, or structures are in order. Then you're devoted to the spirit that inhabits that in the highest part of that.

- 6.56 Then you can pay attention to right now, which is what you want to do anyways because you want to be immersed in the moment. You know that because what are you, preoccupied and worried? That's not optimal. Might be better than blind naivety, but it's not optimal, and this is aiming at optimal.
- 6.57 Thank you all for coming again today. I think we've got, if I have got this memorized properly, I think we've got one more chapter, which we should be able to do tomorrow. Thanks again.

Lecture 7: Ask, See, Knock

At a glance — Matthew 7 — 'ask, seek, knock,' the closing chapter.

- 7.1 So today we're in Matthew 7, the closing chapter of the Sermon on the Mount. It begins with another, I would say, injunction of reciprocity. "Judge not that ye be not judged." So it doesn't exactly say don't judge. And that's a very, very important point. So I spent a lot of time reading Carl Jung's commentary on biblical subjects. And one of the things he said about the structure of the Bible as a whole, one of the great mysteries of the Bible is, in some sense, the appendage of the Book of Revelation onto the end of the biblical corpus. It's a very strange book. It's a description of a visionary experience, and it's an extraordinarily surreal and dreamlike book.
- 7.2 It's amazing to me in some sense that the conservative evangelist types are also advocates in some sense of the Book of Revelation because it's a psychedelic phantasmagoria. It's an incomprehensibly strange account. In the book, Christ comes back as the judge of mankind. His judgment is harsh. He has a sword coming out of his mouth. So the sword is something that divides and carves and kills. It's a primary tool. He says, in his judgment, that he reserves his harshest judgment not for those who are hot or cold—so really, in some sense, not for those who are good or evil—the harshest judgment is reserved for those who play both ends against the middle, the hypocrites, which is very interesting.
- 7.3 Jung believed that part of the reason that it was appropriate from a narrative perspective or a psychological perspective. We don't understand such things. We don't understand why the Bible was cobbled together or aggregated or assembled the way it was and why it has the narrative structure that it does. But it ends with Book of Revelation, and in that book, Christ comes back as a judge. And the judgment is very discriminating. So the damned are separated from the saved in some real sense, and it's hard to know exactly what that means. But I think, at least in part, what it means is the same thing as the separation of the wheat from the chaff.
- 7.4 And what that means is that, well, when you're reading or you're thinking or you're interacting with other people, you're trying to separate out what's no longer fruitful, what isn't edible, let's say, what's contemptible and outdated. You're trying to separate that out, not so that you can damn what's useless, but so that you can conserve and utilize what's useful. This is really what you try to teach people to do when you walk them through great books. It's like, well, you have to do some sifting.
- 7.5 There's a line in the story of Noah that Noah was "a wise man in his generations." Very interesting line. It's not immediately obvious what that means, but if you do some background research, you find out that what the writers of that text were saying was, well, as far as a man for his time and place went, he was as good as you could hope for. And that's about as good as any of us could hope for, because we have to adapt to our

time and place. Then when we look back in the past, we have to judiciously conserve what the past offers by making the assumption that not everything that was good in its time is good now. But that doesn't mean that you can just damn everything in the past because the principles that were applied there aren't exactly the same principles we apply now. You want a judicious reading instead, so that you can conserve.

- 7.6 One of the things I always try to do this when I read is, I'm actually trying to read, I'm trying to read to learn, at least insofar as I'm capable of doing that. That's a judicious sifting. That's been real useful to me in reading, for example, sequential clinical philosophers and theoreticians and researchers because they don't agree on everything. They can't all be right in some sense. But I've found—I was trained as a cognitive behavioral psychologist, and they're quite research-oriented and very rationalistic, and they tend to promote themselves as enemies, in some sense, of the Freudian tradition. Some of that's just jealousy, and some of that's a consequence of overreach on the part of the acolytes of Freud.
- 7.7 But it's way better to read Freud and try to learn from what he has to say, because Freud, like so many of the great clinicians and like so many great philosophers, was a great genius. There's an immense amount you can learn, even if some of the Victorian presuppositions that he brought to bear on the situation are perhaps no longer relevant. It's not exactly the issue. But to read is to judiciously aggregate, and to criticize is the same thing. Criticism doesn't mean denigration. It certainly doesn't mean elevating your stealth in moral status in comparison to that which you're criticizing, because that's not criticism at all.
- 7.8 Criticism means—it means to separate the wheat from the chaff. You don't want to presume that this statement means "don't be judicious," because, of course, judicious also means just. You don't want to throw out justice, and you don't want to substitute mercy, only all-encompassing mercy, for justice either. First of all, what do you do with the criminals? And second of all, it's not even helpful for the person you're dealing with. So when I was working as a clinician, we'd walk through people's lives, and they didn't want me to just pat them on the back and say, "Look, everything you did, no matter how catastrophic the consequences, was just all right. And whoever you think you are and whoever you think you want to be, that's just all right, too." It's like, well, how in the world is that possibly helpful? These are very,
- 7.9 very difficult issues. And if you're trying to straighten out your life, you want to sort through the past and you want to figure out what you did wrong so you can stop doing that in the future. But you also mostly want to figure out, in some real sense, well, what did you do right and how can you keep that and build on it? But the statement here is, "Judge not, that you be not judged." The other part of this is whatever measure you use to judge other people. We talked about this at length and already to some degree, is that you will receive what you give. There's no doubt about that. And so you want to

use, well, then you want to have the hand of justice that you wield, let's say, hemmed in by the appropriate mercy.

- 7.10** And you really want to do, you really do want to do to other people what you would like them to do for you, because that is what they're going to do in the most fundamental sense. And then you have to think through that balance between justice and mercy, because you do also want to—you want to hold yourself to a high standard, so you improve and so that you move towards what's positive. Well, so Jung believed that the Book of Revelation was a necessary narrative appendage. Maybe that was the psychological reason for the vision to begin with, because the Christ in the Gospels is presented, to some degree, tilted towards mercy and compassion.
- 7.11** And Jung believed that left a conceptual gap, or a gap in the image of the divine totality, that had to be filled by the revelatory vision of John. And that pertains as well to Jung's theory of dream and visionary imagination, which he regards as compensatory. And so, for example, you have a structure of the world that you hold consciously and explicitly, but it's got all sorts of holes in it, because what the hell do you know? The question is then, what starts to fill in those gaps? For Jung, that was the dream. That was fantasy and fiction and imagination. It surrounds rational cognition and explicit conceptualization. That's the fictional world. The fictional world is the ethical world and the world of character. The dream is strange and paradoxical, partly because it's dealing with the strange and paradoxical. It's dealing with that which has not yet been brought into the rational domain.
- 7.12** All the solid research on dream cognition from a neurophysiological perspective seems to support the Jungian hypothesis that one of the things that happens when you dream is that the integrity of your categorizations loosens. That's why you can have monstrous images in your dream because a monster is a chimera. The categories are mixed and surreal. The reason for that is because, while you're asleep, you're not running around acting out these conceptions. You can dare to dream. You can dare to conceptualize the world other than it might be because, well, you're paralyzed while you're dreaming. You're not going to run out, run around and act it out. And so the dream is an experiment in what could yet be, in some sense.
- 7.13** It's more sophisticated than that because it's not just random, it's purposeful. It's all part of your attempt to fully pattern yourself after the world. And why else would Christ be a judge, necessarily and inevitably, and in some sense, the ultimate judge and the judge at the end of time? And the answer to that is, well, anything that's an ideal is a judge. And this is partly why people want to tear down ideals, because the higher the ideal, the more severely it judges you. And that's because the higher the ideal is, the more distant you are from it, and the more different you are from it. And that can actually be painful if you're in really dire straits, if you're in the seventh rung of hell and you're looking all the way up to heaven. That's an immense gap. And all you'll see in

some sense is a scowling face because everything you do—that's all you may see, because everything you do is just not right at all.

7.14 Then that distance from the ideal can turn you into an enemy of the ideal. That's to some degree what happens to Cain, too, because part of the reason Cain feels so bereft and so fallen is because, well, there's Abel, who's everything he's not. And you can eliminate that gap. This is really worth thinking about, too. You can eliminate that gap by moving toward the good. Or you can eliminate the gap by trying to eliminate the good—and to become an enemy of the good because it judges you so harshly, but then you lose your ideal. Cain says to God, after he commits his terrible crime, that his punishment is more than he can bear. It's not exactly obvious what he means, but part of what he means is, "What are you going to do when you destroy your ideal?" Especially if it really is your ideal.

7.15 I mean, the reason Cain kills Abel is because he really wants to be Abel. And so now Abel's dead. He's slaughtered the ideal. What the hell's left for Cain? He's destroyed that which, by his own account, was what made life worth living for. There's nothing left but, well, there's nothing left but bitterness and hell and vengefulness and death. It's a terrible thing. And so, you have to bear the weight of the ideal. And then we talked also about the fact that you experience, well, you experience psychological unity. And so the absence of confusion and chaos and depression because of an ethical unity—it's the ethical unity of your highest aim holds you together psychologically. It stops you from being particularly anxious, because anxious is a signal of internal disunity and the inability to navigate.

7.16 And so if you blow the ideal, you don't have anything that unites you, and so then you're anxious. If you blow the ideal socially, then there's nothing that unites us socially. Then we're back in the Hobbesian state of nature where everyone's at everyone else's throat. So it's a bloody catastrophe on the negative emotion side. But then it's an equal catastrophe on the positive emotion side. Because if you don't have an aim, which is an ideal, then you cannot experience any joy or any enthusiasm because you only experience those emotions in relationship to a goal. And so you might say, well, why should I bear the burden of positing the ideal? And the answer is, well, there's no place to go without an ideal. There's nothing but anxiety and misery without an ideal, and there's no hope.

7.17 So that seems like a pretty high price to pay for desecration of the ideal. And so instead, you say, well, then how do you bear the ideal, given that you're so imperfect and that it judges you so harshly? And the answer to that is, that's the answer of humility. It's like humility in faith. It's like, "Yeah, I'm not everything I could be. I accept that. I also have the faith that I could, in good will, move towards the ideal and bridge that gap." That's not a defense, exactly. It's not a defense against the ideal. It's a way of mediating between yourself and the ideal. We talked yesterday about the fact that good prayer is "what am I doing that's stupid and destructive, that I could change, that I would

change?" That's a prayer of humility in some fundamental sense. It's like, I'm not the ideal. I know how I deviate, but I won't even change because I'm too stubborn to do that. But there's some little thing I might change.

- 7.18** And then at least the pathway to the ideal opens up, right? And maybe in steps that you could actually take. And as soon as the pathway opens up, then really the ideal is beckoning to you instead of just judging you and saying, well, at least you're on the right track. And that's as good as, in some sense, in some real sense, that's about as good as it gets. To be on the right track is to be in the right place because it's a continually expanding horizon of possibility. You're never going to accomplish the final end. And so in some real sense, the best you can be is on the right track. And that's again why, when Christ talks about concentrating on the day, well, he says the proper moral orientation is to orient yourself towards the highest good, but then to concentrate on the day. Then the hint there is that the paradise is actually to be found in the attitude towards the journey, rather than in the place itself.
- 7.19** It's an unbelievably sophisticated conceptualization, too, because then the promised land isn't precisely the final destination of the land of milk and honey, where it's just plenitude and abundance. That's good, and let's not criticize that, but that isn't all you want in a situation like that. You still want something to do, and it should be something adventurous. And so it's a union in some sense of the destination and the path at the same time. And that's the highest place. It's a place in a process simultaneously. I suppose it's being and becoming simultaneously, because otherwise, even if it's paradise, it has all the hallmarks of a static situation.
- 7.20** Dostoevsky, in *Notes from Underground*, he talked about the problem with utopianism. He said, "You just don't understand human beings." If you gave them nothing but cakes, and allowed themselves to do nothing but busy themselves with the continuation of the species—it's a very funny section—he says, "The first thing people would do is break things just so that something interesting would happen." That's an original sin doctrine. It's a serpent doctrine. But it's also, it's unbelievably true, right? Is that, well, if you had everything you wanted and you were bored, it's like, well, "Let's see what sort of trouble we could get up to." Because just having what you want isn't enough. You want what you want, plus you want a challenge. The challenge implies in some sense that you haven't got everything either that you want or need, no matter how perfect the state. Then you think, well, the state has to be—the final state of proper being has to be some mediation between being and becoming.
- 7.21** "With what judgment you judge, you shall be judged; and with what measure you mete, it shall be measured to you again." That's another emphasis. This happens continually in the Sermon on the Mount, that you really have to conceptualize yourself as a community. If you're not, you're not conceptualizing yourself properly. We talked about the fact that you are in a real sense as a mature adult who can see the future. You are a community across time because you have to act so that, well, you don't want

to drink too much tonight because then tomorrow you're going to be in pain and useless. You might think like Homer Simpson thinks, when he drinks a quart of vodka with mayonnaise, he thinks, "That's a problem for future Homer." And so you don't want to fall prey to that sort of delusion. You want to treat yourself in the present as if you're something that unfortunately propagates across time.

7.22 But not only that, that you have to deal with other people continually in this iterative game, and an ethic emerges out of that iterative game. And that's a higher ethic, and it's the ethic—it's the sustaining of that iterative ethic across your iterations and across other people that constitutes the basis for a stable polity, and that's a polity not based on power or domination or hedonism. None of that, in large part because it just doesn't work. It's instead something based on the orientation towards the highest good and a radical reciprocity, where there is no distinction made between the individual and the community, in the most real sense.

7.23 And so that's also why Christ says that you have to treat your—you have to love your neighbor. But more than that, you have to treat your enemy as yourself. And that's such a complicated idea, too, because the ultimate enemy is the spirit of Lucifer, let's say, and that's the spirit of nihilism and outrage and contempt and vengefulness and hopelessness and resentment and pride. All of those things, deceit, all of those things. It's like, well, that's you. That's in you. That's the place to confront it. And you confront that all the time. You know, literally, you confront that all the time, because when you're making a decision at any choice point, and every move of your head is that, you're either aiming up or you're aiming down or you're playing both ends against the middle, in which case that's even worse.

7.24 And so, you know, angel on one shoulder, devil on the other, guiding you forward. And that's a very useful imagistic representation and narrative trope. And so then when you're interacting with other people, understand the judgment that you use when you judge books, when you judge art, when you look and evaluate anything as you practice that process of evaluation. That is how you will evaluate yourself and how others will evaluate you. Because if you're honing your evaluative tools and practicing that, well, of course, that's what you're going to apply to yourself because that's what you're developing as a toolkit.

7.25 You want to think, well, how would I like to—if I could be judged in the manner that I would want to be judged, and that wouldn't mean not being judged at all because you could use some improvement, how would it be that I would be judged? Then it's a complicated thing to sort out, but you can certainly practice that in your relationship with other people. Then they'll reflect that back to you, and you can see if it's working. But it's also, it is definitely tooling the implicit and automatic psychological processes that you will most definitely use to judge yourself.

7.26 And so, that's definitely worth thinking about, especially if you're obsessively neurotic and depressed and hard on yourself. You have that superego that just won't quit. It's

like, well, you could practice being a little better to other people, right? To get that balance between mercy and acceptance and judgment right. Very difficult thing to do. I do think, too, that that's related to this idea about being the savor of the earth, the salt of the earth, and to be that which gives what would otherwise be bland some spice. Because I think part of the way that you balance that justice and mercy is likely with play and humor. That all pulls in.

- 7.27** The spirit of play is provocative to some degree. There's a judgmental aspect to it and a challenging aspect because a lot of play is mock battle, let's say. That seems to be, maybe that's the pathway that enables you to —because it's so spontaneously enjoyable, that play. It's a marker that things are optimized. We know, too, the neurobiologists who've studied play, we know it's very fragile. The play spirit can be inhibited by any motivational or emotional state. It only emerges when they're all optimized. It's like a signal of optimization. It's things are so good here, you can afford to play. Maybe that's what you're trying to set up around you all the time. The walled garden is a place of nature and possibility. It's protected enough so that you can play.
- 7.28** That's something fathers should set up in a household. We'll get the security here, not so that everyone is always behaving all the time, but so that the proper amount of free play can emerge within the confines of the system. It's a lovely vision, if it's true, that the optimized social structure is characterized by the spirit of play. I can't really imagine anything better than that. If that was true, and I think it might be true. It looks like it's true. If it is true, you really couldn't imagine anything better than that, because people play sports and they love that and they play music and they go to plays. And it's the highest, in some sense, it's the highest form of culture. And we love it. We love it.
- 7.29** Human beings are neotenists. And what that means is, in the evolution, you see this proclivity of species to evolve towards their juvenile form. So, for example, our skulls are the same shape as chimpanzee infant skulls. As the chimps mature, their skulls change shape substantially, but our skulls look just like chimpanzee infant skulls. We are infant chimpanzees in some—adult infant chimpanzees—in some real sense. What that means in part is human beings have never lost their spirit of juvenile play. That's something else that makes us quite remarkable.
- 7.30** "Why behold thou the mote that is in thy brother's eye, but considerest not the beam that is in thine own eye?" There's another commentary on judgment to some degree. I saw careless students and careless professors again do this with great thinkers of the past, where they'll find one mistake they made, said something careless, or I don't know what it is, misogynist or racist or bigoted. They made some ethical error, and they just say, "Well, we don't have to pay any attention to that person at all anymore." Well, first of all, it's pretty convenient that you can feel morally superior to Nietzsche. It's like, great, man, that's a hell of an accomplishment for an academic or certainly for someone who's 19. It's like, "I don't have to read that philosopher because look at me!" That's just not helpful at all.

- 7.31 What you're supposed to be doing, in some sense, and exactly that, is the beam that is in your own eye, it's like, well, the idea here is that, why are you bothering telling someone else that their vision is partially obscured by something absolutely tiny and almost nonexistent when you have a whole log stuck in your head and you're so blind, you're just running into everything ? And so the notion here, it's associated with this idea of judgment, is that even when you're talking to other people, partly what you're trying to do, even if they're critical and damning and harsh, is you might be able to sort out something from the criticism they're directing at you that's useful.
- 7.32 And in some sense, and maybe this ties back to the idea that you're blessed if you're judged exceptionally harshly, which is a tough one to reconcile. It's like, well, if you really come after me, even if it's 95% just vitriol, if it's 5% useful, and I wouldn't have got that without all the vitriol, which is highly possible, it could be that your enmity is, if I pay attention to it properly, and if I accept it to the degree that I can, that it will prepare me so that I fix something now that I wouldn't have fixed if I—until I hit a really solid obstacle moving forward.
- 7.33 And so your most vicious enemy, in some sense, you can see where they might be your best friend in that way, because they'll go at you even for subtle things. And that means that they might be able to help you repair those subtle things. That doesn't make it easy to bear. But you get the point. Even under conditions where enmity and hostility is being directed towards you, you still have the opportunity to separate out the wheat from the chaff. And it's also why it's so useful to go talk to people who you don't agree with, which I find very interesting. It's one of the things I loved about my clinical practice. I've had a fortunate life, especially in the last 10 years, because I've been exposed to lots of people who are really different from me. I'm very curious, like, well, why do you think that? That's just not what I think at all. How in the world did you possibly come to that conclusion?
- 7.34 Carl Rogers, who's a great philosopher of listening, he said, "People generally don't have the moral courage to listen." Because when you meet someone who really not only is different from you in the way they conceptualize the world, but is antagonistic to your own view, it's very difficult to be empathic enough to listen, because that's a real challenge to your viewpoint. It's way easier for me to think, well, "You're just the devil himself. You've got nothing to say," because then I don't have to take your criticism seriously. If they're profound, it's pretty damn easy for me to not have to take your criticism seriously. So here, the idea here is you should attend to your own blindness. And that just seems like a perfectly reasonable proposition, but a difficult one.
- 7.35 "Or how will thou say to thy brother, 'Let me pull the mote out of thine eye,' and behold, a beam is in thine own eye. Thou hypocrite, first cast out the beam out of thine own eye, and then thou shalt see clearly to cast out the mote, to cast the mote out of thy brother's eye." Well, that makes reasonable sense, too, right? Because you think,

you put yourself together, so your judgment is now the appropriate balance of mercy and justice, and you're discriminating in the highest sense. Then when you try to help someone, first of all, they might allow you to do that, which is sort of like performing surgery. Second, you might be able to make those. Because you've already done this for yourself, you might be able to make those fine distinctions that can help people even improve if all that's impairing their vision is a dust speck and not a whole log.

7.36 And so part of this sequence of verses is predicated on the supposition that you actually can't act as a moral social agent until you've cleaned the debris out of your own vision. You've cleared the debris from your own vision. And of course, we've already talked about the significance of vision. That's mostly attention. It's that open state of watching and listening. That's an opening up to a revelation from the world. If your vision is impaired and cloudy because of your presuppositions and your own internal tyranny, let's say, then you're not open to that attentive gaze. Then if you don't pay attention, well, you can't dance with someone if you don't pay attention to them. That's part of how women evaluate men and vice versa.

7.37 That dance is like, can you pay attention while you keep your bloody hands to yourself at least 15 seconds? Can you pay attention to how we're both moving at the same time? Is there play in the system, in the most fundamental sense? Can you pay attention to multiple things at the same time? Can you bring yourself into harmony with the music and the other people on the dance floor, and me? And can you do that in a manner that's playful and maybe also a bit provocative? All that's being evaluated in the dance, and to dance properly, you really have to pay attention.

7.38 Then you might say, well, if you're a man dancing with a woman, what are you paying attention to? The answer is, if you're only paying attention to her as a sexual object, then you can't dance. You're too preoccupied. You have to be paying attention to the harmony in the interaction, and that has to be superordinate. So that's all an evaluation. It's so interesting. That's all an instantaneous evaluation of a deeply embedded ethic. So you just say, well, "He lacks grace." Well, that's an interesting way of phrasing it because grace, well, that's the grace of God. And to say, to be graceful is to, what would you say, compliment someone on their ability to dance. Well, that's a divine dance in some real sense. And we're very, very sophisticated in evaluating such things.

7.39 "Give not that which is holy unto the dogs, neither cast ye your pearls before swine, lest they trample them under their feet, and turn again and rend you." This is a rough verse. "Do not cast pearls before swine," right? Because obviously, he's not talking about pigs. He's saying, "Do not waste what is holy on what is unfit." And you think, well, that's rough. You want to elevate the unfit, let's say. I've thought about that a lot. One of the things I learned, again, as a clinician, watching people and listening to them, and watching them watch and listen to me, is like, well, when do they not listen? The

answer to that, to some degree, is when I'm not saying the thing that's right for the situation.

7.40 You'll see this when you're interacting with people. Maybe they're troubled people and they come to you for advice, say. That's what they tell you. But when you give them advice, they don't listen at all. They literally don't listen. You can tell that while you're talking to them. But even if they act like they're listening, they don't do anything differently. So they really didn't listen. Why, then, if you told them something that was useful, and they want help, did they not listen? The answer is, well, in some sense, you're casting pearls before a swine. You're pitching your ethical injunction at a level that supersedes their position.

7.41 And so they can't listen. They're afraid of it. They feel it as a judgment, or they're cynical about it. That can't be the case. And that's partly the consequence of their blindness, is that you have to find out where the person will listen. And so here's a way of understanding this, is if you're talking to someone and they aren't listening, you are not where you think you are, and you are not talking to who you think you're talking to. Now, who knows who you're talking to? One of the things you see in clinical practice is that if you stumble across a complex, be a partial subpersonality, that's a way of thinking about it because none of us are fully unified.

7.42 You get angry and you say a bunch of things, and then you stop being angry and you think, "What the hell was that? What came over me?" That can happen if you're tired or under the sway of any powerful motivational impulse. It's a fragmentary personality, and those can be quite complex. Sometimes they can be—Freud noticed this very clearly—sometimes you're talking to someone and all of a sudden you're talking to a part of them that's 10 years old. It's a part that never developed past 10, for God only knows what reason. They hit some barrier in their development on that dimension, at that age, and that's where they're at.

7.43 And so, if you're open to that, you can sort of see it. And you'll say to people sometimes, well, you're just being immature. Well, sometimes that's just literally the case. And then you're talking to that part of them as if it's an adult. It's like, that isn't going work. So then you think, OK, the person is not responding to what you're offering. So in some fundamental sense, you're offering the wrong thing. And this is even true if the person you're talking to is so messed up, you can hardly believe it. You think, well, it's 95% you. It's like, could be, but you're still doing it wrong. You're not making contact. This is a very difficult thing, obviously a very, very difficult thing to learn.

7.44 Then you can experiment. It's like, well, what is this person willing to listen to? And part of the answer to that might be nothing. All they want to do is talk. I had clients, they probably talked to me in our sessions—it's hard to believe because I'm so talkative—they talked to me 95% of the time. I had one client, I saw this person for 10 years, and I learned. It took me a year, probably, because it was really hard to talk to her. It was

always awkward. There was never a dance, and it was always as if she was reacting to me like I was imposing on her. I'd try all sorts of different tactics. She wasn't socially skilled, and she was very socially anxious, and she was very isolated. Definitely, part of her problem was that she couldn't dance.

- 7.45 But I found that if I just listened to her for, like, 45 minutes in the hour-long session, at the end, we could talk. And then I learned that she was alone and she only saw me once every two weeks. And she actually needed just to come and say all the things she'd been thinking, because that was thinking. She had no one to talk to. So she had to come out there and lay out all the crazy thoughts she had. And they weren't all crazy. Some of them were right, some of them weren't. But she didn't know which ones were which, and she didn't have anybody to talk to. And so if I just let her talk, eventually we could talk.
- 7.46 And then I found that as our sessions progressed over many years, that the amount of time that she had to spend doing that would decrease. Then by the time we had come to a decade, I would say, of therapy, she'd come in and then she'd just have to talk for 15 minutes. But then we could have a conversation. By then, she had a lot of friends, and she's actually doing stand-up comedy by then, which was—this was a person who was so timid to begin with that she literally could not have a coffee with me in a cafe when she first met me, even though I was a therapist and we do that privately. That was impossible. And so she'd come a long, long way. But she had, like, 10,000 hours of unsaid things to say. And she was a person who, in many ways, no one had ever really paid attention to. She was just full of undigested material, and she had to listen.
- 7.47 And so if someone's not listening to you, shut up. It's not working. The tendency is to double down. "You're not listening to me." Sometimes, rarely, never in a clinical setting. That never works in a clinical setting, or virtually never. I'm not sure it ever works, period. But it's really useful to know that, well, this conversation is discontinuous. It's full of non sequiturs. There's no dance here. It's boring. It's not going anywhere. It's like, well, what's going on? Well, part of it is, you're not where you think you are, and you're not talking to who you think you're talking to. They're not talking to who you think they're talking to either, because God only knows who they think you are.
- 7.48 That's especially true in the beginning of a therapeutic relationship, but it's not much different at the beginning of a romantic relationship. Man will just assume that you're whatever his image is of a generic and then idealized woman because he wouldn't want to go out with you if the ideal wasn't there. He's going to make that assumption. God only knows, for example, how many times he's been judged by that ideal desirable woman. You're going to be carrying all that. That's the image of the anima, by the way. That's from the Jungian perspective.
- 7.49 It's a projection. What's a projection? Well, it's all the assumptions I make about you because I assume that, depending on why we're meeting, but I assume you have the qualities of a generic man, because obviously I'm going to start with that. But if you're

attracted to someone, it's like, you have all the qualities of a generic desirable person. And then, well, that sets up all sorts of weirdnesses instantly. A whole bunch of the confusion that arises in a romantic relationship is that you get annoyed because the person doesn't live up to your image of the ideal that you've projected on them. And so, the ideal—that's a fair thing because you want to call that forward, but it does interfere with the establishment of a personal relationship. And so.

- 7.50** "Neither cast ye your pearls before swine." And then it gets worse. "Lest they trample them under their feet," so destroy them, "and turn again and rend you." And so it's not merely that you have to be careful about what you say in each situation, but that there's a real risk if you deliver the wrong message, even if it's right in the most fundamental sense, at the wrong time and to the wrong people—that not only is that a practical mistake, let's say, and a procedural mistake, but there's a real danger in it, in that what you're offering can be turned against you and might be and perhaps will be.
- 7.51** You could see that, too. If you're inviting people towards an ideal which they've rejected and that terrifies them, they're going to use even the arguments that you're formulating to make a case for that ideal as a defense against having to move towards it. So. And it's also an injunction about humility. Again, I can't emphasize how important this is, this listening element. Carl Rogers, he had a great technique. It's so smart. It's been the basis of much peacemaking in the last 50 years at the international level, like truth and reconciliation committees and all of that, and these committees that are set up to try to bring peace to warring nations. They're all predicated on this Rogerian approach, and it's predicated in turn on the "dialogos" idea, that redemption can be achieved through honest communication.
- 7.52** It's a deeply Christian idea, although it also has echoes in the Jewish prophetic tradition. Rogers suggests that if you listen to someone —because you're not going to want to listen, especially if they don't agree with you and they're critical. You're not going to want to listen, obviously. How do you check yourself against that? This is so useful. If you have an argument with someone you love, this is unbelievably useful. It's like, I'm going to listen to you. I'm not going to say anything. I'll listen till you're done, till you think it's my turn. Then I'm going to tell you what you just told me, but you have to agree with it. That means you have to put yourself in the other person's position. You can't straw-man them because they get to tell you if you got it right.
- 7.53** What Rogers said, and this is definitely true, he said, "If you do this with people you're arguing with, the first thing that will happen is a huge amount of the emotional tension will go out of the argument." That has nothing to do with whether or not you've decided to agree. Just because I can summarize your argument doesn't mean I agree. But what you do is, you signal to the other person that you regard their utterances as worthy of processing. That's something because everyone wants to be treated as if they're worth paying attention to. I would say we want that more than anything else. If you offer that to someone, they're pretty damn happy with you right off the bat.

- 7.54** Then if you, especially if you summarize properly because they think, well, "Not only did you listen, but you got it." Then another thing that happens is maybe someone talks to you for 20 minutes, and you summarize it. You're not going to summarize it in 20 minutes. You're going to condense it. And so what you offer back to them is a condensed and simplified and streamlined version of what they said, and that's a real gift. They really like that because you don't want to carry around 50,000 words with you to try to conceptualize something, if you can sum it up in a three-minute summary. It's like, you got the point, you got the moral of the story, you got the punchline of the joke. And so they really know that not only did you listen, but you understood.
- 7.55** And then you'll also find that that separates a lot of chaff from wheat, because when you do that summary, a bunch of things that aren't relevant go away. And so it clears the argumentative floor. It's like, well, what are we arguing about? That's what most arguments are about. It's like, "You're upset with me," especially in relationships. You're upset with me. Why are you upset? Well, it's because my grandfather sexually abused my grandmother. It's like, how the hell are you going to know that? It just pops up in the middle of your life in some horrible argument you're having. You have no idea why.
- 7.56** The other person doesn't either. They have no idea why they're upset with you, and they have some proximal reason. It's like, really? You're that upset about that? Why does that bother you? Well, it bothers me because it reminds me of this. That's the psychoanalytic free association. Bothers me because of this, and that reminds me of this. Then I remembered this, and this happened. Oh, wait a moment. I remember my mom reacting like that. So you get this whole fleshing-out of the conceptualization. None of that happens without that listening. Then you can summarize all that and you can get to the point. All of that—you find out, too, doing that, that a lot of this has nothing to do with the issue at hand or even about your relationship. It's some bloody heritable terror in the conceptual web that no one has sewed up yet.
- 7.57** These are very painful things to do within the confines of a relationship. You really stumble across them. If your partner or you are particularly unreasonable, repetitively, about the same thing, you think, oh, my God, what's under that? It's like, oh, who knows what's under that. Like, layers and layers of catastrophe. It's very painful to wade through that. But if you wade through it and sort it out, it disappears. You don't have to carry it forward. Plus, it's a great benefit to your partner because your brain is set up. Your brain basically calculates how much of the world you've mastered, compared to how much is left dangerous. The more that's left dangerous, the more chronically stressed you are, logically enough. This is partly why people lower in hierarchies of social competence die sooner, because more of the world is uncertain to them. So they burn themselves up in an attempt to be ready to move. If you sift through your past and you update your map so that

- 7.58 you're at the deepest levels of your psycho-physiological structure, you know that you're on familiar territory where what you do will work. The more the whole territory that you've traversed is characterized by that representation, the healthier you will be. So the longer you'll live, the slower you'll age. It's directly proportionate to that psycho-physiological stress that burns up the future in the service of the present. And so you can help people tremendously by listening to them, and they sort through that and update their map. And that's what you do when you reconcile yourself to a trauma.
- 7.59 It's not catharsis. It's not just emotional expression. You have to listen to how I was upset. That isn't what's happening. The upset comes along and it signifies the tear in the map, but it isn't the expression of the emotion that's curative. It's the regenerating of the map or the updating of the map, because then, well, then if something terrible happened to you in the past and you sort it out, you set yourself up so that if the same circumstance arises, that same terrible thing won't happen to you in the present or the future. So you can be calm. Because you might ask, well, how can I be calm given that such terrible things happened to me? Well, I'm prepared now so that I won't replicate them. That's how your cognition and your emotion interact.
- 7.60 Your emotional systems are always checking it out. Because they are alarm systems, like, do you know where you are? Do you know where you're going? Do you know what you're doing? The answer to that had better be yes, because otherwise you wander off the path and into a pit, or some horrible dragon eats you. And there's some utility in being concerned about that, let's say.
- 7.61 "Ask and it shall be given you. Seek, and you shall find. Knock, and it shall be opened unto you." This is a beautiful painting, this painting. It's a stunningly beautiful painting. And what I really love about it, apart from the image of the sun behind Christ—that's what a halo is, by the way. A halo is a moon or a sun. And why is that? Well, it's because you assimilate the figure of value to the cosmic light. And so you put the sun behind the king. That's what a gold coin is, is the sun behind a king, or a silver coin. That's why in Canada, at least, we have our queen on the dimes and the quarters. It's a symbol of value, while she's a representation of divine order within cosmic order. What would you say? Illuminated, illuminated at the same time.
- 7.62 And it's silver and gold, that's moon and sun, fundamentally. And so they're the lights that guide you in the darkness during the day and at night, the lesser light and the greater light. And so that's what a halo is. That's cool. There's some idea, too, that the crown of the thorn, crown of thorns, is also a solar image. Because Christ is a cosmic figure. And so the crown of thorns, that's part of the glory that's associated with the conquering of death, is also a solar image. And so that's very cool and very hard to explain these stories. They have these cascading symbolic associations.
- 7.63 And you think, well, what are you just reading that in or did that get built into the story? And what you find is, the more deeply you investigate the story, you see that it's built in. You're not reading it in. It's not just built in. It's echoed endlessly, like hundreds

of times. So the notion that it's some accidental metaphorical overlay or that you're just reading it in, it's like, no, not at all. When you look at this painting, one of the things that's so remarkable about the painting is the use of light on Christ's face. It's beautiful. The colors are stunning in this painting. The palette is amazing. But the use of light is so utterly profound. And there's a peace about it, too. It's a great painting.

7.64 Anyways, so Christ is at the door, just like the devil that tempts Cain, and knocking. And the question is, well, do you open the door? That's one question that the painting is presenting in relationship to this verse, let's say. It's lovely to make these slideshows because every single verse has like 20 great Renaissance paintings or medieval paintings associated with it. And I mean great, not—the best paintings ever done. They're amazing. To produce a slideshow like this, you can wander through the history of great art. Then you see these great artists, these visionary dreamers, who elaborated on the themes of the verse. That's really something, too.

7.65 "Ask and it shall be given you." OK, so this is worth interrogating because this is a very strange verse and it's hard to believe. It's like, really? That's how things are set up? Well, this is associated with the idea that God the Father will provide you what you need and want in the best possible way, if you orient yourself properly. It's like, really? Well, let's assess it critically.

7.66 What's the probability you can get what you want if you don't ask? It's like zero, right? First of all, if you really don't ask, and people do this all the time, they won't even let themselves know what they want. So I have a chapter in my last book called "Do Not Hide Unwanted Things in the Fog." It's like, why would you not let yourself know what you want? Well, maybe you're afraid you'll betray yourself. You can't even let yourself in on the secret. It's like, I'll just let me down. So I'm going to not even be clear about what I want because if I'm not clear, then I can't really betray myself. And then with another person, your partner, it's like, maybe you could let them know what you need and want.

7.67 But man, you cede a lot of power, right? Because once someone knows what you really need and want, they can really hurt you, because they've got you by the soul in some real sense. But if you don't trust them, well, what are they going to do? Stumble across what you need and want? And that's really the alternative game, because what you'll do if you're not clear is, every time they deviate, you'll just punish them. And then they think, well, what do you want? And you say, well, I don't know. It's like, well, if you don't know, how the hell am I supposed to figure it out? And of course, you both do that for each other within the confines of a relationship. It's not that easy to figure out. I'm not just being cynical about it.

7.68 Are you going to get what you want if you don't ask? No. That seems pretty obvious. You're not going to hit a target if you don't aim at it. Is there going to be a target if you don't conceptualize the notion that there might be a target? Well, no, you're not going to hit the target then. What is the asking? Well, you even ask yourself, and this is such a

useful exercise. The first part of it is, OK, here's the deal. You get to have what you need and want, but there's some preconditions. You have to treat yourself properly. So first of all, you have to be willing to take the risk that it's OK that things work out for you, despite how horrible you are. And so that's a tough one, man, to swallow, because almost no one believes that.

- 7.69** I was struck by that in my clinical practice all the time. It's very hard for people to believe in their own innocence or to advocate for themselves because they know their flaws and they're deeply ashamed. And so they often, even if they believe they could get what they needed by asking, it's very hard for them to believe that they deserve it. And that's, I suppose, to forgive yourself for being a sinner. It's like, yeah, you're pretty wretched, all right. And it isn't clear that you deserve the best. But maybe if you were careful, things are constituted so that you could have it anyway. And so, take the risk. And so you can ask yourself, and it's a prayer. OK, if I could have what I needed and wanted so that my life would justify itself, right? So that I would be able to move forward without bitterness and resentment, so that I would actually say that this is worth it. That's a tough question.
- 7.70** What would it be? Are there any conditions under which I would be satisfied? And the answer is, well, certainly people can imagine how they'd be more satisfied. It's like, well, how about you're not alone? That would be a nice start. Someone loves you, somebody at least, and maybe you have some children. And if you don't, well, maybe you have some siblings that you love, and you get along with your parents, and maybe you have a job or a career if you're even more fortunate, and you're pursuing something on the educational front, and you make decent use of your leisure time, your time outside work. It's like, well, let's say you optimized all that. Would that be enough? Well, it'd be better. You could get there and then find out if that was enough.
- 7.71** Then what you'd find, too, once you got there is that, well, then you'd find a bunch of other things that would make things better still. Maybe if you were all in, you could get enough of what is necessary to justify suffering and malevolence, maybe. Maybe to not partake of it as well, to the degree that that's possible, especially malevolence. It's possible. You know you can move towards that. To ask here, asking—this is not a trivial thing. This is, like, you're going to throw yourself all in here. That's the deal. Because if it's a deal with God, you don't get to hedge your bets.
- 7.72** It's like a marriage in some sense, too. We talked about that already. It's an all-in thing. You're not married unless you're all in, and it won't work unless you're all in. That's so strange because, unless you already accept the finality of the vow, you're not married. You never test it. People leave themselves. "If this doesn't work out, well, I can always get divorced." This is living together with someone. You'll do, until someone better comes along because, of course, that's what you're doing when you're living together with someone. You both know it. You both even say it in some sense. It's like, well,

we're not ready to get married. What does that mean? Well, it means I might stumble across someone even more deluded than you that's better for me.

- 7.73** What kind of message is that to give to someone? It's like, you'll do, you'll do, till something better comes along. It's just not going to work out all that well. And it doesn't, by the way. People who live together and then get married are statistically more likely to get divorced, not less. So you think, well, you need to practice. It's like, no, that isn't how it works. You can't practice a total commitment, not in any real sense. "Seek and you shall find."
- 7.74** That's a different thing. I don't know what I want. Well, why don't you look? But then the looking would be the real seeking. It's the search for the Holy Grail or for the water of life. It's part of that adventure. It's like, well, I don't know what I want. It's like, OK, then what you want is to know what you want. You could go about looking for that, and then you could watch, too, your own life. It's like, OK, I don't know what I want. What am I doing when I'm satisfied? That's a very useful thing to do with someone clinically. It's like, well, you're depressed. OK, watch yourself for two weeks. When are you really depressed and when are you not so depressed? Just watch and report because it's often a mystery to people.
- 7.75** Well, it turns out that even though I'm depressed and I don't want to be around people, if I invite friends over, my family tells me that I laugh and smile a lot more. It's like, yeah, exactly, because depression is a positive feedback loop, because you get down on yourself and then you think no one wants to be around you. And then you separate yourself from people, and then you get lonesome. Then you get more depressed. Then you separate yourself. It's a loop that pulls you down like a lot of forms of pathology. And so if you can break that, you'll arise from it at least a little bit, at least in the moment. And then you can start seeing, well, when I'm doing this, it turns out I'm reasonably pleased to be alive.
- 7.76** I had another client, brilliant artist, architect, vicious rational mind. He had very, very smart, corrosive intellect, probably had an overbearing father, had an overbearing father, had an overbearing superego. And his rationality would just grind up anything he was dealing with. He was always consumed by problems of nihilistic despair because his rational mind would just gnaw at him. But if he was—he was a really good artist, and as long as he was pursuing something artistic, then he didn't think that. In some measure, what we did, as well as try to remediate the thoughts, was just to get him doing art more all the time. He was high in trait openness. He had to be artistic.
- 7.77** If you're high in trait openness, you have to be creative. That's your nature. If you aren't, it'll just, you just die. It's like an extrovert who can't go and see people, or an agreeable person who has no one to take care of, or a conscientious person without duty. It's like, you just perish. And so as long as he didn't think and created, then he was fine. His life was fine. And so you have to find, too. It's like, that's the seeking. It's like, when am I in the kingdom of heaven? It's like one minute a week. It's like, you want to

find that. You're with someone you love, you're doing something for someone else. That's often a revelation. It's so often that people find real significance in service. And we've outlined why that would be.

- 7.78** So you want to watch like you don't know yourself, because you're ignorant and suffering. It's like, "Who am I? I don't know. God, look at me. I'm such a mess. I can't control myself. What am I? When am I doing OK? Oh, here, this seems to work. I could do more of this and I could do less of that." And then you can start practicing that. And so that's part of seeking.
- 7.79** "Knock and it shall be opened to you." Well, that's again is, to ask is to decide. Now, I'm going to put my life together. That's what I'm going to aim at. I'm going to aim at that. "For everyone that asks, receives." That'd be a good deal. And he that seeks, finds. Well, what's the alternative? Is the person who doesn't look, finds? I don't think so. That seems highly improbable. In the Harry Potter stories, it's the seekers, right, in the Quidditch game? And they play a metagame, right? And so there's the game, which is like basketball on brooms. But then there's these two seekers, and they're above the game. So they're playing a metagame. And this thing they chase, this is this Snitch, and it's a gold ball with wings. And that's an old alchemical symbol. And it's a symbol of potential, golden potential. And it's a symbol of the spirit Mercury, Mercurius. Mercury is the messenger of the gods, the winged messenger of the gods. And so the seekers are seeking after the winged messenger of the gods.
- 7.80** What is that exactly? That thing, that golden ball that flits in front of you? And that is something will catch your interest. It's like, oh, what's that? It's just something that beckons to you. That's something you can follow. If you follow it enough, you can grab it. And if you grab it, you win. Rowling figured all that out in that game, which is just something spectacular and amazing, that she was able to conceptualize that as a fragment of her narrative. But that's what it means. You can also see, there are things as you walk through the world that beckon to you. They're like lights. They're phenomena, "phaínesthai," phenomena, to shine forth.
- 7.81** You're dull and nihilistic and bent up and preoccupied. But then something glimmers, often something beautiful, and beauty is a real marker for this. And it opens a door into the domain past your narrow and miserable preconceptions. And if you establish a relationship with that, that's why it's so useful to try to beautify something in your house, because you can establish a relationship with beauty. It's very hard to box in beauty. We know this. I imagine, is there any—how many of you like listening to music? It's like, everyone. Everyone has a genre, and music is a place where beauty beckons. It's not, this isn't optional.
- 7.82** That's the water of life. That's the transcendent reality that revivifies your stale preconceptions. That which beckons, that can pull you in that direction, if you're willing to attend to it. You have to be open to it and notice. Then you can get more and more of that, as you practice being able to receive it.

Lecture 8: Path to Resilience

At a glance — The wise and foolish builders — the path to resilience.

- 8.1** "Oh, for what man is there of you? Whom, if his son asks bread, will he give him a stone? Or if he asks a fish, will he give him a serpent?" So this refers back to the metaphor of divine parentage, and it's a question really about the fundamental substructure of reality. Well, let's be biological about this, not religious for a moment, so that we can stay in the narrow straits of the modern conceptual world. It's like, are you adapted to the world or not? Well, the biological answer to that is, well, you're at least adapted enough to live and to reproduce. So yes. So can you adapt to the world? Well, apparently. And so, well, wouldn't that mean that if you opened yourself up to the possibility of learning and transformation, that that would work? Because what else could it possibly mean? And isn't it the case that even biologically, that you're a
- 8.2** repertoire of biologically instantiated possibility, that you can draw on if you challenge yourself? And the answer to that seems to be, well, what happens when you go to the gym? It's like, you're not a weightlifting monster at the moment, and people differ to some degree, but you could be. And that's obviously proportionate to the amount of effort you put in. And that is the drawing forth of a biological propensity. You can obviously learn. And so there is more to you than there is now.
- 8.3** And what's the upper limit to that? And the answer is, we don't know. I mean, you see people who are spectacular, who—Elon Musk is a good example of that. It's like, what the hell's up with him? He's done, like, six impossible things in his life at the same time. And you meet people like that, that you admire, who are obviously maximizing the potential that lies within them. Well, is it not possible? Even being a biological rationalist, say, isn't it possible that if you didn't stop yourself from manifesting what you could manifest, that what you could manifest might be sufficient?
- 8.4** It's certainly—and then you might think, well, how could it be any other way? Because here we are, we're alive. It's been, like, a four-billion-year trip. Every single one of your ancestors going back four billion years reproduced. Every single one. You know how improbable that is? I mean, there's been calculations made of that improbability, but it's astronomically improbable, because it's highly improbable that a line of continuous reproduction will last even five generations, much less four billion years. It's ridiculous. And so, whatever you are is that.
- 8.5** Something also I learned from Jung, he said, you're 40 years old, whatever it might be. It's like, not in the deepest sense. And that's why your true parents are nature and God, in some real sense. It's like, no, you're 13 billion years old, and you need to be able to access that in some fundamental way. And that's hard because in another way, well, you're 30 or whatever it happens to be. And you see this in kids, too. I caught a lot of my daughter's dreams when she was a little kid, three years old or so. And she had

dreams that were so profound. It was just beyond belief. And of course, she didn't know what they meant because she was three. But there's something going on in there that's unbelievably old, and that's something in you.

- 8.6** That's the spirit of the divine Father. That's part of it. It's the spirit of nature, and it's there to be called upon. That's not some metaphysical speculation, although it also might be that, right? Because who knows anything about the ultimate nature of reality? Being a biological reductionist just means you assume your scientific presumptions are correct. It doesn't make you much of a scientist. Things are very weird at the biological level.
- 8.7** "Or what man is there of you who, if his son asks bread, will give him a stone ? If they ask a fish, will he give him a serpent?" So the issue here in some sense is, well , can you trust the structure of reality? I would say, you won't find out unless you try. And that, again, that's part of the adventure of your life. It really is. It's like, you won't find out unless you try, and you can't find out unless you're all in. And that's the prerequisite of faith, because you won't even get the right answer unless you have the faith to ask the question. So you can't put the evidence first . It's just not going to work. Not in the most fundamental sense. When you move into the future, because it's uncertain, there's a necessary leap of faith, always, because you don't know. You can't know. You can only move forward in faith or terror and hatred, if you want to take that route.
- 8.8** "Or what man is there of you? Whom, if his son asks bread, will give them a stone?" OK, so the idea here is, well, mother or father, you've got all your problems, but if your children ask you for something, more or less, you're inclined to do your best to deliver, all things considered. It's in your nature to respond to a genuine request with genuine help. I think that's really true. I mean, even people who are pretty bent and twisted, if someone is desperate and really asks them for help and comes to them as if they might be helpful, there's a pretty good probability that they're going to do at least something in their bent and twisted way that's as good as they can manage.
- 8.9** Partly, I suppose, because it's complimentary to be asked for help, despite your flaws. When someone really asks you for help, assuming you can trust it or assuming you're willing to, then it does call out something in you that's the best part of you. Benjamin Franklin, he's very smart. He had a good trick. Strategy. If you want to integrate yourself into a new neighborhood, he said, well, when you move into a neighborhood, ask a neighbor for a small favor. Nothing big because you don't want to impose on them. And that's different than bringing them a gift. That's right. Ask them for a small gift.
- 8.10** Why? Well, because they want to be helpful, probably, and then you can make it easy for them to show themselves in their best possible light by offering you a gift, and then you can reciprocate, and then you can get the whole process of joint reciprocation going, because that's how people establish a relationship. There's even small talk as well. Here's a little thing of not too much importance . Can you handle it? It's like, well,

then you give back. You don't tell me the trauma of your life when you were four. Sometimes that happens. You go on a bus and someone will sit down beside you and they're really troubled, and they'll just tell you something awful, like right now. And you think, I just cannot handle that.

- 8.11** And that poor person has zero people to talk to. And they've got so much on their mind, they're literally crazy because of it. And they haven't got that small talk ability anymore. They're terrifying. And so with small talk, it's like, well, here's a little something that's almost nothing . Can you handle it? It's like, well, here's something back, a little bigger. And then you get to the point where, well, if it opens up, you can start to talk about something. So don't despise small talk. That's a big mistake . That's part of the professionalism of a persona, is you know how to start casually and appropriately.
- 8.12** And that's a good thing to know, to know that that's—because people say, well, "I don't like small talk ." It's like, no. That might be true if you're an open person and you like ideas and you like deep discussion. So there can be an element of that that's true. But it's often the case that you don't like it because you're just not any good at it. So you should get really good at it because it opens the door to deeper relationships. So anyways, if you're a reasonable person, even an evil person for that matter, even a bent and twisted person, which you are, and someone asks you for something, you're going to do your best, at least in part, to deliver it.
- 8.13** "If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts unto your children, how much more shall your Father which is in heaven give good things to them that ask him?" Now, there's another biological question here. Richard Dawkins, one of the world's most famous atheists and biologists, said—he wrote a paper about 20 years ago, which he sent me. I tried to engage him in a series of conversations. We got a little ways along the pathway. He told me a number of times that he didn't understand what the hell I was up to, or anything I was saying, but that maybe it had something to do with this paper that he sent me, which it had exactly to do with. It was exactly right.
- 8.14** He wrote this paper claiming that, detailing out a claim, that a biological organism, in some sense, has to be a microcosm of the environment that it exists in. It has to be a model of the environment. For example, if you were an alien and someone gave you a bird, you could calculate a bunch of things about Earth. It's like, well, it has an atmosphere because the bird has wings, and they don't work in stone or water. You need air for wings. Then you could calculate the gravity of the Earth because the bird has a certain weight, and it has hollow bones, and it has to have that weight because, otherwise, wings that are that big couldn't make it fly. Then you could calculate the temperature because if it was too hot, the bird would just be cooked, and if it was too cold, it would be a lump of ice. You could just look at the bird and infer the structure of the world.

- 8.15** It's like, well, can you infer the structure of the cosmos from your structure? The answer to that on the biological end seems to be yes. So are you a microcosm of the true cosmic structure? And the answer to that seems to be, well, if you weren't, you wouldn't be able to live in the world. And that's not a religious answer. That's a biological answer. But it's also a religious answer because there is an old idea, a medieval idea, older than that, that we're a microcosm. And you could think about this in some sense as a low-resolution representation of reality itself. We're analogous to the totality. Yes.
- 8.16** You see that idea lurking in the idea of the incarnation of Christ, too. The Catholics have this idea of kenosis because there's a mystery of, well, if Christ was God, how did that work? Because God tells Moses, for example, that he can't even look at his face. You have to just look at a part of God, because if you looked at the whole thing, that'd be the end of you. And so how can you dump that divine totality into a mortal shell without just blowing it into bits? And the kenosis answer is something like, it's something like a thumbnail. It's like Christ as a thumbnail of God. It's something like that. It's a very funny idea. But kenosis means emptying.
- 8.17** And obviously, a mortal frame can't contain the totality. There's an insistence in Christian doctrine that Christ is fully God, but still, the mystery still remains. It's like, what exactly does that mean? Well, the microcosm idea is a nice mediating idea. I'm not saying it's the total idea because it's not. But certainly, Christ is something that's bound, at least in the incarnation sense, the divine is bounded by time and place. Because Christ is a carpenter. He's not a lawyer. He's a carpenter, and that's all. It's in the ancient Middle East, and it's 2,000 years ago. It's like a really particularized time and place, just like it is for you. Really, just like that. That's part of the arbitrariness in some sense of Christ's birth in the narrative stream.
- 8.18** It's like, well, why then? It's like, well, why now for you? And the answer is, well, because everything pointed to that. That's the answer. And so it could have been any time or place because they're all equally arbitrary in some real sense. So then you ask yourself, well, if you can be called upon to deliver and you're a microcosm of the structure of reality itself, in the material sense and the transcendent sense, well, is it not possibly the case that that's reflected at a higher level of being? Well, then again, I would say, well, you bet your life on finding that out because it might be. You say, well, that's still not convincing to me. It's like, OK, fair enough. This is a tough one to swallow, and this whole "ask and you'll receive thing." It's like, what do you do when you want to figure something out? You ask yourself a question, and you get an answer.
- 8.19** The answer is proportionate to how much you want the answer, and maybe it's proportionate to how much work you did in seeking out the answer. If you're trying to write an essay as a student, you have a question, hopefully a burning question, like the burning bush, a burning question. "I really want to answer this." And then ideas flash into your mind. Where do they come from? Well, they bubble up from below. That's

how you think about it biologically. Or they descend from above and they flesh out the question. And maybe that's not enough, so you have to do some research. But then you're opening yourself up again. You're doing, that's the seeking. I'm doing the investigation. Will you get a revelation? It's like, well, you can't think without a revelation because the first stage in thinking, well, the first stage is asking the question, but the second stage is receipt of the revelation.

- 8.20** I can just say that as a secular person. That's just what happens. You ask yourself a question and you get the answer. Where does it come from? Where does anything come from? It's the same question. It manifests itself in the world. Then you have to evaluate it and all that. But so you can ask and receive. That happens all the time because otherwise you couldn't figure anything out.
- 8.21** "If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts unto your children, how much more shall your Father, which is in heaven, give good things to them that ask him?" Well, then that's worth thinking about, too. It's like, if you can think up some useful things now and then, despite how screwed up and disorganized you are, what things could you think up if you put yourself in order? And then you can ask yourself that question seriously. You think, well, who are you inclined to listen to? Then you find people that you listen to, and you see that you listen to admirable people, and you see that they're admirable, I would say, because they're disciplined and productive and generous. As a trifecta, that's not too bad.
- 8.22** That's the characteristic of elders in tribal communities, as we discussed. Their words have weight. They're charismatic. Well, why? Well, because they've organized themselves properly. What does that mean? Well, they fit themselves into the heavenly hierarchy. They're occupants of the city of Jerusalem. They're letting their light shine forth. All of that, clearly. And then their thoughts are worthwhile. And so what does that mean? Well, it means they have higher quality revelations from God. And then you think, well, how could it be otherwise in some fundamental sense? And then you can switch back to the secular and you can think, well, at least you should set yourself up so you're not interfering with your own operations, even if you're just a biological calculation machine, which you aren't.
- 8.23** But even if you were, like the yogis, what they're trying to do is they're trying to take all the pathology out of their psychophysiology. And you know the postures that yogis practice. So people in North America think that you're a yogi if you master all these postures. And that's not the case. No more than you're not a dancer if you just practice the dance moves. If you're a yogi, you practice all those moves because that gives you a repertoire of exploratory moves. And then what you do is you meditate and you feel where your body is out of alignment and use a move to put it back in alignment. And that aligns all those chakras. And that's the hierarchy of psychophysiological being.
- 8.24** It's the heavenly hierarchy. It's Jacob's ladder. You're trying to organize that. If you organize it properly, so all the knots and kinks and twists are out of you, that might be

places you're storing tension . I had a client, for example. She was a pastor, a student, and she was an awkward person and quite paranoid. It was hard to talk to her. She wasn't a good dancer. They fired her without warning from this program that she had quit her job to take. She was about 40. And so it was a real trauma to her. And they did it very badly and very carelessly. And so she was just torn into bits because she'd literally quit her whole job and was reorienting her life and was halfway through this pastoral program. And it was a pastoral program. So when those people betray you, that's really harsh.

8.25 And so they dumped her into—the HR types dumped her into her car with all her belongings and shuttled her off home. And on the way home, somebody hit her in a car going 50 miles an hour. That was her day. She was already traumatized, and then a car ran into her. It's like that, well, she was just broken. That happens to people. They get hit, and then when they're getting up, something else hits them. You do that to someone three times, man, they're in real rough shape because they're just struggling to their feet and like, whack. And that's what happened to her.

8.26 And she always made me uncomfortable when she came in to talk to me. I liked her, and we got along fine , but there's always physical discomfort. And I was watching her and checking her out. And I thought, your shoulder, your right shoulder, is like three inches higher than your left shoulder. It's always like that. What the hell is going on? And I had this intuition. I never did this with any other client. I said, come over. And I had done a lot of massage work in yoga with my wife, so I knew some things about this. I said, come over here. Just stand by the desk. I just want to tap on your back. I tapped along her back, and she was just like, just this, always. She'd probably been in this state of shock, like literally every day and every hour, since she was hit by the car because she just froze into catastrophe position.

8.27 I tapped my hands down her back and she just broke into tears. She cried for 20 minutes. And then when she sat back down, I noticed her shoulder was lower. And then I asked her, "What's up with that?" She said, "Well, it's been like that ever since I got hit by the car," because it was her left shoulder. She was hit on the driver's side. Well, when you get hit, you defend yourself. Then she was just like that. Then we started to practice. Like, well, how high can you lift up your arm? This high. It's like, OK, lift it up there. Now , lift it up half an inch higher. OK, now do that again. Half an inch higher. Keep doing that. We got her arm all the way up to the top.

8.28 She said she hadn't done that for like six years. Then we did it with her shoulders. Like, well, lift up your shoulder and then let it down, lift it up and let it down. She finally got her shoulder down. That poor woman had been holding her shoulder up. Try it. Stand there for three minutes with your arm out and see if you can do that because you can't. To be like that for like six years, that takes a lot of work. And so when you're doing yoga , what you're doing is you're going inside and you're seeing where you're carrying all of that and you're trying to align yourself . And then you end up in this Buddha position,

which is the position. It's a triangular position, like a pyramid, that you sit in, on the lotus, a flower that emerges in the sunlight that comes out of the muck from below because that's what a lotus does.

- 8.29** It grows out of the deepest depths and it comes up through the darkness, up into the light, and it flowers on the surface. And then you sit in there. And then if you're integrated—that's what the postures are for—then you can receive the proper revelation. That's like bottom-up spirituality in some real sense . Maybe that's a precondition for a revelation because you have to get your body in order as well. So then you think, well, the more you get yourself in alignment with this cosmic structure, the Jacob's ladder, then the more you can offer to yourself and to other people, and the more you're a representation of that which does the offering in the most fundamental sense.
- 8.30** And it's like, none of that—it's so interesting because none of that's not rational. It's fundamentally rational. You don't even have to place it in religious language. Although what happens is that, if you talk in this manner, it tends to sound like religious language, which is a piece of evidence in and of itself.
- 8.31** "How much more shall your Father, which is in heaven, give good things to them that ask him?" Well, that's the ultimate question. How good could things get if you put yourself together? Christ says in the Gospels that the people that come after him could do greater things than him. That's a hell of a thing to say, especially when you're the son of God. It's like, no, you could improve on that. It's like, OK.
- 8.32** "Therefore, all things whatsoever ye would that men should do to you, do ye even so to them, for this is the law and the prophets." OK, the law. Well, that's the Mosaic law, and that's custom and tradition. That's Osiris , the Egyptian god of the state. But it's static and it's tradition. You need a prophetic antidote to that because the state tends to become static and to degenerate and not to be full enough to deal with the future because it's the past. So it's dead in some sense. Necessary, wise , dead. It has to be allied with the prophetic voice. And then the union of those two things, that's the soul, I suppose, in some sense. Certainly, it's the sovereign citizen because the sovereign citizen is the union of the wisdom of the past and the prophetic voice. Maybe the eye as well, the eye that's the light of the world.
- 8.33** And so what Christ says is that that spirit, there's a spirit that is the central essence. Imagine the spirit as a character . Then imagine that in the biblical corpus, there are multiple characterizations of the divine. Then imagine that because all those characterizations, which are diverse, are of the divine , there's some central aspect to the divine, because otherwise there couldn't be multiple characterizations of the same thing. It's different, but there's an essence. And Christ's statement here is, well, what's the essence of the law and the prophets? That union, which is the Old Testament union, and that's, "Therefore, all things whatsoever ye would that men should do to you, do unto them." And that's a direct instruction. It's a direct instruction.

- 8.34** It's like, figure out how you would like to be treated. So this is a good deal. You get to be treated exactly how you want to be treated. You can have that. The price you pay is that you have to do that to other people, first. Then you think, well, will that work? It's like, well, probably they'll be pretty happy about that, so maybe they'll return it. And then if a bunch of them are returning it, you're going to get a lot better at thinking through what it is and better at applying it to yourself. So then you think, well, how could that not work?
- 8.35** And it's a sacrificial move, too, because you're not getting it for yourself. You have to just let yourself go to begin with. You just have to offer it to other people. But then what you find, too, in that is that, that isn't even a sacrifice because what it is that you're trying to attain can be most properly attained by exactly that practice. If you find that you start treating other people in the best possible manner, you're already doing the best possible thing. It's like, you win the game just like that. You know that's the case, especially you know that, I think, especially you know that once you have children, because you see very clearly at that point, to the degree that your wisdom allows it, that whatever your relationship is with your child is something that all of you is properly subordinated to, even your life.
- 8.36** Because I do believe that most parents, most, without anything more than understandable hesitation, would certainly risk their lives to save their children, but also, I think, die for their children. I really do believe that that's the case. And your children, there isn't anyone you love more, would want to love more than your children. And so that's the fundamental relationship. And if that's the nature of the relationship or the most fundamental relationship, then, well, that's also echoed in the notion that Christ died to save mankind. It's like, well, that's God's children. What's the proper attitude towards that? It's like, the willingness to make the ultimate sacrifice.
- 8.37** The passion story, whatever else it might be, from a narrative perspective, is a story of ultimate sacrifice. It says, what could you sacrifice if you had to sacrifice everything? Well, you'd subject yourself to betrayal. You'd subject yourself to tyranny. You'd subject yourself to nihilism. You'd subject yourself to an early death. You'd subject yourself to an early death as if you were a criminal despite the fact that you're innocent. It's said, not only innocent, but the best possible person. And all of that. So it's an ultimate sacrifice. And so the idea, it's the most amazing idea. I really do believe that, is that the ultimate sacrifice is ultimately redemptive.
- 8.38** And then you think, how could it be any different? Because you're going to face all this, all of that; it's in your life. All of it. And so how are you going to adapt to your life without accepting all that? And then, maybe not just accepting it because that's all right, I'll accept it. It's like, no, no, it's like, celebratory acceptance. Bring it on. It's like, that's a hell of a thing to ask, man, to bring all that on. I read this line by Nietzsche the other day. It was very good. He posited it like so much of what he writes. This is so very

good. He said, "Well, imagine you could be happy." It's like, OK, happy, no sorrow. That'd be a good deal.

- 8.39** It's like, well, then imagine that isn't exactly how the world is constituted. Imagine that there's some proportion between the degree of joy and the degree of suffering, and that they're integrally tied together in some real sense. You can think about that if you listen to a profound piece of music, classical music. It's complicated, and so that's off-putting to people sometimes. But part of the reason people have a hard time with it is because it really asks a lot of you. It goes all the way to the tragic depths and up to the highest pinnacle, all within a single piece. The more profound the piece, the more territory it covers.
- 8.40** You really see that with someone like Beethoven. Mozart's quite pretty, and Bach has this mathematical beauty. But Beethoven, with that Romanticism, it's all the way from hell to heaven. The Ninth Symphony is probably the greatest example of that, which is why they played it when the Berlin Wall fell in Germany. It was the perfect—I think it's the European Union national anthem, which was a daring choice on their part. But it spans the whole gap. Imagine that you're not really designed for happiness. That's just one part of the equation. It's sort of like being stuck in an elevator with elevator music playing. It's like, well, I'm happy. It's insipid. Maybe it's breadth of life.
- 8.41** You see that in the call to adventure for Abraham, for example, because God calls Abraham to adventure. God is in that wise—the voice that calls you to adventure. It's like, Abraham has—it's war and famine and tyranny and catastrophe. It's the whole thing. It's the entire wide distribution of the catastrophe of life. But it's a great adventure, and maybe that's better than happy. I just can't see how that can't be true. The great people that I've met, they've been great adventurers. I have a friend. God, he's quite the character. When I first met him, I think the first time I saw him, he had blond hair down to here, and he has two wandering eyes, and he's definitely a pirate. I mean, he had a spider—a poisonous spider bit one of his legs, and it's quite damaged.
- 8.42** He's sailed around the world by himself a number of times. He's been in fog for three months. He's just this ridiculously tough guy and very unbelievably blunt. You look at him and you think, "Look, that's Bluebeard." And he's not a nice guy, but I wouldn't trade him for a nice guy for all the tea in China. He's way better than a nice guy. He's an unbelievably interesting person. And he has this immense capacity for mayhem. It's right beneath the surface all the time. And he's a formidable person. You can't even walk down the street with him without him getting into trouble. He's just trouble, man.
- 8.43** He's so admirable, and he's such an adventurer, and he's such a pirate. He's also a very good person. They used to hire him in corporations. He's a really good engineer. Corporations will get corrupt, and they'd bring this gentleman in. Because I talked to him one day. I had to let a graduate student go, and I kept this person on way too long, and they were demoralizing the lab. I'm not good at that; I'm not good at that. I'm too compassionate to fire people. This is not a virtue. So I asked my friend. I knew they

brought him into corporations to fire people, so the corporation would go south, and they'd bring him in to houseclean and he'd start at the bottom.

- 8.44** I said, "Well, how can you stand firing people? It's so hard." He says, "I enjoy it." I thought, oh, you enjoy it? He said, "Yeah, I find these people who are narcissistic to the core. They take credit for everything that the people around them do. They never give any credit. They're lying all the time. All they're doing is trying to climb up the hierarchy. They're just a bloody catastrophe. I go in there and I find them and I fire them and I enjoy it." I thought, oh, that's a whole perspective I'd never even considered.
- 8.45** What happened to him continually, because he got fired all the time, is he'd go into companies and he'd start housecleaning at the bottom, but he wouldn't stop. He'd like, "Well, you're all gone. It's like, now it's your turn. You're all gone." Then he'd get up to the point where he was going to houseclean someone who didn't want to be housecleaned, and then they'd fire him. But he did that many times and has a reputation in the corporate world for being the person who can do that. If you met him, you'd think, "Yeah, you're definitely the person who can do that."
- 8.46** But that's a good way to conceptualize yourself. It's like, you just want to be like elevator music? You want to be insipid and harmless or, like, do you want to be something to contend with? And there's a tremendous charisma that's associated with that and a sexiness and a humor and a viciousness and the requirement for respect and the judiciousness, all of that. And I don't think you get that without accepting the whole bloody catastrophe, and not even wishing that it was only half of what it was.
- 8.47** And then maybe you could have your cake and eat it, too, because it's also possible. I thought about this a lot on the issue of malevolence. Why would God create a world where there's evil? It's like, well, maybe a world where the possibility of evil exists is a better world than the world where no possibility for evil exists. Maybe if we got our act together, we could have the option of evil without its actuality. I mean, in some sense, that's what you try to do in your life. You know you could go sideways at any moment in a negative way. So it's there, and it's an index. The fact that it's there is an index of the possibility that you have in front of you. You have the whole range, and you could just try to optimize without sacrificing the range.
- 8.48** It does look like the biblical corpus is set up so that if God was forced, say, to choose between a world that was only good or a world that had good and evil in it and free will, that that would be a better world than a world where there was no evil. And that's also really worth thinking about. And maybe that's why there's a serpent in the garden, because you might ask, well, God made the damn garden. Why throw a snake in there? It's like, well, maybe a garden with a snake is a better garden because then you learn how to handle snakes. And then you're not just a bunny rabbit. Not that they don't have teeth, but they're still bunny rabbits. And that's not what you're supposed to be. You're supposed to be something can handle serpents by the dangerous end.

- 8.49** And that's certainly what women want from men. There is no doubt about that. And that's been true forever. And then what do men want from women? Well, Eve, the word Eve, I think I told you this, in Hebrew means "beneficial adversary." And so men are looking for someone to contend with, too. And man might think, "I want a woman who'd do anything I ask." It's like, no, are you kidding? First of all, you'd take advantage of her in 15 seconds, and then you'd be bored stiff, and then you'd be wondering, well, "Why do you do anything I ask? Who the hell do you think I am?" There's a subordination there that's just not helpful.
- 8.50** And then you ask yourself, well, "Why would I be with someone who just does whatever I ask?" You want someone to contend with, and that keeps the dynamism in the relationship alive. There has to be some uncertainty there. There's some calling each other out constantly on misbehavior and deviation from the ideal. And that's way more interesting than just like abject subordination. God, that's not a marriage. That's a tyranny. It's a tyrant and a slave. And you're pretty damn foolish if you're satisfied with being a tyrant.
- 8.51** And people have asked me this, too, because I've made this case that power doesn't rule. What about dictators? Aren't they successful? It's like, well, we could think about that. Solzhenitsyn wrote very interestingly about Stalin. Stalin trusted no one. Why? Because everyone around him lied to him all the time. So he was like king of the Soviet Union, let's say. He's king of hell. Well, if you're king of hell, are you the most successful person in hell or the least successful person? I think, well, you're the least successful person. The most successful devil is the least successful entity.
- 8.52** So if that's what power buys, right, sycophants and bully henchmen and lying, craven cowards for hypothetical friends and nothing but betrayal—it's like, that's your victory for being a tyrant, is it? And that's an accomplishment. That's what power brings. And in a marriage, it's exactly the same thing. If you're a tyrant, well, there's no love in a tyranny. If you're a tyrant to your children, there's no love there. And maybe "they do what I tell them to." It's like, well, great. That's your victory. And maybe that's better than being just an insipid weakling, although perhaps not, because it's just the opposite extreme. But it's certainly, there's nothing in it that's optimal, obviously.
- 8.53** "Therefore, all things whatsoever ye would that men should do to you, do you even so to them, for this is the law and the prophets." That's in some sense, so interesting in some sense, that that's the Christian revelation. The large part of it is the transformation of this tradition into this dynamic principle of judicious reciprocity. That's brilliant, brilliant. Transformation of the notion of ethic and outside the domain of law, because now it's a living principle. It was to some degree in the prophetic tradition already. It's implicit. That's why the Christians say that Christ is implicit in the Old Testament. I think in some sense, and I do believe this is true—I learned this from Jung as well—that if you took any comprehensive series of narratives, Christ and Satan

are implicit in them because they're the archetypal pattern, the hostile brother pattern behind all narrative.

8.54 Again, you can think about that from a secular perspective. If you're just an analyst of what constitutes narrative, there are fundamental plots. There's obviously plots, because without plot, there's no story. There's obviously characters, because without characters, there's no story. Are there fundamental plots and characters? The answer is there has to be, because you couldn't recognize something as a story otherwise and certainly not as a good story. Then the question is, well, what's the greatest story ever told? That would be the pattern of intrinsic narrative lurking behind all narratives. In some real sense, that is what the Bible is, in the most real sense. Again, you can just speak anthropologically and biologically about such things.

8.55 "Enter ye in the strait gate, for wide is the gate and broad is the way that leadeth to destruction, and many there be which go in thereat." The strait gate. It doesn't mean straight. It means strait. It means confined. It means narrow. It means there's one right way to do things in the final analysis. This is a pointer to something like a divine unity. It's a very hard thing to attain exactly. It's like dancing to the music properly. If you're fortunate, that happens to you sometimes. Sometimes you can have that happen to you at a concert. That's why people love concerts so much, rock concerts, country music concerts, it doesn't matter. You'll get in there now and then. The band will just, a great band. They're doing something inspired and they're improvising, and they're just cooking. And everyone in the auditorium is in the same place and doing the same thing. And the band is playing off against the audience, and the audience is playing off against the band.

8.56 That's that line between yin and yang. That's a line of meaning. And everyone is there at once. That's a paradisaal vision. That's that strait gate. And that's something to see and observe. It's not something to conceptualize precisely. "Because strait is the gate and narrow is the way, which leadeth unto life; and few there be that find it." Yeah, well, that's harsh, too. But of course, you know, it's a vision of paradisaal perfection. And of course, it has to be a rarity because it's the highest possible thing, and it stands up above all the rest. So it's going to be rare, and it's going to be hard to attain, and it's vital. And so.

8.57 "Beware of false prophets." That's a good line for today. "Which come to you in sheep's clothing." I'm harmless. I'm harmless. I'm doing nothing but nice. I wouldn't hurt a fly. All I'm doing is eating grass. Because that must be the vegetarians, ha, ha. "But inwardly, they are ravening wolves." And that's such a smart line, too, because the most effective guise of a predator is compassion. And narcissists and psychopaths are so good at that. They'll use your compassion against you. That's exactly what they do. And they do that by making an unwarranted claim of moral virtue in relationship to you and elevating themselves falsely in moral status because of that. And that's literally, metaphorically. This is a wonderful description of that, a wolf in sheep's clothing.

- 8.58** "You shall know them by their fruits. Do men gather grapes of thorns, or figs of thistles?" What was the Jungian line? I love this, psychoanalytic dictum. If you can't tell what someone's up to—this is not 100% true. It's a tool you can use now and then to sort things out. Maybe you get in trouble the same way four times. It's like, why would I do that? Because you're aiming at it. Once, accident. Twice, bad day. Three times, pattern. Four times, there's something in you aiming for it. This is also a good disciplinary rule of thumb. It's like, when should you discipline someone? Wife, partner, you? You let them off the hook once. You give them a break twice. Three times, it's like, no, I saw you do this three times. People will try to weasel out of it. It's like, "No, I didn't do that." It's like, "No, no. Yes, you did. And then you did it again. And then you did it again. And I didn't say anything until I gathered three pieces of information."
- 8.59** This is also useful, too, because you want to know in your life, how patient should you be? You don't want to fly off the handle about every little thing. It's like, so, OK, three is a good rule. The psychoanalytical dictum is, if you can't understand the motivation, look at the consequence and infer the cause. It's like, well, you keep going out with terrible men and getting beat up. Why? Because something in you wants to go out with terrible men and get beat up. Why?
- 8.60** If you don't think that sort of thing happens, you read Theodore Dalrymple, a psychiatrist who worked in the inner cities of London for decades. He figured he interviewed 20,000 victims of domestic abuse. This is a guy with deep knowledge. He's very, very smart. It's like, what are you aiming at? Or what's the outcome? Now, it's not unerring because you can't always tie consequence to cause. But if you're flailing about, looking for reasons for your own behavior or behavior of someone around you, and the same thing keeps happening, you start thinking, well, that's an indication of the aim. It's really useful diagnostically in your life. That's why Jung said, you should know what myth you're living out because you'll have your characteristic experiences, and maybe they're tragic.
- 8.61** "Oh my god, the same thing happens to me in every relationship." It's like, OK, if it's not you, it's certainly something in you that you can know by what it's aiming at. These kids who shoot up high schools, it's like, what's the spirit that possesses them? Well, they want to produce as much mayhem as they possibly can to the most innocent possible people, merely for the sake of notoriety, and then they want to cap it off with suicide. You think, OK, let's see if we can explain that. Why not just save the world the trouble and shoot yourself first? If you're so hopeless. It's like, no. It's not just hopelessness. It's like, up yours, like seriously. And in the broadest possible sense, it's like it goes really down, I would say, it goes right down into the satanic. It's like, I'm so tired of life. I'll do everything I can to make it miserable. And then just to show you how little I care, I'll cap it off with my own demise. That's a dark thing, man. It's years of meditation before you get to that place.

- 8.62** "You shall know them by their fruits. Do men gather grapes of thorns, or figs of thistles? Even so, every good tree bringeth forth good fruit." Well, this is another example of getting the whole structure right. So the whole tree is healthy. It's the tree of life. The whole tree is healthy and it brings forth the proper fruits. Now, this is a great painting. So the tree there is the tree of the knowledge of good and evil and the tree of life. And on the one hand, you see Eve handing out the apples of death. And so that's how death comes into the world. You can see the skulls on the tree there. And then on the other side, that's the church and Mary. It's an intermingling of them symbolically.
- 8.63** And what she's handing out, you see there's a crucifix on the other side that's juxtaposed against the skull. And the crucifixion is the antidote to the skull. And that's a very strange idea. And what it means in part is the acceptance of death is the cure for death. It's something like that. It's not just that. So now Mary, the church as well there, is handing out the host. They're the apples of the tree. But it's the host. It's the wheatenwafer that's the body and blood of Christ. And so what does that mean? It means that the antidote to death, in the broadest possible sense, is the incorporation of the willingness to accept the catastrophe of existence. That's what that painting means.
- 8.64** It's not like the person who painted the painting knew it. In that explicit sense is that the painting itself was an attempt to explore that set of ideas and to come to terms with this. This is an unbelievably profound painting. There's a couple of different representations of this from the medieval world, but it sums up the entire biblical narrative in one image, and that's something, man. That's a whole culture in one image. It's an amazing image. It just blew me away when I understood to some degree what the image meant. Stunning, stunning. An idea that the antithesis of death is the acceptance of death. That's—
- 8.65** We don't know what that means, in the deepest sense, because if you could accept the whole catastrophe of your life all the way to the bottom, how much would you triumph over suffering and malevolence? We don't know that, and we especially don't know the answer to that if we all did that collectively. If we were all all in and working as hard as we could to make things better, what would be the limit of that? How good could we make things? What could we overcome? We could certainly, at least in principle, overcome malevolence. Could we overcome death? Well, I don't know if we want to. That's one question.
- 8.66** I asked my parents once, if you could be 18 again, but know what you knew, would you do it again? I asked it seriously because I was curious. They're in their 80s and they're getting old, and so they're starting to suffer from old age. It's like, well, if you can have youth again, would you have it? They didn't leap forward to say yes. I'm ambivalent about this. Would we want to conquer death or would we want to learn to accept it? Socrates posited that if you lived your life completely, that would be enough. Maybe

that's true. Maybe there's an advantage in that boundedness that we don't want to transcend.

8.67 We're playing with this on the technological front. All the transhumanists are playing with this, like, well, maybe we could just replace you with a machine and upload you, which we can't, by the way, but hypothetically, we could. Maybe that would be better . It's like, yeah, then you'd be a robot. Then are you not dead? How is that you? Because what is you? "It's what I feel I am moment to moment." It's definitely not that either. So.

8.68 "Even so, every good tree bringeth forth good fruit; but a corrupt tree bringeth forth evil fruit." And that's worth knowing, too. If your life is going seriously sideways, sometimes it's luck of the draw and terrible things happen to people, earthquakes and so forth. It's hard to lay them at their feet. Although earthquakes are a lot less harmful when the builders aren't corrupt. You go into a corrupt country, and there's an earthquake, and everyone dies . You go into a country that's not corrupt and there's an earthquake, and no one dies, and it's the same earthquake. So that's worth thinking about, too. So if terrible things are happening to you all the time, I wouldn't want to say that's your fault. But you might want to say that, on the off-chance that you're doing something that increased the probability of the catastrophe , because at least you could rectify it to some degree.

8.69 "Every tree that bringeth not forth good fruit is hewn down and cast into fire." That's because in your own life, you bring forth an evil fruit and you will absolutely pay for that. And that's a burning. And if you let the burning occur, it'll burn off the branch that produced the evil fruit. And if you don't, it'll just burn and burn and burn. "Wherefore by their fruits, ye shall know them. Not everyone that saith unto me," this is a new thought, "not everyone that saith unto me, Lord, Lord, shall enter into the kingdom of heaven; but he that doeth the will of my Father, which is in heaven." That's a very powerful line, too, because—and modern people are particularly prone to this with their rationalism. You just have to say that you believe.

8.70 Well, that's not what this line says. It says, you can say that you believe all you want, and not everyone that says that will enter into the kingdom of heaven. So the fact that you say that doesn't doom you, but it's no indication of your salvation, so no certain indication. So the religious faith isn't your statement about what you believe, not in the most fundamental essence. The most fundamental essence is, "but he that does." It's an existential emphasis. It's acting out. It's the act of imitation of Christ, fundamentally, in the deepest sense, or the spirit of Abel. "But he that do the will of God, which is in heaven." That's the ticket. And it's embodied action in the world.

8.71 And that's why there's this tremendous emphasis in Christianity on embodiment. God , the word, the divine word. It's an abstract conceptualization. The spirit that exists at the beginning of time that calls the order that is good out of potential. That takes on determinate form. And the taking on of that form, it's an incarnation . It's an element of

the trinity itself. It's a reflection of what's supreme itself. And so, of course, it's going to be action. That's why Christ is a carpenter, too. Not a thinker, not in that abstract sense, not a priest even, in the most fundamental sense. But a carpenter, you can't get more hands-on than being a carpenter. Action. "But he that doeth the will of my Father, which is in heaven."

8.72 "Many will say to me in that day, Lord, Lord, have we not prophesied in thy name? And in thy name have we cast out devils, and in thy name done many wonderful works? And I will profess unto them, I never knew you. Depart from me, ye that work iniquity." And so falsely referring to your achievements as indication of your ethical wondrousness —I suppose that's the temptation of the aristocracy, right? Because that's not sufficient evidence either. And this is a practical issue, too, because if the kingdom of God is a state, a psychological state and a social state at the same time, and actually a state that you can inhabit, this is a guide to inhabiting it, actually. It's something very practical. Part of what's being taught here is the notion that, well, there's things that people try to do to attain that that just don't work.

8.73 A mere profession of propositional faith is insufficient. It's not going to work. Neither is a mere piling-up of good works. That also isn't going to work, especially if you're doing the good works for you, for your own benefit. In that narrow sense, in that narcissistic and self-aggrandizing narrow sense, it's not going to work. There's no way that you can get there. You can't get there from that place.

8.74 "Therefore, whosoever heareth these sayings of mine and does them, I will liken him unto a wise man which built his house upon a rock. And the rain descended and the floods came, and the winds blew and beat upon that house, and it fell not, for it was founded upon a rock." What's the rock? The rock is the crucifixion. The rock is the story of the passion and the acceptance of that catastrophic destiny, that intermingling of tragedy and malevolence, and the willingness to face that and to tool a character in response to that challenge that can then withstand all of that. It's exposure. You can walk through all of that before it happens. And then when it happens, you're ready. And then if you're ready, it doesn't happen.

8.75 And so that's so peculiar. That also harkens back to that notion that if you lose your life for Christ's sake, you'll find it. It's the same idea, is that if you give all that up a priori, if you expose yourself to all that you want to avoid a priori, voluntarily, then maybe it won't even happen. And you think, well, that's hard to believe. I said, well, I've seen people confront death bravely, the death of someone they love. And the person still dies and they still suffer the loss, but it's not hell. They transmute it at least to the degree that was possible. Sometimes even, I wouldn't say turn it into a positive good because it's still the terrible loss. But if you sort things out with your parents before their final stages, you can take care of them better. You can shepherd them through those last stages in a way that isn't contaminated with bitterness and horror, as well as

with the terrors of old age and degeneration . It's at least something. God only knows how good you could get at that.

8.76 "And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house, and it fell not, for it was founded upon a rock. And every one that heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them not, shall be likened unto a foolish man, which built his house upon the shifting sands." The multiplicity and not the unity. "And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew and beat upon that house, and it fell. And great was the fall of it." And that's a nice reference to the interplay between natural catastrophe and spiritual unpreparedness. It's like, well, the rain came and the floods came and the winds blew and the house fell. But why? Because of the rain and the floods and the winds, or because it was built on sand?

8.77 It's always worth thinking about that in your own life. It's like, why did tragedy defeat you? Is it because of the tragedy or is it because you weren't ready to withstand it? I'm not offering an answer to that. It's a question , and it is a fundamental question. How prepared can you get? And maybe you can get prepared for everything, or at least you can strive for that, and then you're somewhat prepared for everything, even the apocalypse, let's say.

8.78 "And it came to pass, when Jesus has ended these sayings"—this is an amazing line, too. "The people were astonished at his doctrine." And so that means they couldn't believe what they heard, and they couldn't believe that they'd heard it in the manner that it was delivered . To be astonished is to be, what would you say, overwhelmed by the intensity of the light. It's something like that. That's its connotation. And so it's a very interesting phrase, too, because it tells you something about the crowd's reactions. It's like, I can't believe what I just heard. I can't believe that it was delivered in that manner. And then it ends with this. "For he taught them as one having authority, and not as the scribes."

8.79 Right. So that's the Sermon on the Mount. Thank you all very much for participating.